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INDIA AIRLIFTS MORE AID, LOOKS AT BAILEY BRIDGES TO HELP RELIEF EFFORTS

Nepal races against time to look for survivors, 290 Indians still missing

Death toll now 392, hundreds missing; China alerts Nepal about threat from new barrier lake

Yubaraj Ghimire, Divya A & Shubhajit Roy
Kathmandu, New Delhi, August 27

WITH HUNDREDS still missing in Nepal a day after a flash flood ravaged several districts in the country's north, rescuers searched mud-filled valleys and hills for survivors as the official death count climbed to 392 Thursday night.

In New Delhi, the Ministry of External Affairs said at least 290 Indians were still missing and around 200 others were stranded on the Chinese side of the Sino-Nepal border. It said India was in contact with authorities in Nepal and China to coordinate their rescue.

As the Nepal Army and security personnel stepped up search and rescue operations, the flood forecasting division of the Meteorology Department, quoting Chinese officials, warned about the formation of "a significant barrier lake" on

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Schoolchildren at an Army rescue camp in Nepal's Nuwakot district, Thursday. PTI

Relief for some, anxious wait for many: 'Tell us how they are, where they are...'

Arun Janardhanan & Sujit Bisoyi
Chennai, Bhubaneswar, August 27

THREE PILGRIMS from Tamil Nadu's Hosur, an Australia-based couple from Odisha, and the wife of a former MLA from Bengal were among scores of tourists from India who are still missing in the aftermath of the devastating flash flood that



Missing: Sandeep Mohapatra, wife Siddharthi Kumari Sahu

struck Nepal on Wednesday.

Anxious family members, dealing with unreachable networks and mobile phones switched off, are knocking at every possible door to get word on the whereabouts of their loved ones.

According to the Ministry of External Affairs (MEA), 290 Indian nationals are still out of contact in Nepal.

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Nadda meets anti-quota protesters: 'Talks cordial, will meet again soon'

Lalmani Verma, Liz Mathew & Jatin Anand
Lucknow, New Delhi, August 27

UNION MINISTER J P Nadda on Thursday met members of the "Reservation Hatao Andolan (RHA)", days after hundreds gathered at Jantar Mantar demanding that affirmative ac-

tion be based on economic criteria rather than caste.

In a post on X, Nadda said "cordial discussions" took place with the RHA's Harsh Dubey, Ran Bahadur Singh Chauhan, and Mrityunjay Pathak. The meeting came days after a delegation led by Dubey met Uttar Pradesh Deputy Chief Minister

Brajesh Pathak, who assured them he would take up their demands with the BJP brass and arrange their meeting with a Union Minister. Pathak and the delegation also addressed a press conference.

"Following the movement that took place at Jantar Mantar

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Business as Usual
By EP UNNY

6-month plot, 3 states, iCloud use: CBI joins the dots on Adhikari aide killing

Ravik Bhattacharya
Kolkata, August 27

THE KILLING in May of Chandranath Rath, personal assistant to Suwendu Adhikari, days before he took charge as West Bengal Chief Minister, was the culmination of an alleged conspiracy hatched over six months. The CBI uncovered



Chandranath Rath was shot dead in his car on May 6. FILE

the plot using digital evidence, including a photo on iCloud, and by joining the dots between CCTV footage, road tolls and multiple phones, including one at the bottom of the Hooghly river, *The Indian Express* has learnt.

The CBI filed a chargesheet before the Additional Chief

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Happening today

● **UNION FINANCE** Minister Nir-mala Sitharaman will visit the US where she will lead an Indian delegation at the G20 Finance Ministers and Central Bank Governors meet under the US Presidency of the G20 and participate in an Investor Roundtable.

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● 'HAVE TO MAKE INDIA AN ATTRACTIVE CASE ON ITS OWN MERIT AND NOT JUST BECAUSE IT'S CHINA PLUS ONE'

Goyal: Ready to act on feedback, expect Japanese investments to pick up pace

PAGE 1 anchor

Sandeep Singh
Osaka, August 27

New Delhi is not only seeking higher investments from Japan but is keen to deepen its economic partnership with Tokyo. In an interview to *The Indian Express*, Commerce and Indus-

try Minister Piyush Goyal said after his four-day visit to Tokyo, Nagoya and Osaka, he hoped that the pace of investment will pick up further. To increase its presence in Japan, he said India must strive to become its global sourcing partner, and that businesses need to be more outward-looking. Edited excerpts:

How far do you think review of trade deals

EXPRESS interview

PIYUSH GOYAL
UNION COMMERCE AND INDUSTRY MINISTER

signed with Japan will yield benefits for India?

It took us so many years to get them to the table to talk. As of now, even terms of reference have not been discussed. We have just done a macro level opening.

But we will enter the Japanese market for our goods and bring them more and more to India so that they naturally

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

Hydel plant in Nepal feeding power to India among several units hit

Pratyush Deep
New Delhi, August 27

A HYDROPOWER plant that supplies electricity to India was among the power plants hit by Wednesday's flash flood in Nepal. Authorities were assessing the extent of damage to scores of power plants which cater to the bulk of Nepal's electricity needs.

A senior Indian government official told *The Indian Express*

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HIMALAYA NEEDS SHARED SYSTEM FOR EARLY WARNING P 10

Thursday that Nepal slashed its power supply to India by half, from around 800 megawatts (MW) to at least 400 MW. The 14-MW Devghat hydropower plant that supplies power to

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Hanging glacier collapse in focus, NDMA for hard look to reduce future risks

Nikhil Ghanekar & Amitabh Sinha
New Delhi, August 27

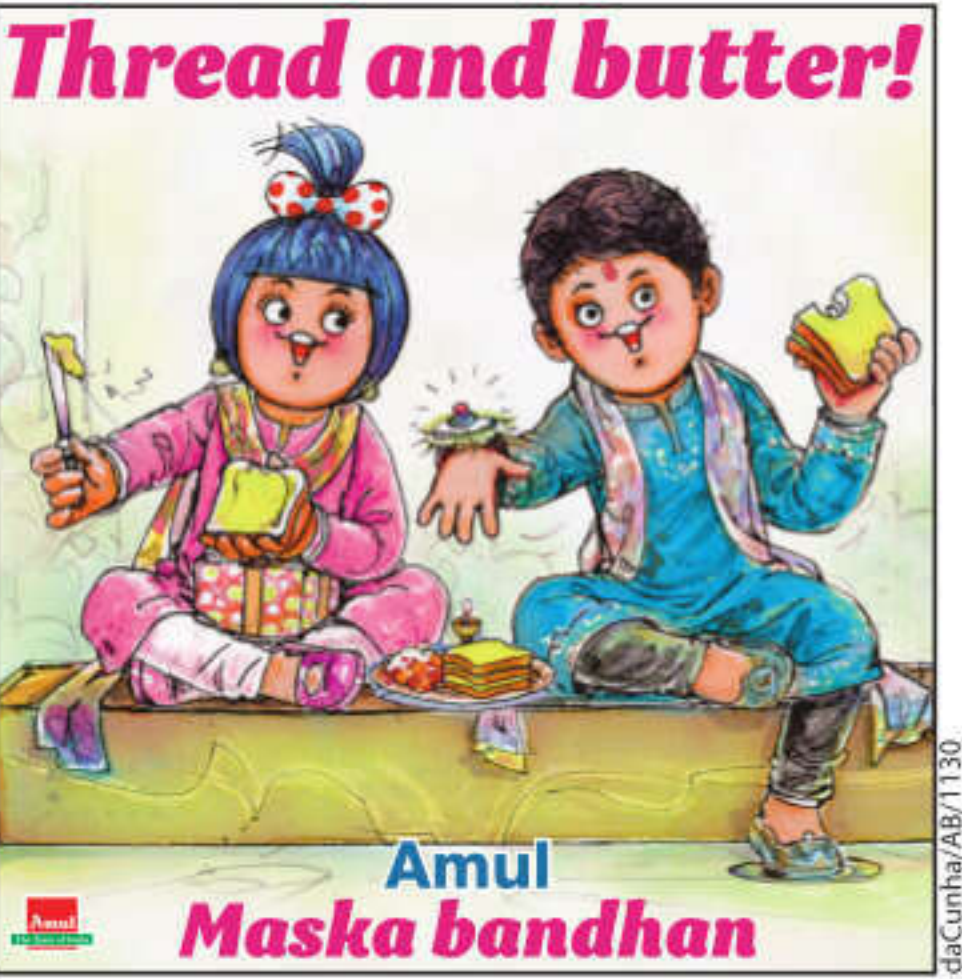
WITH THE spotlight now on the collapse of a hanging glacier as the likely trigger for the devastating flash flood in Nepal, the incident is being closely monitored by the disaster management establishment in India where similar disasters have

E. happened in the recent past.

The National Disaster Management Authority (NDMA) said Thursday it was planning to initiate a comprehensive study on the Nepal event.

"Many areas in India are vulnerable to the kind of

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Penguin India won't publish Sonia's book, had asked for 'changes' which author rejected

Ritu Sarin
New Delhi, August 27

PENGUIN RANDOM House India (PRHI), expected to publish 'Belonging: A Journey of Love,' the much-anticipated memoirs of Congress leader Sonia Gandhi, in India, will not do so, *The Indian Express* has learnt.

Sources said this was precipitated by certain "editorial changes and deletions" that Penguin Random House India wanted in "a part of the



'Belonging: A Journey of Love' by Sonia Gandhi. ALFRED A. KNOPF

manuscript" which was turned down by the author.

With Penguin India out, several Indian publishers are now in the fray and Harper Collins is reported to be close to finalising the agreement to publish and distribute the book in India.

The release, scheduled for November 10, was first announced by US-based Alfred A Knopf, a division of Penguin Random House. Knopf had added

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Nepal

the Tibetan side which posed a new threat. This prompted authorities to alert residents on either side of the Trishuli river to take safety measures and exercise extreme caution.

The warning, which was reported by China Central Television, stated: “A significant barrier lake has formed near the confluence of the Chhochen and Purepu Tsangpo rivers across the border in Tibet with its current water volume estimated at 2 million cubic metres as of Thursday morning with the lake already overflowing. Another 3 million cubic metres of water is expected to flow into the lake over the next three days, posing a high risk of a breach.”

So far, over 1,000 people have been moved to safety, 60 per

Nadda

on 21 August, cordial discussions were held, as per the pre-determined schedule, with Harsh Dubey, Ran Bahadur Singh Chauhan, and Mrityunjay Pathak, members of the team. In this connection, we will meet again soon,” Nadda wrote on X.

Dubey said the group held talks with the minister Wednesday too. “Discussions took place over two days, Wednesday and Thursday. There will be a press conference on September 7, where our decision will be announced,” he told *The Indian Express*. Dubey, a NEET aspirant, and businessman Abhishek Agnihotri, his relative, were at the forefront of the Jantar Mantar demonstration.

“We presented the demand that reservation should be based on economic status. The minister assured us that the government would consider our demands. We trust him and we are hopeful that the government will act on our demands. We had a discussion with the minister today for two hours and for three hours on Wednesday,” said Chauhan, a retired Army officer from UP’s Kannauj district.

“But if the demands are not met, we will protest again at Jantar Mantar and with a bigger

cent of them from the worst-hit Rasuwa district alone. Government officials have been checking with travel agents about pilgrims who had arrived in Nepal for the journey to Kailash Mansarovar.

In New Delhi, External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar held a meeting with top officials and India’s envoys to Kathmandu and Beijing. He said India was making “urgent efforts” to ascertain the status and well-being of Indians stuck in flood-hit areas.

Since Wednesday night, India had sent a total of 47.5 tonnes of emergency supplies to Nepal in two military transport aircraft and was in the process of sending more relief material. India was also looking to send Bailey bridges to help with the rescue and relief efforts in Nepal – many bridges there have been swept away in the flash flood.

Randhir Jaiswal, spokesperson

crowd,” Chauhan said.

The activist said anti-quota movement does not intend to encroach upon rights of SCs, STs, and OBCs. “They are our brothers. Reservation should depend on economic status. Creamy layer should be abolished,” he said. Asked about alleged differences in the RHA, Dubey said, “(Some) people are just concerned with the politics of it, but I believe it would be better if they remain with the movement. If they deviate from it and only politicise it, it will be wrong.”

In the BJP, the decision to engage with the anti-quota activists is seen as an attempt to placate the upper castes. These communities have been upset with the party of late, especially over the now-stayed UGC equity regulations aimed at preventing caste discrimination in higher education institutions.

The upper castes, a core constituency of the party since 1989, were unhappy with the regulations over their potential “misuse”. BJP leaders said the regulations had deeply antagonised the upper castes and recent discussions on caste census had intensified their unease.

The meetings — first with Pathak and now Nadda — were an attempt to “pacify them, assure them that the party would listen to them and to give them confidence that the party would ad-

son for the Ministry of External Affairs, said the missing Indians in Nepal included those working on hydropower projects and tourist groups from different states including Tamil Nadu and West Bengal.

“There are 288 Indian nationals who remain uncontactable. These include 73 Indian nationals who are working on the Trishuli-1 power project. Our embassy in Kathmandu is in touch with the project head to get more details about these people,” he said.

The Ministry later revised the number of missing Indians from 288 to 290.

“We have rescued 21 Indian nationals who are from Tamil Nadu... We have received information that a number of Indian nationals who had gone on the Mansarovar Yatra are stranded on the Chinese side,” he said, adding that around 200

dress their concerns”, said a BJP insider.

“In the past, BJP’s top leaders have made assurances that there will not be any change in the quota regime and it is impossible to go back on them. The voice of this (anti-reservation) group, which is getting traction among a significant section, is getting louder in many parts of the country, especially in UP, Uttarakhand, and Bihar. The party has to placate them,” said a BJP leader from UP.

He said holding meetings would not satisfy them. “You can buy peace for a while with just a meeting. But you will have to answer their questions. Leaders want to know data-based information on the quota policy and its implications,” the leader said. BJP sources said addressing the concerns raised would be the party’s “utmost priority” because “if a small section, even if 2-3%, sits at home during the next election, it will damage party’s prospects in UP”. According to estimates of BJP leaders, upper-caste communities such as Brahmins and Kshatriyas constitute over 20% of the electorate in the poll-bound state.

“They may have more leverage than Gen Z because this group can hurt BJP’s prospects in Purvanchal (eastern) and western UP,” a party leader said.

Indian nationals have sought assistance for evacuation.

After chairing the high-level meeting, Jaishankar said: “Urgent efforts are underway to ascertain the status and well-being of all Indians in the flood-affected areas.” He said his ministry was coordinating with various ministries, state governments, tour operators and other relevant authorities.

“We are working closely with the Nepali side, both on this aspect and on the relief efforts,” he said. India sent a second tranche of 37.5 tonnes of relief supplies in a military transport aircraft to Nepal Thursday, a day after it dispatched 10 tonnes of HADR (Humanitarian Assistance and Disaster Relief) materials.

“A second flight has just taken off, carrying 37.5 tonnes of HADR material, medicines and food packets for Nepal,” Jaishankar said.

Hydel

India was among the plants affected by the floods, the official said. India imports electricity from multiple hydroelectric power plants in Nepal.

According to data from Grid India, India imported 963.4 MW from Nepal at the day’s peak on August 26 when the flash flood struck. Two other hydroelectric plants, Chilime and Trisuli, which supply electricity to Bangladesh, have also been affected.

Nepal’s Energy Ministry, in a statement, said that around 13 hydroelectric power plants and a solar plant were affected. Floods affected nearly 359 MW of capacity, mostly hydro power, Energy Ministry’s statement said.

Queries sent to the Ministry of Power and Grid India did not elicit a response. According to Nepal government, operational power plants with capacity of 236 MW and three under-construction major hydropower projects with capacity of 342.42 MW have been affected in Rasuwa district. The affected projects include Upper Trishuli-I (216 MW), Rasuwagadhi (111 MW), Rasuwa Bhotekoshi (120 MW), Sanjen Khola (78 MW), Upper Mailung A (6.42 MW), Mailung Khola (5 MW), Laidang Khola (20 MW) & Chilime (22 MW).

from Anand, who were travelling to Kailash Mansarovar via Nepal. “They were heading to the immigration office for their visas to cross into Tibet. They had an 8.30 am appointment... We have not been able to reach them since,” said Nilesh, Bimal-kumar’s brother-in-law.

In Mehsana, the family of 43-year-old Australia resident Bhavinkumar Raval is awaiting an update.

Others identified as missing from Gujarat include Kinnari Patel, Mihir Patel, and Ashok Kapadi from Ahmedabad; US residents Paresh Patel and Jyoti Patel hailing from Surat; Jay Kotecha from Rajkot, and Roma Intwala from Valsad.

From Bengal, Sharmistha Bhowmik Roy, wife of former Bijpur MLA Subhrangshu Roy and daughter-in-law of the late politician Mukul Roy, has gone missing. She left Kolkata on August 21 as part of a 30-member tour group. “I spoke to her on Tuesday. She was somewhere called Gyirong. Since then, we have not been able to connect with her,” Subhrangshu said.

(INPUTS FROM SREENIVAS JANYALA IN HYDERABAD, SHAJU PHILIP IN THIRUVANANTHAPURAM, ADITI RAJA IN VADODARA AND SWEETY KUMARI IN KOLKATA)

Goyal

start making India their global source partner. Whether they export to Japan or export anywhere else in the world, I don’t mind as long as jobs come to India and import substitution ends in India.

In all the FTAs we have put some unique element, and we have negotiated from a position of strength. Like we have done with the European Free Trade Association (EFTA) that includes Iceland, Liechtenstein, Norway, and Switzerland and they have committed \$100 billion investment. If they don’t bring, then I can claw back concessions. Similarly, New Zealand has committed \$20 billion investment.

What is the progress on investment promises of \$70 billion by Japan?

It was announced last year, and in 10 months it has already reached \$10 billion. After this visit, it will pick up further. They are looking for projects. I met the chairman of a large textile retailer here and he said that he wants to come to India in a big way. “India is my only horizon,” he said. They have 1,000 stores in China and 4,000 stores worldwide. As they come, the quality consciousness will improve and even exports will improve as these companies do international sourcing (from various geographies) and we have to see if on a net basis exports are more or the imports are more.

Has there been any discussion with Japan on job creation?

We have discussed with companies across sectors including shipping, chemicals, hi-tech and different types of service sectors and they will train around 3 lakh Indian youths in Japan.

You have made references to China in your address, including a comment that seemed to be a reference to Jack Ma. What is your view on China?

It was on a lighter note. We support enterprises, entrepreneurs. We protect them, we protect technology, we protect data. I have never said that they should move their investments from China. India on its own should be an attractive destination. See, they want to diversify their supply chains but for that India is not the only place, they can go anywhere. We have to make India an attractive case on its own merit and not just be-

Adhikari

Judicial Magistrate’s court in Barasat on August 7. The probe, it is learnt, states that the man who allegedly pulled the strings was Sagar Sonkar, Rath’s 29-year-old assistant.

Rath was shot inside his vehicle in Madhyamgram in Kolkata around 10 pm on May 6. His associate Buddhadeb Bera was injured in the attack.

The chargesheet names 12 people, of whom all but Krishna Kumar Singh (from Bihar) have been apprehended. The arrested include Sagar and his brother Saheb Sonkar (both from Kolkata); Uttar Pradesh residents Vikash Mishra, Vinay Rai, Sanjay Rai, Gyanendra Singh, Raj Kumar Singh, Golu Singh and Naveen Kumar Singh; and Bihar’s Mayank Raj Mishra and Vicky Maurya. Sagar and Saheb, 20, were arrested on July 31, more than two months after CBI held 11 people, including four alleged sharpshooters.

According to CBI probe, Sagar had allegedly come to re-

cause it’s China plus one.

Are there opportunities that India sees vis-a-vis Japan-China ties?

What is happening between them and another country is not something for us to interfere in. We are focussing on our own strengths. Automobiles have become a strength area; so are textile, footwear, leather, precision engineering, aerospace and defence. We have done well on mobile phones and so we are moving forward on areas where our strength lies.

We have to stand on our own feet and become an international player. We have done FTA covering 38 countries (all rich countries) and we have opened up two-thirds of global trade for India.

What are some of the challenges that Japanese firms are pointing out, which are hindering investment?

They have indicated they are having challenges, particularly at the local body level and in some states also. But it’s a mixed bag. Some of them have had such wonderful experiences. They come and share that your government has transformed investments in India.

Everybody has some thoughts and suggestions that you may amend this to make it easier. We take this feedback very seriously. In one of my meetings with regard to the semiconductor industry, we took a decision quickly and I have already instructed lawyers, and instructed my ministry to prepare a framework.

Can you elaborate on the case?

Tokyo Electron is a semiconductor company that is planning to come to India. They raised concerns with me over BIS certification. They need over 13,000 parts. As they source it from all around the world, it would be a herculean task to get BIS certification for each of them. They make high quality semiconductors so they can take care of that themselves.

On that basis, for specific industries, which are hi-tech industries, we said we will make a new rule or a new regulation. They want to create a new rule or recognition by which we can give either a company-wide exemption or exemption to make semiconductors.

In another case, somebody wanted approval for SEZ in Dhoolera. I talked to Mr Harsh Sanghvi about it. He said he was waiting for a large group to cer-

tify as to what is the ecosystem, how much land they want and he would immediately apply for SEZ approval and my ministry will immediately process it. So we ourselves are excited and want companies to come with any issues they face so that we can resolve them.

You spoke about the \$100 billion EFTA investment commitment. What are your expectations from there?

We are still working on which specific areas. Pharmaceutical is one major area that they are working on, where they think that clinical trials and innovation in India can be done in a big way and large amounts can be invested.

They also are very keen to shift their high precision and middle SMEs to India. They don’t have labour there as it’s too expensive. At best, what they will produce, they will use locally because they can afford high prices. So they are all looking for Indian partnerships. Now, the Indians have to go and make connections and partnerships, bring technology.

You said Indian businesses are complacent. Can you elaborate?

I am doing it all the time. I am talking to Indian businesses, telling them to be more outward looking, go and explore the world. Hon’ble Prime Minister has directed all our missions to focus on technology, trade and tourism.

I mean geopolitics has now become economics geopolitics or economic diplomacy. Earlier our embassies used to stay away from businesses, now they are changing that. We are saying we will market our business companies, not one particular company. We are encouraging Indian industry and we are willing to stand by Indian industry. We have to stand up for our investors.

India, US ties have recently shown some stability. The first set of Section 301 tariffs have not been extremely harsh like they were last year. Some companies are also getting back their tariffs refunds and RBI on Monday said that India is better prepared to handle Section 301 tariffs. Is the year-long negotiations yielding fruits?

Section 301 is a mechanism that they have found to try and put duties on everybody in the world because the earlier tariffs got struck down by the (U.S.) Su-

preme Court. So they are now attempting different ways to put tariffs. Our deal is kind of done, we have to now formalise it. We have to make sure that our tariff is lower than our competition, which is an assurance the U.S. has given us. So Indonesia, Vietnam, all these countries are our neighbours and competitors, they have to make sure that we get a lower rate than them, which is a part of our agreement. After all, what is a free trade agreement? It’s a preference you have over your competition.

In the USA, we just want to make sure we get a better rate than the competition, then we can sign the deal.

But are things better with the US?

It was never bad, it was just a small phase when the oil duty was imposed. Otherwise we have a very strong partnership. Trade is just one element, they are the largest investors. We have strategic defence tie-up, we have technology tie-up, we have critical minerals tie-up. We are members of Pax Silica, members of Quad, and a lot of our interests align in WTO. So, America is very important and special.

We learn that India is looking to partner with countries to jointly explore opportunities in Africa.

Yes, we are having very active discussions. The concept is that India has manpower, skill and scale and the UAE has financial power. Together, if we go and invest in a third country, we can become a force multiplier. The UAE on its own cannot do it, because who will set up the infrastructure? Who will run the factories there? India has a requirement of capital to support this. The UAE has a lot of relationships in Africa, other countries, which gives them confidence when they are investing. We also have very good relations, but we need the capital. So together, we complement each other and can go to third countries, both for services, for infrastructure projects, and for setting up factories.

With Japan, is India looking at securing rare earth and critical minerals?

We have been talking to them, and there is already a serious dialogue with them for jointly developing technologies or exchange and transfer of technology to help us become self-reliant in rare earth and critical minerals.

The correspondent is in Tokyo at the invitation of FICCI

Anxious wait

On Thursday, many of the survivors, including a group of footballers from Odisha and their coach, reported safe although a number of them remain stranded. The Hosur pilgrims were part of a 57-member group that left through a Kumbakonam-based agency on Sunday. Officials said that 20 members of the group were safe, but there was no verified information about the others.

Roopalakshmi, whose mother-in-law was among the pilgrims, said, “We haven’t received any details... We have come to know that 20 of them are safe. My mother-in-law’s name is not among them.” She said the telephone numbers broadcast as emergency help-lines had elicited no response. “I really want the government to tell us how they are, where they are...” she said.

Two other Hosur residents, Thimarayasamy and his wife, Mamtha, were part of the same pilgrimage, according to his younger brother, Anand. “We have been calling them since

morning, but have been unable to connect at all,” Anand said.

Separately, the Isha Foundation said it had lost contact with an 80-member international group returning from the Kailash Mansarovar pilgrimage. Founder Jaggi Vasudev said the group was believed to have reached an immigration building shortly before the flood struck. “The entire group must have been in that building,” he said.

From Odisha, Sandeep Mohapatra, his wife Siddharthi Kumari Sahu and a 20-year-old woman are reported missing. From Khurda district, the couple had been living in Australia for the last eight years. They reached Nepal on August 22 and had plans to visit Odisha thereafter. Their phones were switched off. “The couple’s last location was detected near the immigration centre when the flood struck,” said Pritish Panda, the nodal officer appointed by the state government to coordinate with authorities.

A missing 20-year-old from Baripada town in Mayurbhanj district had gone to Nepal with friends for trekking. A team of six football players from Odisha along with their coach Halim, who went to Pokhara for a

match, are reported safe and so is Puri native Rakesh Kumar Panda who is on his way back to India. Seven persons from Andhra Pradesh have been identified as stranded or missing in Nepal. Four have been traced and are safe, and efforts are underway to locate three missing persons, said minister N Lokesh Naidu. Among the missing are Rajyalakshmi Nimmagadda and Sasi Kumar, part of Isha foundation groups. Bhaskar Shastri and three others from Adoni and Kurnool have been confirmed to be safe but remain stranded. They were part of a 156-member group travelling to Kailash Mansarovar.

From Kerala, 53 people, including a number of non-resident Keralites, are stranded in Nepal. In a video shared by one of the travelling groups, the 35-member team got stranded in a forest while moving in two mini buses to Pokhara city.

In Gujarat, an agonising wait continues for families after 18 people from the state, including 14 NRIs and several Kailash Mansarovar pilgrims, went missing or lost contact.

Among those said to be missing are a US-based couple, Bimalkumar Patel, 47, and Jaimina Patel, 43, originally

Sonia book

that the first print run for the title would be 100,000 copies.

The Indian Express sent questions to Knopf and Gandhi’s agent David Godwin who were not available for comment. Penguin Random House India CEO Gaurav Shrinagesh was asked about the requested “changes/deletions” in Gandhi’s manuscript. He was unavailable for comment.

Sonia Gandhi has previously authored and edited other books but this, according to those who have worked on it, is her most personal and definitive account of her life. Knopf has called it a “riveting memoir by one of the world’s most prominent women leaders that tells a richly engaging story of love, family, and an endlessly fascinating country: India.”

Knopf’s release quoted Sonia Gandhi saying: “Much has been written about my family, but few narratives were able to reach into the truth of their motiva-

tions, their actions and even their human failings... My story also offers readers a unique perspective of the social and political changes I have witnessed for six decades.”

Earlier this year, PRHI had issued a statement that it had “not printed” former Army chief General M.M. Naravane’s memoirs titled ‘Four Stars of Destiny’ but a hard copy of the title was flashed by Rahul Gandhi in Parliament. Excerpts from the memoirs, including Naravane’s account of the India-China clashes in Galwan and the Agni-path scheme, had been extracted in the media.

In June this year, *The Indian Express* had first reported how PRHI pulled the plug on acclaimed graphic novelist Joe Sacco’s book on the Muzaffargarh riots titled ‘The Once and Future Riot’. Then, CEO Shrinagesh had said that the publisher had raised some “content issues” with the author during the legal scrutiny process which included a map showing inaccurate boundaries of India.

Glacier

disaster we have just seen in Nepal. We have had such events in the past. So it is important for us to study this, and understand this. We do plan to look at it in detail,” Krishna Swaroop Vatsa, Member, NDMA, said.

India has had several major flash flood incidents in recent years, including the Kedarnath tragedy in 2013, the Chamoli disaster in 2021, the Sikkim lake burst in 2023 and in Dharali last year. These incidents claimed hundreds of lives and caused large-scale damage.

Following the Chamoli incident in 2021, the NDMA had initiated an effort to mitigate the risks from such events through the installation of early warning systems on glacial lakes considered vulnerable to breaches.

The National GLOF Risk Management Programme seeks to strengthen the boundaries of these glacial lakes in the four hilly states of Arunachal Pra-

desh, Sikkim, Uttarakhand and Himachal Pradesh, and equip them with early warning systems. The programme covers the Union Territories of Jammu and Kashmir and Ladakh as well. In April 2024, ISRO has revealed that of 2,431 glacial lakes larger than 10 hectares in size in the Indian Himalayan River basins 676 had expanded notably between 1984 and 2023.

“This programme is progressing well. It will take some time, but this will help in significantly reducing the risks from glacial outbursts. The Nepal incident just reinforces the importance of this programme. Simultaneous efforts to create capabilities in forecasting landslides, and develop a landslide early warning system, are also extremely crucial. Experimental landslide forecasts are already being done in some areas. These are very important,” Vatsa said.

While scientists are still trying to ascertain the exact trigger for the Nepal flash flood, glaciologist Anil Kulkarni of the Indian Institute of Science said the col-

Real Creator IAS Edition https://t.me/+2RvD_RGf9mJmZg1

lapse of a large chunk of snow and rocks from a hanging glacier was the most likely cause. He likened the fall of this chunk to “a high-intensity bomb blast”.

The National Remote Sensing Centre Thursday released satellite images of before and after the event, which, too, indicated the collapse of a glacier mass and the swollen channel of the Bhote Koshi river.

“From various satellite images and evidence available as on Thursday, it can be said that a hanging glacier collapsed vertically with a drop of between 1.5-2 km into a deglaciated valley. The drop was quite steep and the mass of ice that crashed must have generated immense energy. The force of the steep drop together with the debris, water available in the deglaciated valley is likely to have unleashed the flood,” Kulkarni told *The Indian Express*.

He said he likened it to a high-intensity bomb blast as the large mass of ice dropped on a soft bed of moraine and debris in a deglaciated area, which means

Skywatch

Forecast: August 28, 2026

Cloudy sky. Light rain, thunderstorm and lightning.

MAX: 34-36

1.9°C above normal

MIN: 25-27

0.6°C above normal

AQI Tracker

Alipur

Satisfactory

AQI: 73

Mundka

Moderate

AQI: 147

Dwarka

Poor

AQI: 207

Anand Vihar

Very Poor

AQI: 328

● Good (0-50)

● Satisfactory (51-100)

● Moderate (101-200)

● Poor (201-300)

● Very Poor (301-400)

● Severe (401-500)

166 new H1N1 cases

New Delhi: Delhi reported 166 fresh H1N1 cases in the last 24 hours, taking the cumulative tally to 2,612.

The cumulative number of Influenza-A cases in the Capital has also risen to around 3,300 from 3,177 reported a day earlier, according to Delhi government data. PTI

Delhi Govt invites bid for scheme offering Rs 10 L medical cover for families of construction workers

Gayathri Mani
New Delhi, August 27

THE DELHI Government has invited bids for the Delhi Building and Construction Workers Health Scheme, which will provide around 2.7 lakh registered construction workers and their families in the Capital with free annual health check-ups and several medical services worth up to Rs 10 lakh per year.

According to officials, the government has invited bids from central and state public sector undertakings (PSUs) to appoint a Project Implementing Agency (PIA) for providing construction workers and their families with annual health check-ups, OPD (Outpatient Department) and IPD (Inpatient Department) services through empanelled hospitals, laboratories, and clinics, as well as its own facilities, officials said on Thursday

The scheme was approved by the cabinet chaired by Chief Minister Rekha Gupta in June.

The scheme is expected to cover nearly 10 lakh beneficiaries in the city with providing free and quality healthcare services to construction workers and their eligible family members, including spouses, children and parents. Under the scheme, officials said, each



LG Taranjit Singh Sandhu and Chief Minister Rekha Gupta visit a state-of-the-art lecture hall at Indira Gandhi Delhi Technical University for Women at Kashmere Gate, in New Delhi on Thursday. ANI

registered worker will be entitled to treatment of up to Rs 2 lakh at empanelled hospitals, while the limit for a family will be up to Rs 10 lakh.

"Construction workers are particularly vulnerable to extreme conditions, which can lead to health related risks. In this context, the Board aims to ensure the timely health screening of approximately 2.70 lakh registered workers and their families to support their health, safety, and overall working conditions...the number of the construction workers may

increase or decrease as per the conditions," said a senior government official.

According to officials, the scheme proposes to provide free of cost, comprehensive and accessible health care services to building workers and their families under the Delhi Building and Other Construction Workers Welfare Board (DBOCWWB).

The scheme aims to ensure cashless access to quality health care services, thereby reducing the financial burden on beneficiaries and strengthening the

cumstances like a worksite accident or medical emergency, officials said.

"Coverage shall be on a per-beneficiary basis per financial year and shall include diagnostics..., medicines and hospitalisation," an official said.

The selected PIA will also establish a 24*7 Toll-free helpline and call center to provide beneficiary support for healthcare services and establish minimum six labs spread evenly across the city, an official said.

Officials said that the PIA will also test all the samples in its own laboratories. It will also be tasked to maintain electronic medical records through central dashboard of cloud based system developed by it on their own cost for DBOCWW board, they added. "PIA shall ensure that the beneficiaries availing healthcare services under Delhi State health scheme or any other govt schemes shall not be eligible for availability benefits under this scheme (the Delhi Building and Construction Workers Health Scheme)," read a document.

The annual health check-up package, conducted by the PIA under the approved government health department scheme, will be Rs 2,000 for men and Rs 2,200 for women workers.

ATTEMPT TO IDENTITY DELHIITES

Check missing person reports, Chief Secy tells DMs after flash floods in Nepal

Gayathri Mani
New Delhi, August 27

DELHI CHIEF Secretary Rajeev Verma has directed all district magistrates in the Capital to co-ordinate with the Delhi Police on missing persons' complaints registered in the city to find out if any resident has gone missing during the recent Nepal flash floods, officials said on Thursday. The flash flood on Wednesday claimed at least 392 lives, while thousands, including 290 Indians, have been reported missing so far.

Officials said that the district magistrates have also been asked to approach private tour operators to ascertain how many residents of Delhi travelled to Nepal through them and whether they have received any complaint yet.

"This is to ensure prompt action can be taken to rescue those who may have been stranded and assist their families," said a senior Revenue department official.

According to a statement shared by the Chief Minister's Office, a group of 25 people from Delhi had visited Mansarovar before the tragedy hit Nepal and have now returned. "Information about those who went on personal tours is being collected," the statement read.

"People visit Mansarovar after registering for trips organised by the Ministry of External Affairs ... As per information shared by the Centre, 25 recently went to Nepal through a tour facilitated by the government and they already returned to Delhi before the disaster happened...as of now, no one has approached us, nor

have we received any missing complaint. However, the Delhi government is taking all necessary steps and putting efforts to help people..." said a senior official.

The Transport department, meanwhile, has closed bus services between Delhi and Kathmandu. "...a Flash Flood hits Nepal on 26.08.2026 due to which approximately 160 people have been killed and hundreds are missing, after a massive flash flood road transportation was completely shut on National Highway, Delhi-Kathmandu Route in Nepal at present," read a government order.

The Delhi-Kathmandu International bus services, officially known as Indo-Nepal Maitri Bus Sewa, operates from the Dr. Ambedkar Stadium Terminal near Delhi Gate. The Delhi Transport Corporation has now cancelled trips to and from Nepal, scheduled for Friday and Saturday.

A senior transport official said: "Buses between Delhi and Nepal run on alternate days. The buses that arrive from Nepal and those routed from Delhi to the neighbouring country are currently stuck at the check post ... With the current situation being critical, the Transport department has decided to cancel all trips till Monday. If the situation gets normal by then, the services will resume."

Delhi-Kathmandu Maitri Bus Sewa operates six days a week, with DTC buses running on Mondays, Wednesdays and Fridays, while buses operated by Nepal's Manjushree Yatayat run on Tuesdays, Thursdays and Saturdays.

Caught breaking a traffic rule in Capital? Your local cop can now issue an e-challan

Sakshi Chand
New Delhi, August 27

DELHI POLICE personnel posted at police stations and other units will soon be able to initiate action against traffic-rule violators using an e-challan application on their mobile phones, significantly expanding the force available for traffic enforcement in the Capital.

How will it work?

Under the new system, police personnel will be able to photograph vehicles violating traffic rules and upload the details on the e-challan app. The information will then be processed through the system and a challan notice issued to the registered owner of the vehicle.

At present, local police personnel who spot traffic violations have to involve the Traffic Police to issue a challan.

Under the new system, they will be able to independently initiate action.

Local, Traffic Police have to work together?

Not necessarily. Either wing will be able to independently detect violations and initiate enforcement action.

Why is it significant?

The move comes amid a wider push by Delhi Police Commissioner Anurag Kumar to improve traffic management, ease congestion and strengthen road discipline in the Capital.

Earlier this month, *The Indian Express* had reported that the Police chief held a meeting with senior Traffic Police officials and asked them to prepare an action plan to address congestion, accident-prone stretches and chronic traffic

choke points across the city.

As part of the exercise, the idea of allowing local police personnel to issue traffic challans was considered. The proposal had been pending for some time and was aimed at expanding the pool of personnel available for traffic enforcement.

Officials said the initiative can help in implementing consistent enforcement of traffic rules across neighbourhoods.

Local police personnel deployed on patrol or other duties can act against visible traffic violations without having to wait for a Traffic Police team to arrive, said a senior Traffic Police official.

Officials said the arrangement could also allow the Traffic Police to focus its resources on congestion management, accident-prone corridors and other specialised traffic duties.

Delhi govt plans to appoint transaction advisor to assess its land and buildings

Express News Service
New Delhi, August 27

DELHI GOVERNMENT is planning to engage a professional transaction advisor to conduct a comprehensive assessment of its land and building assets, which can be redeveloped and commercially utilised.

According to officials, the aim is to assess the existing assets and redevelop it for optimal commercial utilisation. "It will also help in identification of revenue-enhancement opportunities and development of financially viable models for under-utilised assets," said an official.

These assets include Varun- alaya/Jhandewalan office premises as well as residential housing at Haiderpur and Lajpat Nagar.

"The objective is to unlock the value of DJB's existing assets and generate additional sustainable revenue without compromising operational requirements," said the official.

The government, through the IT department, had devel-

oped a portal named Delhi Asset Management Information System (DAMIS) — a centralised, digital and GIS enabled repository of all government owned land and properties.

Under this, the government urged all its departments to submit details of land parcels and properties under them so that it can use the same to build schools and hospitals, among others. Various departments have already uploaded details of nearly 14,000 properties on the DAMIS, said officials.

PUBLIC NOTICE

PUBLIC NOTICE

FOR INVITING OBJECTIONS REGARDING AMENDMENT IN PROJECT REGISTRATION NAMELY

"ASTER AVENUE 36"

LOCATED AT SECTOR 36, SOHNA, GURUGRAM BEING DEVELOPED BY

M/S 4S DEVELOPERS PVT. LTD.

It is for the information of the general public and the allottees of the project, namely "Aster Avenue 36", situated in Sector-36, Sohna, Gurugram, that an application dated 19.08.2026 has been submitted by M/s 4S Developers Pvt. Ltd. for amendment of the registration certificate no. 104 of 2024 of the aforesaid project, which is registered with the Authority under Section 4 of the Real Estate (Regulation and Development) Act, 2016 (the "Act").

The Department of Town & Country Planning, Haryana granted Licence No. 235 of 2023 dated 02.11.2023 in favour of M/s 4S Developers Pvt. Ltd. for setting up an Affordable Group Housing Colony over an area measuring 8.309 acres in Sector-36, Sohna, Gurugram. Thereafter, Licence No. 269 of 2023 dated 28.12.2023 was granted by the Department of Town & Country Planning, Haryana in favour of Sh. Ashutosh Verma S/o Sh. Baldevwar Verma, Sh. Mahesh Kumar S/o Sh. Hari Chand and M/s 4S Developers Pvt. Ltd., in collaboration with M/s 4S Developers Pvt. Ltd., for setting up an Affordable Group Housing Colony over an additional area measuring 1.37 acres (in addition to Licence No. 253 of 2023) in Sector-36, Sohna, thereby making the total project area 9.6840 acres.

The Promoter obtained the revised demarcation-cum-zoning plan and phasing plan of the project vide DTCP Memo No. ZP-1949/JD(RA)/2024/14070 dated 09.05.2024. As per the phasing plan approved on 09.05.2024, the entire project comprises two phases, namely Phase I measuring 7.207 acres and Phase II measuring 2.477 acres. Further, the Promoter obtained approval of the building plans vide Memo No. ZP-1949/JD(RA)/2024/20570 dated 09.07.2024 from DTCP, Haryana.

Thereafter, the aforesaid project namely "Aster Avenue 36" was registered with the Authority vide Registration Certificate No. 104 of 2024 dated 10.10.2024. Subsequently, the Promoter obtained the revised demarcation-cum-zoning plan incorporating TDR for the project vide DTCP Memo No. ZP-1949-Vol-II/JD(RA)/2025/40156 dated 16.10.2025, and revised building plans for Phase I and Phase II of the project vide DTCP Memo No. ZP-1949 Vol-II/JD(G)/2026/11690 dated 09.04.2026.

Further, the Authority registered Phase II of the project, namely "Aster Avenue 36 Phase 2", measuring 2.477 acres, vide Registration No. 33 of 2026 dated 01.06.2026. Now, the Promoter has approached the Authority for amendment of Registration Certificate No. 104 of 2024, pursuant to the revision of the building plans as mentioned above. The Promoter further states, in its application dated 19.08.2026, that certain changes have been proposed in the configuration of the Commercial-1 and Commercial-2 buildings pursuant to the revised approved building plans.

The proposed changes include an increase in the number of shops in Commercial-1 from 39 to 63. The Promoter has disclosed that 18 shops in Commercial-1 have already been sold. In respect of Commercial-2, the Promoter has proposed a revised configuration comprising from 60 shops to 38 shops and 108 service apartments, and has stated that no third-party rights, sale, or transfer have been created in Commercial-2.

As per the provisions of Section 14(2)(ii) of the Real Estate (Regulation and Development) Act, 2016, any alteration or addition to the sanctioned plan of the project requires the written consent of at least two-thirds of the allottees. As per the details submitted by the Promoter, all 708 residential units have been sold to 708 allottees. In respect of the commercial units, 18 out of 99 units have been sold, involving 16 unique allottees. The Promoter has further submitted the written consent of 724 unique allottees, comprising consents in respect of 514 residential units and 6 commercial units, which constitutes more than two-thirds of the total number of unique allottees in the project, for the revision of the approved building plans.

The Authority is considering the application submitted by the Promoter for amendment of the registration certificate under Section 4 of the Act of 2016 in respect of the aforesaid project and hereby invites objections, if any, in this regard.

The relevant application and related documents are available in the office of the Haryana Real Estate Regulatory Authority, Gurugram which can be seen by any concerned on any working day during office hours up to 11.09.2026 from 11:00-4:00 PM for filing of objections with respect to the above application dated 19.08.2026, if any. Such objections shall be filed in the registry of the Authority up to 11.09.2026 till 4:00 PM. Also, if anyone wishes to appear, may appear before the Authority on 14.09.2026 at 11:00 AM during the hearing.

Given under the approval of the Authority and its seal.

Dated: 28.08.2026

Secretary,

Haryana Real Estate Regulatory Authority, Gurugram.

EXPRESS

Careers

RAYAT SHIKSHAN SANSTHA, SATARA (Maharashtra)

Karmaveer Samadhi Parisar, Powai Naka, Satara

Dist.- Satara – 415001 (Maharashtra)

(Affiliated to Shivaji University, Kolhapur, Punyashlok Ahilyadevi Holkar Solapur University, Solapur, University of Mumbai, & Savitribai Phule Pune University, Pune)

(Permanently Granted)

WANTED

Applications are invited from eligible candidates for the following post:

Sr. No.	Name of the College	Vacant Posts	Affiliated University	Name of Reservation
1	Chandrabai Shantappa Shendure College, Hupari, Dist- Kolhapur	1	Shivaji University, Kolhapur	
2	Sou. Mangaltai Ramchandra Jagtap Mahavidyalaya, Umbraj, Dist-Satara	1		
3	Dahiwadi College, Dahiwadi, Dist-Satara	1		
4	Rajarshi Chhatrapati Shahu College, Kolhapur, Dist-Kolhapur	1		
5	Baiwant College, Vita, Dist-Sangli	1	Principal	Open to All
6	Sharaddchandra Pawar Mahavidyalaya, Lonand, Dist- Satara	1		
7	Yashwantrao Chavan Mahavidyalaya, Pachwad, Dist-Satara	1	Principal	Open to All
8	Arts and Commerce College, Madha, Dist - Solapur	1		
9	Dr.Babasaheb Ambedkar College, Aundhgaon, Pune, Dist-Pune	1	Savitribai Phule Pune University, Pune	
10	Mahatma Phule Mahavidyalaya, Pimpri, Pune, Dist-Pune	1		
11	S.M. Joshi College, Hadapsar, Pune, Dist- Pune	1	University of Mumbai	
12	Maharaja Jivajirao Shinde Mahavidyalaya, Shrigonda, Dist-Ahilyanagar	1		
13	Loknete Ramsheth Thakur Arts, Science and Commerce College, Mokhada, Dist- Palghar	1		
14	Veer Wajekar Arts, Science and Commerce College, Phunde, Dist-Raigad	1		
Total Posts		14		

Note: 1. For detailed information about post, qualifications and other terms and conditions please visit University website: www.unishivaji.ac.in and Sanstha website: https://principal.rayatrecruitment.com

2. Apply giving full particulars within 15 days from the date of publication of this advertisement to the undersigned.

Secretary,

Place: Satara Date: 28/08/2026

Rayat Shikshan Sanstha, Satara (Maharashtra)

भारत निर्वाचन आयोग

Election Commission of India

CHIEF ELECTORAL OFFICER, HARYANA

SIR 2026

विशेष गहन पुनरीक्षण

हरियाणा

आपका मत, आपकी पहचान – हर संकल्प

फॉर्म-6

नए मतदाता के लिए

यदि आप 18 वर्ष की आयु पूर्ण कर चुके हैं और आपका नाम मतदाता सूची में नहीं है, तो फॉर्म-6 भरें।

+

नया नाम जोड़ने हेतु

फॉर्म-7

नाम हटाने के लिए

यदि कोई मतदाता स्थाई रूप से स्थानांतरित हो गया है, मृत्यु हो गई है या दोहराव (डुप्लीकेट) है, तो फॉर्म-7 भरें।

x

नाम हटाने हेतु

फॉर्म-8

विवरण सुधारने के लिए

यदि आपके नाम, आयु, पता, फोटो या अन्य विवरण में कोई गलती है, तो फॉर्म-8 भरें।

विवरण सुधारने हेतु

उपरोक्त फॉर्म 6 व 8 के साथ आवश्यक दस्तावेज एवं घोषणा-पत्र संलग्न करें।

फॉर्म के साथ आवश्यक दस्तावेज जमा करने के विकल्प

ऑनलाइन

voters.eci.gov.in

के माध्यम से

या

अपने क्षेत्र के ERO / AERO कार्यालय में व्यक्तिगत रूप से

विशेष अभियान की तिथियां

29-30 अगस्त, 2026

विशेष अभियान दिवस

सभी बी.एल.ओ. अपने-अपने मतदान केन्द्र पर प्रातः 9 बजे से सायं 5 बजे तक उपस्थित रहेंगे।

लोकतंत्र को बनाएं और मजबूत

अधिक जानकारी के लिए टोल फ्री नंबर 1950

ECINET ऐप डाउनलोड करें नवीनतम जानकारी पाएं

मतदाता सूची देखें voters.eci.gov.in

epaper.indianexpress.com

50-km roads cleared this week: Demolition drive in Gurgaon now focuses on footpaths, cycle tracks

Abhimanyu Hazarika
Gurgaon, August 27

TWENTY-THREE DAYS after assuring the Supreme Court that all illegal encroachments within its jurisdiction would be removed within two weeks, the Gurugram Metropolitan Development Authority (GMDA) has reclaimed 49.5 kilometres of road space this week, as per data shared by officials.

While earlier drives mainly targeted arterial roads, the focus this week was on freeing up footpaths, cycle tracks, and pedestrian walkways from commercial spillover and illegal construction. The authority deployed heavy machinery and multi-departmental teams on Monday, Wednesday and Thursday to dismantle permanent sheds, concrete ramps, and scrap shops that have long choked the city's right of way (ROW). ROW refers to public land legally meant for unobstructed roads, footpaths, utilities, and emergency access.

The enforcement drive cleared 16 km of roads in Sectors 30 to 41, Sohna Road, and Sectors 60 to 67 on Monday, officials said. On Wednesday, 18.5 km was covered at MG Road, Gwal Pahari Road, and Sectors



The drive underway at Gurgaon Sector 51 on Thursday. GMDA

27 and 28. Illegal boards, slum clusters, and vendor carts were removed a GMDA spokesperson said. Another 15 km was reclaimed on Thursday.

The drive also covered the upscale Golf Course Road and Vyapar Kendra Road and Basai Road, Sectors 101 to 106.

District Town Planner (Enforcement) Amit Madholia Thursday issued a warning against the commercial misuse of stilt parking too, stating that converting mandated parking floors into PG accommodations, guest houses or shops will invite sealing and demolition.

Recognising the chronic problem of quick re-encroachment once the bulldozers leave, GMDA Chief Executive Officer P C Meena has mandated strict post-demolition surveillance across the cleared stretches.

ACCUSED ON THE RUN; WOMAN CREMATED AMID HEAVY POLICE DEPLOYMENT

Months before West Delhi woman's killing: A tale of suicide attempt, drugs and abuse

Pragynesh
New Delhi, August 27

A SUICIDE attempt, followed by drug addiction and increasingly abusive behaviour, marked a dramatic change in 23-year-old Imran's life before he allegedly killed a 21-year-old woman at her West Delhi home on Wednesday.

Imran had entered Muskan's house in Tilak Nagar and allegedly strangled her and stabbed her multiple times in the stomach before fleeing.

Police said Muskan and Imran, who is on the run, met in 2024. At the time, Muskan was beginning to build a career as a content creator while pursuing a Bachelor of Arts degree through Delhi University's School of Open Learning, an officer said.

The two met at Seven Zone gym, about 2 km from Muskan's house. Imran had joined the gym as a trainer around four months ago, while Muskan joined soon after.

Police said things began to change about two months ago. Imran allegedly attempted suicide and subsequently became addicted to drugs. His behaviour towards Muskan also

turned abusive, prompting her to approach the police once, a senior officer said.

"He became abusive... Due to this, she went to the police once," the officer added.

The gym later fired Imran over what the trainer described as his "erratic behaviour".

Police said Imran, who had been booked in a culpable homicide case from 2021, subsequently went to a de-addiction centre.

When he returned, he allegedly met Muskan at a hotel on August 20.

"He was suspicious that she had been talking to another man and confronted her. This led to a fight between them," claimed an officer.

According to police, Imran reached Muskan's neighbourhood around 5.40 pm on Wednesday. Police said there was no sign of a forced entry into the house, and that Imran was likely let in.

She was alone at home. Her mother was out buying vegetables. Her two sisters were in Chandigarh.

"Muskan and Imran got into a heated argument. It appears that Imran strangled her before stabbing her multiple times in



Security was stepped up near the victim's house. RENUKA PURI

the abdomen with a knife he had brought with him. He then took her phone and fled," a senior officer said.

About 6.40 pm, the family's domestic help came to the house and found the door open. She saw that all the lights had been switched off, except

for the one in Muskan's room.

"She went inside and found Muskan, injured and bleeding. Hearing her screams, neighbours rushed to help and took Muskan to the hospital," the officer said.

Muskan was cremated around 3 pm on Thursday amid

heavy police deployment outside the cremation ground. No media persons were allowed to enter.

Security was stepped up near her house. Barricades blocked the entry to the lane, with police officers questioning everyone trying to enter.

Muskan was one of four siblings raised by their mother. Kamlesh Sharma, after their father died about 15 years ago. Her mother works as a lab assistant at Guru Gobind Singh Hospital, a family friend said.

Her two older sisters include Anamika, while her younger brother is 18 years old. The family lived on the second floor of a building inside a narrow lane in Old Mahavir Nagar, a dense mix of shops and residential buildings in Tilak Nagar.

"Muskan had been pursuing content creation like her sister, Anamika, who is a model. She started earning enough to build a decent career," said a friend who lives three lanes away from her home.

Muskan's social media accounts show a young woman trying to establish herself in the world of content creation. Her Instagram is filled with professionally shot pictures from gyms and wedding-wear boutique shoots, along with reels she made while travelling and at home.

Imran's Instagram profile, meanwhile, largely reflects his life at the gym, with several reels of him working out.

EXPRESS special

Faridabad doctor's clients: Patient who sold drugs for Rs 40k, Afghan national who bought medicines

Manish Sharma arrested on April 21 with cancer medicines worth Rs 50 lakh

Pragynesh
New Delhi, August 27

A BLOOD cancer patient, desperate for a medicine after three others had failed to provide relief, got Iclusig — an advanced cancer drug not approved for sale in India — through a US-based patient assistance programme. When the drug did not suit him, he decided to sell it.

That was when 39-year-old Dr Manish Sharma, a resident of Faridabad in Haryana, allegedly stepped in.

In January 2024, Sharma — who had been running online pharmacy HK Pharmaceutical on IndiaMART portal since 2023 — bought two packs of Iclusig (ponatinib) from the patient for Rs 40,000, Delhi Police said. Each pack, containing 30 tablets, was worth more than Rs 17 lakh in the market.

According to the police, this was not an isolated transaction. For over a year, Sharma had allegedly been buying and selling expensive cancer medicines through his online pharmacy, including Darzalex and Human Albumin.

He had, police said, sold the two drugs to a patient from Afghanistan among others.

Sharma was arrested last Friday in Delhi with medicines worth more than Rs 50 lakh.

The orders

Police said Sharma's alleged dealings began with his IndiaMART listing for HK Pharmaceutical. Pharmacies and medi-

cine suppliers use the platform to list their businesses and provide contact numbers, through which customers and wholesalers can place orders.

In January 2024, a blood cancer patient contacted the number listed by Sharma. At least three medicines had failed to provide him relief, following which he was prescribed Iclusig, a drug that works by blocking proteins that promote tumour growth.

"A US-based organisation, Max US Foundation, had agreed to provide the medicine to the patient under a patient assistance programme and sent him batches of Iclusig," said a police officer.

"But even this medication was not suiting the patient. So, he decided to sell it," the officer added. Sharma allegedly agreed to buy two packs for Rs 40,000.

According to police, Sharma knew the real value of the drugs. For over a year, the officer said, his company had been sourcing and selling Darzalex 1.8 mg — banned in India — and Human Albumin Solution 20%.

"Darzalex is not entirely banned, just its 1.8 mg version. It's used as an antibody to treat plasma cancer in patients, and is priced at around Rs. 2.27 lakh. Human Albumin is used to expand blood volume in cancer patients and maintain blood flow through their heart," said an officer.

Police said Sharma had already paid Rs 40,000 for



Packs of Iclusig and Darzalex seized by police from accused Manish Sharma (right). EXPRESS

batches of Darzalex and Albumin to sellers he contacted through IndiaMART and was planning to sell them.

Doctor who couldn't be

Sharma was born and brought up in a well-to-do family in Gwalior. He was the first in his family to pursue an MBBS after Class 12.

"But unable to get admission in a decent medical college in India, he went to Russia in 2010 to study medicine," the officer said.

He returned to India in 2014 and sat for the Foreign Medical Graduates Examination three to four times. But he failed to clear the test required for foreign-trained doctors to obtain a licence to practise in India, police said.

"He then started working at Park Hospital in Faridabad. While working, he met his wife, who is Ayurvedic doctor," the officer said.

In 2021, Sharma opened his own hospital, KMC Hospital, in Faridabad's Jawahar Colony. In



2023, he married his then girlfriend and opened another branch of the hospital in Sohna, Haryana.

The businesses, however, struggled to meet their operating costs.

"They used to hire freelance doctors but the incurred cost was too much. So, they shut down the hospitals and transitioned into smaller medical businesses," said the officer.

The couple set up HK Polyclinic in Faridabad and started HK Pharmaceutical. The latter was registered on IndiaMART.

The arrest

To arrest Sharma, a team led by Inspector Pawan Kumar and Sub Inspector Anupama laid a trap. They placed a fake order

with Sharma and asked him to deliver the medicines near Sukhdev Vihar in Southeast Delhi. On April 21, he allegedly drove from his home in a Honda City carrying packs of Iclusig, Darzalex and Albumin.

"When he reached Sukhdev Vihar and got out of the car, he was apprehended... On verification, he was found to be Manish Sharma," said DCP Harsh Indora.

Four packets of Iclusig tablets, four 100-ml vials of Human Albumin Solution IP 20% and two boxes of Darzalex 1.800 mg were seized from him.

"Inspection of some of these batches of Albumin and Darzalex revealed that they might have been produced in Turkey," the officer said.

Police suspect human carriers may have been used to bring the medicines into India through air or sea routes. "We are talking to customs regarding this," the officer said.

The officer added that inspectors linked to Darzalex and other brands examined some of the seized batches. "They suspected that the MRP stickers could be fakes. We are awaiting the FSL report for confirmation if the medicines are authentic."

Following his arrest, Sharma allegedly told police that he had procured the Albumin and Darzalex from pharmacists in Patel Nagar in Delhi and Gurgaon in Haryana.

"But when we raided these places, we didn't find anything. We are trying to ascertain whether they got a tip about us coming or whether Dr Manish is lying. We are yet to confirm what the source of these medicines are," the officer said.

IIT DELHI STUDENT'S SUICIDE

Students want inquiry panel to probe claims victim's mother made to cops

Sophiya Mathew
New Delhi, August 27

FIVE DAYS after the alleged suicide of MSC Physics student Rishikesh Kumar, IIT Delhi late Wednesday reconstituted an external inquiry panel, to be now headed by retired Delhi High Court judge Justice Mukta Gupta — an appointment that was sought by the students. But the move did little to halt the student mobilisation that began spontaneously on Monday and has since grown into a campus-wide protest.

The reason: The students now want the panel's terms of reference widened to include the serious allegations made by Kumar's mother to police and assessing whether those named should be held accountable. Initially, the panel was tasked with discussing Kumar's death with students, faculty and administrative offices; reviewing protocols and processes and submitting a report within two weeks.

In her complaint to the police, Rishikesh's mother had alleged that the IIT Delhi administration had not allotted her son a hostel and that he was humiliated by the college's dean. She claimed Rishikesh was told that there was no provision for "such children" to stay in the hostel. According to the complaint, the incident left Rishikesh deeply distressed.

The protest began on Monday with six students from different programmes, including PhD, MSC and BTech. With most students still in class, they approached classrooms and asked professors to release students early. "Some professors were very receptive. Some didn't take it very well," a student said.



At the protest on the campus on Thursday. EXPRESS

The gathering grew through the day, eventually drawing thousands of students. The student said around 1,700 people had joined a WhatsApp channel being used to coordinate the protest.

However, sustaining the protest alongside IIT Delhi's academic schedule has not been easy. Students have continued attending classes and laboratories while participating in the protest, pooling money for water, sandwiches and snacks. "People are tired. Many students are not able to eat on time," the student said, adding that still, students continued to protest because Kumar's death had resonated with their own experiences on campus.

The protests have also prompted students to share their experiences. One student, the protester said, recalled approaching a counsellor simply to be heard but being told: "Just go back and sleep for now."

"The protest is continuing because every student is somehow affected by the general unresponsiveness they have faced," the student said.

Students have particularly

objected to the administration's refusal to accept their demand for the resignation of the Associate Dean (Student Welfare). They said the demand is about accountability. "We were disturbed and disappointed when IIT Director explicitly told us that there cannot be any resignation. This complete denial has hurt the student community. We just want administration action against someone incompetent," the student said.

Students are now collecting emails, messages and testimonials from current and former students about alleged insensitive remarks by officials, faculty and staff. They also alleged that some professors had made comments linking academic performance and suicide while the protest was underway.

In a statement on Thursday, IIT Delhi said student wellbeing was a "fundamental prerequisite" for its academic ecosystem and cited measures already in place, including lighter first-semester credit loads, life-skills courses, academic flexibility, faculty mentorship and 24/7 counselling and psychiatric support.

• SOUTH CITY II RESIDENTS SAY OVERFLOWING MASTER DRAINS LEAVE THEM WITH NO OPTION

Upscale Gurgaon colony pumps out rainwater to save homes, gets FIR warning

Abhimanyu Hazarika
Gurgaon, August 27

AROUND 12.30 pm on Monday, S C Sharma, a 72-year-old tax consultant, was at home in Block A1 of Gurgaon's South City II when rainwater began entering houses in his lane.

Within minutes, the internal colony road was submerged, leaving residents with little choice but to switch on emergency dewatering pumps to drain the water out. "If the Gurugram Metropolitan Development Authority's drain backflows water into our society, what other option do we have?" Sharma said.

But pumping the water out triggered a standoff between

residents of the upscale plotted colony — where ground-floor plots command upwards of Rs 3 crore — and the GMDA.

On Tuesday, an official on duty warned residents that an FIR would be lodged against them for pumping water from the society onto the main road.

In a formal representation to GMDA Executive Engineer Ajayender Singh Suhag, marked to CEO P C Meena, the South City II Residents' Welfare Association (RWA) flagged severe and recurrent waterlogging in Block A1 and also protested against the alleged FIR threat by GMDA Junior Engineer (JE) Sonu Kaushik.

RWA flags recurring flooding

According to the RWA, each time the city sees a spell of heavy rain, it causes the master stormwater and sewer lines along the Sector 47-49 dividing road to overflow.

This, it said, results in sewage and runoff flowing into Block A1 through internal drainage lines and from beneath the boundary wall adjoining the GMDA road.

The flooding directly impacts nearly 200 households. The RWA pointed out that even on July 9, 2024, approximately 160 houses had been severely affected, and a community dog died of electrocution during the waterlogging.



The point where pumps of South City II's A1 block discharge excess stormwater into surface drains of GMDA; (right) waterlogged street outside A1 block. GMDA OFFICIALS, EXPRESS

"We are not doing it out of choice," said Navdeep Yadav, president of the South City II RWA. "When the water volume



increases and the government agencies do not intervene, what other option do we have but to deploy our own tempor-

ary pumps so society roads can remain clear?"

RWA member Neeraj Yadav maintained that temporary pump arrangements remain the only lifeline for residents during torrential showers when master drains overflow into their homes.

'Surface drains not for pumped-out water'

Responding to the RWA, Suhag, it is learnt, told residents that surface drains are not meant for pumping society water. "The Municipal Corporation of Gurugram (MCG) officer concerned was requested to get the society's connection hooked into the master stormwater line, and not the roadside surface

drains," Suhag told the RWA.

Speaking to *The Indian Express*, JE Sonu Kaushik explained that the roadside surface drains are only 2 to 2.5 feet wide and are designed to carry runoff from the carriageway, rather than the high-volume discharge pumped out of residential complexes.

"We got the information from the labour supervisor of the workforce clearing the surface drains. I only warned them against pumping water onto the road, letting them know that if there are any further violations, an FIR may be filed. There was no threat," Kaushik said.

"Societies and commercial establishments dump water on the road like this and make 10

mm of rain seem like 50 mm, and then videos are flashed all over social media to defame authorities," he claimed.

Kaushik added that societies often fail to maintain their internal rainwater harvesting systems and instead push the burden onto public infrastructure.

He said GMDA officials had also warned the society on Friday against deploying pumps in this manner, but the warning was not heeded. "As per legal norms applicable, the FIR can be lodged under relevant sections regarding damage to public property," he said.

GMDA has not formally responded to the RWA's communications.

Maharajganj, Kushinagar districts on high alert in UP

Express News Service
Lucknow, August 27

MAHARAJGANJ AND Kushinagar districts in Uttar Pradesh remained on high alert on Thursday with officials monitoring the water level of rivers emanating from Himalayas, especially Gandak following Wednesday's devastating flash flood in neighbouring Nepal.

Three bodies, believed to have been swept downstream from Nepal, were recovered from Gandak in Maharajganj district on Thursday.

Officials have been directed to ensure that residents of vulnerable villages can be evacuated immediately if the situation deteriorates. Police stations and revenue department personnel have been deployed in riverine areas and equipped to begin rescue operations when required.

In Kushinagar, District Magistrate Mahendra Singh Tanwar and Superintendent of Police Keshav Kumar inspected vulnerable riverside villages and the Valmikinagar barrage.

The water discharge from the Valmikinagar Barrage on the Gandak River, which originates from the Kali and Trisuli rivers and is known as Narayani in Nepal until it enters India, peaked at around 1.5 lakh cusecs (cubic feet per second) on the intervening night of August 26 and 27, according to sources at the

The UP government says its priority is to safely evacuate stranded Indian citizens from Nepal

Central Water Commission (CWC). Since then, the discharge has receded steadily, falling to around 1.02 lakh cusecs by noon on Thursday and the current discharge remains well below the barrage's designed discharge capacity of 8.50 lakh cusecs, the sources said. Residents were advised to stay away from the river and low-lying areas and remain alert to official advisories.

Similarly, in Maharajganj, senior officials, including Additional DM Prashant Kumar, have been deployed in vulnerable riverine areas to monitor the water level and flow of the Gandak, Darjaniya, Tail Fall and other rivers and water channels receiving water from Nepal. The administration has also directed officials to use loudspeakers to alert residents in vulnerable villages. Drinking water, mobile toilets and other essentials are being arranged as a precaution.

The government said its priority was to safely evacuate stranded Indian citizens from Nepal and ensure that residents of vulnerable border villages have timely access to relief and

rescue assistance.

Three bodies, including two women, were spotted by a rescue team of the Sashastra Seema Bal being carried by the strong current of the Gandak river in Maharajganj. The team used a motorboat to retrieve the bodies and sent them to the district headquarters mortuary, officials said. Their identities have not yet been established, and the administration is coordinating with Nepal authorities to trace their relatives.

SSB Inspector Arun Pandey said three bodies are believed to have been swept into the Gandak from Nepal. With the river flowing rapidly following heavy flooding in Nepal, officials said more bodies could potentially be carried downstream.

Meanwhile, administration and police officials are monitoring the Gandak, known as the Narayani in Nepal, as well as other rivers and water channels emanating from Nepal.

The UP government has deployed one SDRF platoon comprising 32 personnel, along with 22 personnel of the 26th Battalion of the Provincial Armed Constabulary (PAC) to Nepal to assist in relief and evacuation operations.

A dedicated helpline, 1070, has been activated for relatives seeking information or assistance regarding UP residents stranded in Nepal.

Bihar CM conducts aerial survey along Gandak river

Patna: Bihar Chief Minister Samrat Choudhary on Thursday conducted an aerial survey of Bihar's northern border districts along the Gandak River basin, including Valmiki Nagar, Bagaha, Bettiah, and Motihari. The CM said ensuring the safety of communities in low-lying riparian zones and providing prompt relief remain the state's highest priority.

Choudhary held review meetings with local officials, instructing disaster management personnel and Water Resources Department (WRD) engineers to remain on high alert.

Local authorities in Bagaha reported that standard operating procedures (SOPs) were triggered early, with residents from vulnerable riverbanks safely relocated to higher ground and temporary shelters stocked with food and essential supplies. ENS

'We cannot just sit at home': Ranchi family wants to visit Nepal to find missing son

Shubham Tigga
Ranchi, August 27

THE LAST 24 hours have been some of the worst the Ghosh family has been through. There's been no word on Ramprasad Ghosh since last evening, and with each passing hour, the Ghosh family's anxiety grows.

"It's been more than 24 hours. We have neither been able to speak to him nor received any information about him," Ramprasad's sister-in-law says anxiously.

The 41-year-old Ranchi man is one of 288 people missing after flash floods swept through parts of Nepal. The flash floods, triggered by an earthquake and an avalanche, have killed 359 people and left 1,500 people missing.

Of the 288 missing Indians, 73 — including Ramprasad — were working on the Trishuli One hydroelectric site when the



Ram Prasad Ghosh's father and other family members show his photograph after he went missing while working at a project for a company based in Kathmandu. ANI

floods struck.

For the family, passing time brings more dread. "We spoke to him last on Tuesday," Ditya says. "There's been no contact since."

Ramprasad had been working on the project since last year. Back home, the family — his 75-year-old father, Ranjit

Kumar Ghosh, his older brother and his brother's family — have been in touch with the Jharkhand migrant workers' cell and have also contacted the Indian Embassy.

Shikha Lakra, head of the migrant workers' control room, said there was no information yet on Ramprasad's whereabouts. "We have written to them [the Indian consular authorities in Nepal] seeking an update," she said. "He is the only one who's untraceable in Jharkhand. The department had spoken to his family."

The family, meanwhile, is now making plans to travel to Nepal.

"We cannot just sit at home. We will leave tomorrow and see what we can do there. We will go and find him," Ditya says, while his father, Ranjit Kumar Ghosh, adds: "Our only appeal is that he should be found as soon as possible and brought back home safely."



ICAR-INDIAN VETERINARY RESEARCH INSTITUTE
IZATNAGAR-243 122 (UP) INDIA
Website : www.ivri.nic.in
Walk in Interview

Walk-in-interviews have been scheduled for engagement of One Young Professional-II at ICAR-IVRI, Izatnagar in “**Network Project on Agricultural Bioinformatics & Computational Biology**”. The engagement is purely temporary on contractual basis and there will be no provision of absorption/re-employment in ICAR or ICAR-IVRI on termination of the project.

A. ONE YOUNG PROFESSIONAL-II (Network Project on Agricultural Bioinformatics & Computational Biology): Eligible candidates will be interviewed on **22nd September, 2026 at 11:00 AM** at Bioinformatics centre, IVRI, Izatnagar.

Please visit Institute website www.ivri.nic.in for detail of advertisement and further updates and notifications regarding interview.

(Dr Amit Kumar)
Principal Investigator

Prakriti International Documentary Film Festival



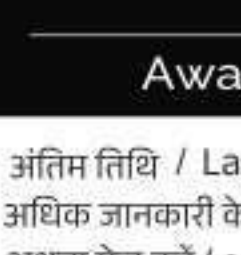
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INTIMATION REGARDING 61st ANNUAL GENERAL MEETING (AGM)
It is hereby informed that the 61st AGM of the Company will be held on Tuesday, 22nd September 2026 at 1200 hours (IST) through Video Conferencing (VC)/Other Audio Visual Means (OAVM) in line with the applicable provisions of the Companies Act, 2013 and rules made thereunder read with circulars issued by MCA and SEBI. In this connection, following is informed:
1. Annual Report including AGM Notice of 61st AGM will be sent only through electronic mode to those shareholders whose email addresses are registered with the Company/depository participant.
2. Notice and Annual Report 2025-26 is available on ITDC website www.itdc.co.in, website of RTA, BSE and NSE.
3. Remote e-voting and e-voting at the AGM facility has been provided. Details are given in the AGM Notice. Voting period starts from Thursday, September 17, 2026 (09:00 a.m. (IST)) to Monday, September 21, 2026 (05:00 p.m. (IST)).
4. Procedure for E-voting, Voting at AGM, Registering email address, mandate for receiving dividends and other information for the shareholders have been described in detail in the AGM notice and are also available at the Website of the Company.
5. A letter with the web-link and path to the Annual Report 2025-26 and 61st AGM Notice is being sent to shareholders whose email addresses are not registered.
Shareholders are requested to scan the QR code given below for more details on 61st AGM of the Company. In case of any further assistance in this regard, shareholders may contact KFin Technologies Limited, RTA of the Company at id: einward.rs@kfinfintech.com, or Contact No.: 1800 3094 001.
For India Tourism Development Corporation Limited
Date: 27.08.2026
Place: New Delhi
**Sd./ V.K. Jain (Company Secretary)**
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दिल्ली सरकार

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रक्षाबंधन की हार्दिक शुभकामनाएं



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रेखा गुप्ता
मुख्यमंत्री, दिल्ली

**विद्या वाहिनी योजना : फ्री साइकिल**

**होली-दिवाली पर फ्री गैस सिलिंडर**

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Nepal Disaster

FRIDAY, AUGUST 28, 2026

ACROSS INDIA, PRAYERS FOR THE MISSING AND AN AGONISING WAIT

‘A torrent of mud, rocks & ice’

‘2 buses ahead swept away’: Karnataka man on lucky escape



Mallinath Kolkundi (extreme left) and other members of the group at the start of the journey.

Kiran Parashar
Bengaluru, August 27

“WE HEARD a deafening roar, and within seconds, before anyone could even comprehend what was happening, everything in front of us was destroyed,” recalled Mallinath Kolkundi, 50, a pilgrim from Karnataka who narrowly escaped the devastating flash floods in Nepal on Wednesday. Mallinath and his son-in-law Sangamesh, 30, residents of Kalaburagi district, were travelling from Kathmandu toward Mansarovar in the Tibet Autonomous Region near Mount Kailash when massive flash floods swept through the Nepal-Tibet border. The deluge has claimed over 350 lives as of now, leaving scores missing, including several Indian pilgrims.

Part of a 25-member tour group that left Hyderabad on August 21, the duo had obtained their visa clearances on August 25. On Wednesday around 6 am, they boarded two buses toward the border.

Recalling the horror, Mallinath said the flood struck around 9.30 am while they were on their way.

“Our vehicle was barely 200 metres from the flood zone. Seeing the wall of water, our bus driver immediately executed a sharp turn and headed to higher ground, which saved our lives,” Mallinath said.

“There was nothing anyone could do. It was pure chance. Most people had no time to react; they were either starting or returning from their pilgrimage.” A massive torrent of mud, water, rocks, and ice carved a path of destruction extending up to 64 km, sweeping away hotels, roads, and border infrastructure.

“In a matter of seconds, everything was wiped out. Two buses ahead of us were completely washed away, and I don’t think bodies can even be retrieved from there,” he added. “The hotel where we stayed and the immigration office we were supposed to visit no longer exist; there is no trace left. By God’s grace, we survived.”

Mallinath and Sangamesh remain stranded, waiting for Real Creator IAS Edition https://t.me/+2RvD_RGf9mjMzg1

road connectivity to be restored so they can return home.

While some survived, anxiety continues for families of other pilgrims. Rakesh Naik, a Dharwad native residing in Australia, went missing near the border. Rakesh was part of an Isha Foundation contingent on the Mansarovar circuit.

According to his brother-in-law, Praveen, Rakesh had reached Delhi on August 12 and was returning from the pilgrimage. “He called us around 3.30 am on Wednesday to say they were returning and planned to reach Kathmandu by morning before catching an evening flight to Australia,” Praveen said.

Rakesh is believed to have been inside the border immigration centre when the floods struck; the facility was entirely obliterated. His wife and two children are in Australia, and his parents in Dharwad, and they have appealed to the government for urgent assistance.

Another survivor, Murali S, noted that several sites where his group had stayed just days earlier were washed away. “All the places we stayed, including hotels and administrative buildings, have been destroyed. We are lucky to be alive,” he said.

Addressing the crisis, Deputy Chief Minister G Parameshwara confirmed that state authorities are actively tracking stranded citizens.

“We have information that eight people from Bengaluru are stranded in Nepal, and steps are being taken to rescue them. We have no reports of fatalities among Karnataka residents so far,” Parameshwara said.

S Honnamba, Commissioner of the Karnataka State Disaster Management Authority (KSDMA), said that 13 inquiries had been received via state helplines. “We managed to establish contact with three individuals, who confirmed that a group of 23 people from Karnataka are safe. Severe network outages are hampering communication, but efforts are ongoing,” she said.

Family members seeking information regarding stranded people can reach out to the state control room: 1070 / 080-22253707.

his Mumbai-based adventure company Hills and Trails for the Kailash-Mansarovar pilgrimage could not be contacted. The group included two prominent Mumbai doctors, Andheri-based gynaecologist Dr Gayatri Deshpande and her husband Dr Anand Deshpande, who headed the haematology department at Hinduja Hospital. Several senior citizens, including 68-year-old Sunil S Subhedar and 64-year-old Chetana Gupta, are also among those reported missing.

Chitley, who is in his 60s, completed his MBBS from Grant Medical College in 1983. But his fascination with adventure sports drew him away from medical practice. In 1997, he co-founded Hills and Trails. His own mountaineering



(Clockwise from top) A child traverses a sludgy street; children undergo treatment at a search and rescue camp; army personnel comfort infants, in Nepal on Thursday. PTI



Kailash Mansarovar Yatra bookings saw a marked surge in ’26

Divya A
New Delhi, August 27

FOR FIVE years between 2020 and 2025, the Kailash Mansarovar remained out of bounds for Indian visitors in the wake of the Covid-19 pandemic and the Galwan standoff that strained India-China ties.

In late 2024, as New Delhi and Beijing began efforts to repair ties, the resumption of the Kailash Mansarovar Yatra in the summer of 2025 was the first tangible takeaway of the thaw.

As people waited to see how the resumption of the yatra panned out in 2025, when the Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) took 750 Indian passport holders in batches, this year saw a rebound in the number of visitors to Kailash Mansarovar.

While the MEA marginally increased the quota from 750 to 1,000, the private operators — who take visitors through Nepal checkpoints such as Rasuwagadhi and Hilsa — saw a



marked surge in 2026. Though an exact count of the number of Indians who signed up for Kailash Yatra through private operators this year is not officially compiled yet, China had announced a cap on the total permissible quota for Indian passport holders via Nepal routes at 24,000 for the season. The quota was 20,000 in 2025.

A major tour operator based in Kathmandu told *The Indian*

Express that a huge number of experiential Indian travellers, including over a thousand Indian passport holders residing abroad (NRIs), had signed up for the yatra through their agency.

“Despite rising costs owing to inflation, and increased fees and charges for allied services, this year saw maximum bookings so far,” he said.

As the yatra took off in June, there were reports of Indian

citizens undertaking private tours being stuck in Nepal before being able to cross over to Tibet. On June 27, the MEA had issued an advisory to citizens to not commence their journey unless all permits were received.

“The Ministry is in receipt of several requests for help and assistance from Indian citizens stuck in Nepal while undertaking Kailash Mansarovar Yatra without the required entry per-

mit and visas for China, through tours organised by private operators,” the MEA had said.

Before the yatra suspension in 2020, the government programme generally accommodated 800-1,000 pilgrims annually. For 2025, the capacity was 750 pilgrims — 250 through the Lipulekh route in five batches and 500 through the Nathu La route in 10 batches.

Beyond its spiritual significance, the yatra is also one of the world’s most logistically complex pilgrimages. Located in China’s Tibet Autonomous Region, it requires extensive diplomatic coordination between New Delhi and Beijing, meticulous planning and strict medical screening because of extreme altitude and inhospitable terrain.

Pilgrim groups having to halt yatra for days en route owing to inclement weather is a norm rather than an exception. But a tragedy of this scale has not happened before. The worst recorded tragedy associated

with the Kailash Mansarovar Yatra before 2026 has been the 1998 Malpa landslide in the Pithoragarh district of Uttarakhand, which claimed over 220 lives, including 60 pilgrims who were on their way to Kailash.

Mount Kailash is about 6,638 m above sea level, while the nearby Mansarovar Lake is at an altitude of 4,590 m, among one of the world’s highest freshwater lakes. Pilgrims traditionally undertake the 52-km Kailash Parikrama, or Kora, which is now reduced to 13 km through some routes.

For those taking the government-operated Lipulekh route, the journey from Delhi to the Kailash covers roughly 1,000 km by road, besides the 52-km parikrama. The alternative Nathu La route through Sikkim is longer by road but involves comparatively less trekking.

In 2025, of the 750 pilgrims who registered for the yatra, 688 participated and completed the journey, as per the MEA.

Veteran mountaineer, wife go off the radar

Ishika Gupta
Mumbai, August 27

FOR DR Milind P Chitley, medicine was a profession but mountaineering was a calling. After completing his MBBS and beginning his career as a doctor, his growing love for the mountains and adventure eventually led him to leave medical practice and devote himself to mountaineering, a passion that would see him build an adventure company and spend more than three decades leading expeditions.

On Thursday, the veteran mountaineer was among the Indians reported missing after flash floods in Nepal. Chitley, his wife Janhavi and several members of a group of around 40 pilgrims travelling through

his Mumbai-based adventure company Hills and Trails for the Kailash-Mansarovar pilgrimage could not be contacted.

The group included two prominent Mumbai doctors, Andheri-based gynaecologist Dr Gayatri Deshpande and her husband Dr Anand Deshpande, who headed the haematology department at Hinduja Hospital. Several senior citizens, including 68-year-old Sunil S Subhedar and 64-year-old Chetana Gupta, are also among those reported missing.

Chitley, who is in his 60s, completed his MBBS from Grant Medical College in 1983. But his fascination with adventure sports drew him away from medical practice. In 1997, he co-founded Hills and Trails.

His own mountaineering



(Left) Dr Milind P Chitley and his wife Janhavi; Chetana Gupta

record is extensive. He has walked more than 3,000 Himalayan trails and expeditions and climbed to more than 23,000 feet on Mount Kanchenjunga. He was part of the organising committee of the 1997 Everest Expedition and served as the climbing doctor for the first Indian civilian expedition to a mountain above 8,000 metres.

He received the Girimitra

Award in 2005 for his contribution to mountaineering.

The group began its journey on August 23 and was scheduled to return on September 6. Chetana Gupta, 64, had learnt about Hills and Trails through close friends who had earlier participated in a Mount Everest trek organised by the company.

“She had her sights set on the Kailash-Mansarovar tour and had even implored me to come along. However, I preferred to opt out because of age-related concerns and worries about low oxygen levels at high-altitude places,” said husband Anand Gupta.

He was last in contact with Chetana in the early hours of the day communication was lost. She was travelling towards an immigration centre, he said.

Actor stranded, TMC leader’s wife missing

Sweetie Kumari
Kolkata, August 27

AMID REPORTS of at least 32 visitors from West Bengal missing and several others stranded in Nepal following flash floods and landslides, the state government has set up a 24x7 emergency control room to track people missing from the state and coordinate assistance.

A 32-member team from Kolkata comprising 30 pilgrims travelling to Mount Kailash and Mansarovar alongside two staff members of Kolkata-based travel agency Cholo Jai Travels has been unreachable since Wednesday night. The group, which left Kolkata on August 21, had reached the Nepal-China border immigration office around 8.30 am Wednesday to



Actor Kharaj Mukherjee and Sharmistha Bhowmik Roy, wife of TMC leader Subhranshu Roy

secure permits for Tibet when a sudden avalanche struck, instantly severing communication links. Expressing deep concern over the tragedy, Chief Minister Suvenudh Adhikari stated that West Bengal stands in full solidarity with Nepal.

“Deeply pained by the colossal tragedy caused by catastrophic flash floods in Nepal, I

extend my heartfelt condolences to all the bereaved families who have lost their loved ones in this devastating natural calamity. Extremely concerned about reports of over 100 Indian visitors, mostly pilgrims on the Kailash Mansarovar Yatra, who are missing,” he said on X late Wednesday.

Sharmistha Bhowmik Roy, wife of Trinamool Congress leader Subhranshu Roy and daughter-in-law of late veteran politician Mukul Roy, is among those reported missing after catastrophic flash floods struck near the Nepal-China border.

Sharmistha had left Kolkata on August 21 as part of a 30-member Kailash-Mansarovar pilgrimage group and was reportedly around 10 km from the site of the deluge when com-

munication with her was lost.

“I spoke to her at 11.30 pm on Tuesday; she was fine. She was somewhere called Kyirong. Since then, we have not been able to contact her,” Subhranshu told *The Indian Express*.

Popular Bengali actor Kharaj Mukherjee and his wife Protiva are among those stranded. They had travelled to Nepal along with their film crew on August 20 for a shoot.

Mukherjee said his team, camping in a forest amid torrential rain, plans to head to Gokharpur by road and then fly to Kolkata on Friday.

Several families across Bengal said dozens remain uncontactable or halted mid-journey. Some stranded tourists have managed to establish partial communication.



PROTESTERS AGREE TO END THEIR STIR AFTER MEETING SENIOR EDUCATION DEPT OFFICIALS

Bihar govt blinks on single-stage teachers' exam, protest called off

Himanshu Harsh
Patna, August 27

THE BIHAR government has agreed to the demand for a single examination in the fourth Teacher Recruitment Examination (TRE-4) following which the protesters agreed to call off their stir that entered its 10th day on Thursday.

Following a meeting with senior Education Department officials, a delegation of 13 student representatives unanimously agreed to withdraw its ongoing agitation, an official said. The decisions were taken at a meeting chaired by the Secretary, Education Department, Bihar.

The protesters have been promised that further action would be initiated on the "one candidate, one result" issue according to rules.

Protesters have been demanding a "One Candidate, One Result" policy to prevent "seat wastage", where high-scoring candidates occupying multiple positions (Primary to Senior Secondary) leave vacancies behind when taking up only one job.

Protesters have urged that a



Bihar CM Samrat Chaudhary interacts with students during Samvad programme at Magadh Mahila College in Patna on Thursday. PTI

filtering system be implemented that removes successful candidates from lower-tier merit lists, ensuring each person fills only one seat and enables others to take up the remaining vacancies.

According to the proceedings of the meeting, the government accepted the demand for conducting the TRE-4 recruitment process through a single examination as against separate prelims and mains. "On the issue of one candidate, one result, it

was decided that further action would be taken as per the applicable rules," an official said.

The meeting also addressed several other demands raised in a written memorandum submitted by the student delegation.

"On demands relating to the 70th Bihar Public Service Commission (BPSC) examination, recruitment examinations conducted by the Bihar Staff Selection Commission (BSSC), the sub-inspector recruitment examination and the

Bihar Eligibility Test (BET), it was decided that complaints and suggestions would be placed before a committee to be constituted under the chairmanship of a Patna High Court judge," the official said.

The committee will examine the issues on the basis of evidence and suggestions submitted by complainants, with further action to be taken according to its recommendations. The proceedings also state that the further process of the 1,799-post sub-inspector recruitment examination will be taken up only after the committee submits its report.

The government further decided that the BSSC would issue a recruitment examination calendar at the earliest and take steps to conduct examinations on schedule.

"On the recruitment of librarians, officials agreed to initiate necessary action soon to begin the process in accordance with the available vacancies," the official said, adding that a high-level committee will also examine the demand for a separate quota where contractual employees are given marks or weightage in Bihar government

recruitment processes, in accordance with government provisions.

On domicile issue, it was decided in the meeting that further action on implementing the maximum possible domicile policy in Bihar's recruitment processes "would be taken in accordance with legal advice obtained from jurists". The demand concerning the maximum age limit for recruitment was also agreed to be placed before the committee for consideration.

There was also consensus on issuing recruitment calendars and ensuring their strict adherence. A proposal to ensure transparency in the question papers, OMR sheets and answer sheets of recruitment examinations conducted on the lines of BPSC examinations will be placed before the committee headed by a Patna High Court judge.

"Regarding allegations of paper leaks in BPSC examinations, including the AEDO and sanitary-related examinations, the Economic Offences Unit (EOU) of Bihar Police is taking necessary action in accordance with law for an impartial investigation," the officer said.

Padma Awards not for family members: Shah

Express News Service
Ahmedabad, August 27

"PADMA SHRI, Padma Bhushan, Padma Vibhushan, Bharat Ratna—all these awards are not for the family, not for people known to you. It is for those who, without expecting praise dedicate their lives to the poor people of Bharat Mata", said Union Home and Co-operation Minister Amit Shah in Amreli on Thursday.

Shah also said that it was because of Prime Minister Narendra Modi's "wish" that Surat-based diamond businessman Govind Dholakia was made a member of the Rajya Sabha.

Recalling the contribution of the Govind Dholakia-founded Shree Ramkrishna Group in curbing religious conversions in the districts of South Gujarat, Shah said Dholakia's foundation (SRK Knowledge Foundation) built "Hanuman temples and schools".

Shah was speaking at the inauguration of the Gujarat Gaurav Sarovar in Amreli, built by the Harekrishna Group and the Dholakia Foundation promoted by another leading diamondaire Savji Dholakia. Both Govind Dholakia and Savji Dholakia belong to Dudhala village of Amreli and are based in Surat.

Referring to the Padma Shri awarded to Savjibhai in 2022, Shah said, "Look at his modesty. Savjibhai said I have not even applied and yet I got a Padma Shri... Savjibhai after rejuvenating 208 lakes if you have to apply for these (awards) our government would be considered useless.

Cong slams BJP over state chief justifying 'purification' ritual at Kharge rally venue

Press Trust of India
New Delhi, August 27

THE CONGRESS on Thursday accused Uttarakhand BJP chief Mahendra Bhatt of "justifying" the "shuddhikaran (purification)" ceremony at the venue of a rally addressed by Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge in Haldwani, and asked whether the ruling party would take action against the leader as he "defended untouchability".

Bhatt reportedly said the place was polluted with slogans unfit for a religious place, as he dismissed the criticism over the ritual.

Congress general secretary (organisation) K C Venugopal said, "It was evident from day 1 that Union Minister Sh J P Nadda's statement of regret in the Rajya Sabha was a mere eye-wash. If Mr. Nadda truly meant that the BJP doesn't subscribe to such acts, how is the BJP's own Uttarakhand Chief defending the so-called 'shuddhikaran' that their workers did after Kharge ji's event?"

"The BJP's true casteist nature keeps rearing its ugly head, no matter how much cover-up their leaders attempt. If there is even an iota of truth in Mr Nadda's statement in Parliament, they must sack Mr Mahendra Bhatt and take strict criminal action against those who insulted Kharge ji," he said.

Tagging a video of Bhatt's remarks, Congress's media and publicity department head



“It does not matter that Nadda ji described the shuddhikaran in Haldwani after Kharge ji's rally as 'unfortunate'. The truth is that discrimination flows through the veins of the RSS-BJP like blood”

K C VENUGOPAL,
CONGRESS GENERAL SECRETARY
(ORGANISATION)

Pawan Khara said, "It does not matter that Nadda ji described the shuddhikaran in Haldwani after Kharge ji's rally as 'unfortunate'. The truth is that discrimination flows through the veins of the RSS-BJP like blood." Now, the Uttarakhand BJP president has justified the "shuddhikaran", he said.

Last week, the Congress Working Committee (CWC) had strongly condemned the alleged purification.

Don't try & bulldoze: Kharge asks PM to call all-party meet on delimitation Bill

Express News Service
New Delhi, August 27

CONGRESS PRESIDENT Mallikarjun Kharge on Thursday wrote to Prime Minister Narendra Modi, asking whether the government plans to hold a special session of Parliament to pass the delimitation Bill and reiterating the demand for an all-party meeting on the issue.

Kharge, who is also the Rajya Sabha Leader of Opposition, said he is writing the letter "to reiterate this request (for all-party meeting) since the Union Minister of Parliamentary Affairs (Kiren Rijiju) has publicly stated in a television interview last night that such a special session of Parliament could well be convened". "This perhaps explains the continued delay in the prorogation of the Monsoon Session itself," Kharge wrote.

The letter comes days after the Congress questioned why the Lok Sabha had not been prorogued after 10 days of it being adjourned sine die. "What explains the abnormal delay now? Is the Union Home Minister

(Amit Shah) still in search of his bahukalakit (tarnished) 2/3rd majority to get the Constitutional Amendment Bill on Delimitation passed in a Special Session," asked Congress general secretary (communications) Jairam Ramesh in a post on X.

Kharge in his letter mentioned an earlier letter on July 16 "requesting you (the PM) to convene an all-party meeting for discussing the government's proposals for delimitation". "I had also requested you to give all political parties adequate time to study such proposals in detail before they are introduced in any special session of Parliament that you may be contemplating," he wrote.

Kharge said the Congress was "very clear" on its stand on the issue. "Maintain the existing strength of the Lok Sabha at 543 for another 25 years. Maintain the existing state-wise strength in the Lok Sabha for another 25 years. Introduce one-third reservation for women from the 2029 Lok Sabha elections," wrote Kharge.

Fresh Faces

FOLLOWING BJP national president Nitin Nabin's first meeting with the eight new general secretaries of the party on Thursday, insiders are looking forward to several high-profile organisational appointments over the weekend. Sources said the meeting, held at the party headquarters in the Capital, focused on party affairs in poll-bound states. The interaction is likely to pave the way for the appointment of fresh faces on posts such as state election in-charge as part of a party-wide restructuring, said the sources.

3 judicial officers appointed judges of Himachal HC

New Delhi: Three judicial officers were elevated to judges of the Himachal Pradesh High Court on Thursday. A notification regarding their appointments was issued by the Union Ministry of Law and Justice.

Chirag Bhanu Singh, currently District & Sessions Judge, Kangra at Dharamshala, was appointed as a judge, while Bhupesh Sharma and Yogesh Jaswal were appointed as additional judges.

Additional judges are usually appointed for a period of two years before being made judges, or what is popularly called 'permanent judges'. Sharma is currently Registrar General of the HC and Jaswal the District & Sessions Judge, Sirmour. PTI

THE SLOGANS that rang out in Karnal earlier this month captured a political shift underway in Haryana.

The last prayers for Biru Balmiki, 25, shot dead in Karnal by bike-borne assailants on August 5, rang with "Jai Bhim, Jai Balmiki, Jai Shree Ram". Hours after the killing, the police shot dead two alleged shooters, one from the upper-caste Ror community. It was a response so swift that Dalit representatives such as advocate Sonia Tanwar noted people struggled to digest such stringent action for a Balmiki youth. Hindu Raksha Dal members stood alongside the Balmiki community leaders throughout the protests and at the bhog (a ceremony to mark the end of the mourning period after someone dies).

The Karnal incident is a sharp contrast to the July 2025 case of Ganesh Valmiki in Hissar. The teenager died following a scuffle with the police for playing loud music at a birthday party. The family and the Balmiki community rose in protest and did not cremate the body for 11 days until their demands, including action against erring cops, were met amid intervention by senior Congress leaders.

The difference in the police response to the two incidents has not gone unnoticed. Dalit assertion itself is relatively recent in a state long



Biru Balmiki was shot dead by bike-borne assailants on August 5.

described as Jat land. The change gained pace after the BJP came to power in 2014 under Manohar Lal Khattar, ending a long line of Jat chief ministers. Ever since, the party has pursued caste engineering by consolidating non-Jats and non-dominant Dalit groups, particularly Balmikis. The approach has continued under CM Nayab Singh Saini.

Scheduled Castes (SCs) form roughly a fifth of Haryana's population, with Jatavs the largest bloc and Balmikis, or Valmikis, among the largest of the rest. The BJP bets that splitting the Jatav bloc from other SC communities yields a decisive edge.

Post-poll data from the 2024 Haryana elections backs this: according to Lokniti-CSDS, the Congressed among Jatavs 50%-35%, while the BJP led among other SCs 45%-33%. This explains why Saini chose to be sworn in on Valmiki Jayanti, after visiting a Valmiki temple in Panchkula.

The outreach has moved past symbolism. After the Supreme Court's August 2024 ruling permitting SC sub-classification, Haryana was the first state to act on it, splitting its 20% SC quota in November 2024 into Deprived Scheduled Castes (DSC, 36 communities including Balmikis, Dhanaks, Mazhabis Sikhs, and Khatiks) and Other Scheduled Castes (OSC, covering Jatavs and a caste associated with leather work), each entitled to 10% of total seats. In May 2025, of 7,596 Group D posts announced, 605 were reserved for DSC candidates and 604 for OSC.

The project is as much about identity as reservation. The slogans at Biru Balmiki's prayers reflect a vocabulary where caste assertion and Hindu identity aren't seen as contradictory. Young Balmikis increasingly call themselves "sab se kattar Hindus" (the most fundamentalist Hindus) online.

Political scientist Krishan Kumar, the author of "Reading

• FOR THE LAST TWO-AND-A-HALF YEARS, DILAWAR HAS BEEN IN THE LINE OF CONGRESS FIRE OVER A SLEW OF ROWS AND CONTROVERSIAL REMARKS

Why Rajasthan's Education Minister Madan Dilawar is facing CJP firestorm

Hamza Khan
Jaipur, August 27

FLAGGING a news report about around 30 students of a Kota government school falling ill after having a mid-day meal, the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP)'s co-convenor Ashutosh Ranka Tuesday said that none of the states would have seen as many incidents and scandals as Rajasthan Education Department under Minister Madan Dilawar.

Kota is also BJP leader Dilawar's home turf, with his Assembly constituency, Ramgani Mandi, falling in the district.

During the last two-and-a-half years of the Bhajan Lal Sharma-led BJP government, Dilawar has been in the line of the Congress's fire over a slew of rows and controversial remarks.

Now, the CJP has turned up the heat on Dilawar. Following the outfit's move to inspect schools in Rajasthan under its countrywide "School Think

Karo" campaign, the BJP government recently imposed restrictions on entry of outsiders and taking photos and videos in government schools, citing privacy of students.

Divisive pitch

A six-time legislator, Dilawar has been embroiled in multiple rows in his career, especially after he took charge as the Education Minister in December 2023 following the BJP's return to power in the state.

In January 2021, Dilawar had slammed the farm agitation against the now-repealed central agricultural laws, saying "so-called farmers" were enjoying dry fruits, chicken biryani and other luxuries at protest sites and that it was a "conspiracy to spread bird flu".

Speaking in the Assembly in September 2021, Dilawar called Mewata "mini-Pakistan", alleging that the Braj region has become a "den of terrorists and

goons" where cow slaughter and atrocities against girls were rampant coupled with the replacement of destroyed temples with mosques.

In another Assembly speech, in March 2023, he called the Congress's state in-charge Sukhjinder Singh Randhawa a "terrorist".

In May 2023, referring to Mallikarjun Kharge, Dilawar said the "Congress president, who is 80 years old, bhagwan kabhi bhi unko utha sakta hai (God can summon him anytime) but I would pray to God to not call him for 200 years."

'DNA test' remark

In February 2024, the Education Department directed schools to hold "surya namaskar", amid opposition by Muslim groups who pointed out that Muslims only pray to God.

In the same month, Minister Dilawar suspended three Muslim teachers at a govern-



Madan Dilawar. FILE

ment school in Kota, alleging that there is a "conspiracy of religious conversion, love jihad, and Hindu girls are forcefully being made to offer namaz." However, a spot visit by *The Indian Express* then found school staff, local education officials and several villagers denying any conversion attempts, with inquiries finding no evidence beyond a few disputed student statements.

In June 2024, Dilawar said the heat wave was "the result of Congress's *kukarn* (misdeeds)".

In July 2024, the Education Department announced that Vir Savarkar Jayanti will be marked in schools on May 28 and Swarna Mukut Mastak Diwas will be held on August 5 to celebrate the abrogation of Article 370 from Jammu and Kashmir, apart from Matr Pitri Diwas on February 14 and Surya Namaskar Diwas on February 4. Referring to the Hindutva ideologue's event, Congress state president Govind Singh Dotasra castigated the "politicisation of education".

In September that year, Dilawar announced that the bicycles given to schoolgirls would be saffron – a shift from black during the Congress regime – reasoning that their colour was saffron under the previous BJP government (2013-18).

In October, referring to female teachers, he said that "*kai beheno ko dekhta hun, jo aache kapde nahi pehenti, poori shareer dikha kar ke school*

mein jaati hain (I see several sisters who do not wear proper clothes and go to school exposing their entire body)," which, he added, led to "bad *sanskaar*" among students.

2025: Targeting Akbar

In January 2025, amid a spike in student suicides, Dilawar said some cases were also caused by "*prem-prasang* (love affairs)", prompting Dotasra to say, "I request the CM (Bhajan Lal Sharma) to save the state – make Dilawar the CM but please hand over Education Department to someone else."

In March 2025, he said Mughal emperor Akbar was a "rapist and looter". "It pains you and I so much what they used to teach about the great men (of the country). They tried to belittle Maharana Pratap. And Akbar, who used to set up '*meena bazaar*', was a rapist, an invader and a looter, was called as great. This was an insult to the country,

of our great men. This cannot be tolerated." In February 2024 too, he had said that even "taking Akbar's name in India is a sin".

In June 2025, Dilawar stoked another controversy by saying, "*Main alag prakar ka aadmi hun, gaushalaon ke khilaf hun* (I am a different kind of person, I am against cow shelters)."

In November 2025, orders were issued, and withdrawn, twice by the state government to schools to "celebrate" the Babri Masjid demolition day (December 6) as "Shaurya Diwas", with Primary and Secondary Education Director Sita Ram Jat maintaining that he did not issue any such orders. However, in the second instance, the official statement accompanying the government order had stated that it was decided upon instructions from Minister Dilawar.

'Leak not a big deal'

In May 2026, following the

NEET paper leak, Dilawar said, "The investigating agencies must have found that there are some irregularities and decided to cancel it. *Toh is mein koi badi baat nahi hai* (So it isn't a big deal). Wherever irregularities are found, the government will work to fix it."

In July, he also justified the police crackdown on student protesters during the CJP's march in New Delhi, saying it was "less" considering the "hooliganism" there.

Jhalawar school

The biggest controversy of Dilawar's tenure has been the collapse of a Jhalawar government school in July 2025 in which seven students were killed and eight seriously wounded.

The Jhalawar case prompted a statewide audit of schools which revealed that of the 63,018 government schools in the state, 5,667 were "completely dilapidated".

Modi to begin four-day visit to Uzbekistan and Kyrgyzstan tomorrow

Express News Service
New Delhi, August 27

PRIME MINISTER Narendra Modi will go on a bilateral visit to Uzbekistan from August 29 to 30 and the Kyrgyz Republic for the 26th Shanghai Cooperation Organisation (SCO) Summit, to be held from August 31 to September 1.

Announcing the visit, the Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) said, “At the invitation of the President of Uzbekistan, Shavkat Mirziyoyev, Prime Minister will undertake a state visit to Tashkent on 29–30 August 2026. This will be the Prime Minister’s fourth visit to Uzbekistan.”

During the visit, the Prime Minister will hold delegation-level talks with President Mirziyoyev to further strengthen the strategic partnership between the two countries.

“The two leaders would review cooperation in trade and investment, defence, digital connectivity, energy, education and people-to-people domains and set the agenda for the road ahead. They will also share perspectives on advancing the shared developmental visions of Viksit Bharat 2047 and Uzbekistan-2030,” the MEA said.

Prime Minister Modi is also expected to visit the Shastri Memorial in Tashkent and the Real Creator IAS Edition https://t.me/+2RvD_RGf9mjMzg1



PM Narendra Modi. FILE

Mahatma Gandhi Centre at the Tashkent State University of Oriental Studies.

From Tashkent, MEA said, at the invitation of the President of Kyrgyz Republic, Sadyr Zhaparov, the Prime Minister will travel to Bishkek to participate in the 26th SCO Summit on August 31 – September 1.

The summit marks the 25th anniversary of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation, of which India has been a full member since 2017. “The Prime Minister will address the summit where he will highlight India’s priorities of security, connectivity and opportunity at the forum,” it said.

Modi will also hold bilateral meetings with SCO leaders on the sidelines of the summit. In addition, he is also expected to attend the opening ceremony of the sixth World Nomad Games, a celebration of the cultural heritage of Central Asia.

Fadnavis gives auto and taxi drivers a year to learn Marathi

Vallabh Ozkarar
Mumbai, August 27

JUST DAYS after Maharashtra began checking autorickshaw and taxi drivers for Marathi proficiency, Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis on Thursday put enforcement on hold for a year, giving drivers a fresh window to learn the language and ruled out action against those who failed the test during this period.

The decision follows protests by drivers’ organisations, which argued that many drivers — from different age groups and with limited formal education — could not be expected to acquire even basic Marathi within weeks.

Representatives of the organisations met Fadnavis and sought a year to comply. “Their demand was that they should be given one year’s time. The state government has accepted their demand,” Fadnavis said. He said the year would be used not simply as a grace period but to train drivers.

“During this one year, no action will be taken against them. We will help them by arranging different types of classes and preparing literature so that they can learn basic Marathi,” the chief minister added.

The rollback comes just a week after the Transport De-



Officers verify if an auto driver in Mumbai has the required working knowledge of Marathi. FILE

partment began enforcing the language requirement from August 20. On the first day alone, 8,217 drivers were tested and 1,268 were issued notices after failing to demonstrate the required working knowledge of Marathi.

Under the amended Maharashtra Motor Vehicles Rules, drivers of autorickshaws, taxis and other public service vehicles must demonstrate basic Marathi communication skills with passengers. A driver failing the test was initially given one month to improve. A second failure could result in suspension of the public service vehicle badge for three months.

Transport Minister Pratap Sarnaik had strongly defended the enforcement, arguing that drivers were required to know only basic Marathi needed to communicate with passengers and that the government did not intend to deprive anyone of their livelihood.

On Thursday, however, Sarnaik backed the one-year window announced by Fadnavis, emphasising that it would be the final concession. “We have waited 36 years for the implementation of the 1989 rule, so waiting another year is not an issue. But after one year, there should be no further demands. If you want to do business in

Maharashtra, you will have to speak Marathi,” he said.

He also claimed that a 105-day Marathi training campaign conducted by the Shiv Sena had helped around 1.65 lakh auto-rickshaw and taxi drivers learn the language.

Haji Ashraf, who was part of the delegation that met Fadnavis, said drivers would use the one-year window to learn Marathi properly.

“Within one year, every auto-rickshaw and taxi driver will learn Marathi and speak it properly. We will not just learn a little Marathi; we will learn to speak good, proper and fluent Marathi,” he said.

Delhi High Court quashes defamation case against former MP Pinaki Misra

Sohini Ghosh
New Delhi, August 27

THE DELHI High Court Tuesday quashed criminal defamation proceedings against former Biju Janata Dal Lok Sabha MP and senior advocate Pinaki Misra, ruling that there was insufficient material to sustain the case.

The order, made public on Wednesday, was passed by Justice Swarana Kanta Sharma, who noted that continuing the criminal proceedings “would not advance the cause of justice and would instead subject (Misra) to the rigours of a criminal trial in the absence of sufficient foundational material”.

The case arose from a complaint filed by advocate Siddhartha Singh, who had accused Misra of professional misconduct before the Bar Council of Delhi in August 2018, alleging that Misra took contradictory positions on e-waste rules — first before a parliamentary committee, and later, while representing power distribution companies at the National Green Tribunal. Misra denied the allegations and, in response, called Singh a “crook” and “blackmailer”.

Singh subsequently filed two criminal complaints in 2019 before a magistrate court in Patiala House, seeking defa-

mation proceedings against Misra over the remarks. The magistrate court summoned Misra to stand trial in both cases on April 20, 2019.

Justice Sharma noted that there is “no material on record, in the form of statement of any other person or otherwise, to prima facie demonstrate that the alleged imputation had the effect of lowering” Singh’s reputation. The court further stated that during the pre-summoning evidence stage, Singh had examined only himself as a witness, and that a bare assertion of reputational harm did not meet the legal threshold required to initiate criminal defamation proceedings.

Singh’s case relied on an online report by Dailyhunt in which Misra was quoted calling him a “crook”. Misra denied giving any such interview and pointed to a letter he had written in March 2019 to the editor of *Odisha Post*, seeking a published clarification on the same grounds.

The court also observed that the magistrate had not examined the publication or the reporter concerned — a step that could have established, at least prima facie, that Misra had actually made the statement. In its absence, the court found “no independent material” linking the remarks to Misra.

Office of the Director
INDIRA GANDHI INSTITUTE OF MEDICAL SCIENCES,
SHEIKHPURA, PATNA – 800 014 (Bihar, India)
Tel.: 0612 – 2297631, 2297099; Fax: 0612 – 2297225; Website: www.igims.org;
E-Mail: director@igims.org
E-Tender Notice
(E-Tendering mode only on www.cproc2.bihar.gov.in)

Memo No.-EC/EW/E800/198/26/146
E-Tender Notice No.- IGIMS/EC/EW/06/2026-2027

IGIMS, Patna invites sealed tender in two bid system (Technical and Price) from reputed agency/authorized dealer for “Supply, installation, testing and commissioning of 15 Passenger/1020 kg (Stretcher & Passengers) Lift/elevator for G+2 New Modular OT Complex building beside mortuary area, at IGIMS, Patna-14”

The last date and time for submission/uploading of complete tender document at www.cproc2.bihar.gov.in is 21/09/ 2026 Up to 3:00 PM. The Technical bids will be opened on 23/09/ 2026 at 3:00 PM at www.cproc2.bihar.gov.in. Details of the tender can be seen and downloaded from institute website : www.igims.org & www.cproc2.bihar.gov.in. The Undersigned reserves the right to accept/reject any or all tenders without assigning any reason. Prospective bidders are advised to regularly visit : www.cproc2.bihar.gov.in & www.igims.org for corrigendum/amendments etc, if any. It will be notified on these portals only and no separate advertisement will be made.

This information is available on www.state.bihar.gov.in/prdbihar also

PR. No. 010636 (B&C) 2026-27

Director,
I.G.I.M.S. Patna

नशामुक्त हो जाए बिहार, सुरक्षित रहे घर परिवार।

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON
See Section 84 Bhartiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita-2023

Whereas complaint has been made before me that the accused person Namely **Amit Tomar S/o Lt. Shadav Tomar R/o- H. No. A-119, Gali No-8, Meet Nagar, Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in **case FIR No. 440/2013, U/s 279/337 IPC PS Welcome, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **Amit Tomar** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Amit Tomar** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said **Amit Tomar** accused of **FIR No. 440/2013, U/s 279/337 IPC PS Welcome, Delhi** is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **29.09.2026**.

By Order
Mrs. Deepakshi Rana
JMF-03, Room No. 19
Karkardooma Court, Delhi

DP/12014/NE/2026 (Court Matter)

NORTH CENTRAL RAILWAY

Notification No. : DRM/C/AGRA/2026/1-16 Dated : 27.08.2026

Public Notification

On behalf of President of India Senior Divisional Commercial Manager, North Central Railway, Agra invites applications for engagement of station ticket booking agent (STBA) on commission basis for issuing the unreserved Railway tickets through Computerised unreserved ticketing system (UTS) at 18 locations of 16 (NSG-4, NSG-5 & NSG-6 Category) Railway stations of Agra Division, for the period of (NSG-6 & NSG-5) 03 years and (NSG-4) Category Station till 20.05.2027 or instruction received from Railway Board.

Notification No. : 2026/01 To 2026/16

Nature of work : Engagement of STBA for 18 Location of 16 Stations (NSG-4, NSG-5 & NSG-6)

Earnest Money (EMD) in Rs. : (NSG-4-10,000/- NSG-5 - 5,000/- & NSG-6 - 2,000/-) as well as on Indian Government portal www.tenders.gov.in If the Notification documents are downloaded from the website, then, the applicant will have to attach the cost of Application form Rs 1,000/- +180 (18% GST) = Rs 1,180/- with Application form in the form of DD. (in original) issued by any Nationalized/Scheduled Bank in favour of Sr. Divisional Finance Manager N. C. Railway- Agra, otherwise the Application will be rejected. Application received after the date and time specified above will not be considered. Offer valid up to 90 days from the date of opening of application form.

Railway Administration keeps its right reserved to Cancel any one or all the Application forms without assigning any reason. 1998/26 (C)

North central railways www.ncr.indianrailways.gov.in @ CPRONC

Notification No.	Name of Station	Category	Code	Shift
2026/1	JHAREDA	NSG-6	JREA	24 Hrs.
2026/2	BHAINSA	NSG-6	BSA	24 Hrs.
2026/3	BIWAI	NSG-6	BW	24 Hrs.
2026/4	RUNDHI	NSG-6	RDE	24 Hrs.
2026/5	AGRA CITY	NSG-6	AGA	24 Hrs.
2026/6	CHHALESAR	NSG-6	CHLR	24 Hrs.
2026/7	GAZIKA	NSG-6	GZKA	24 Hrs.
2026/8	KITHAM	NSG-6	KXM	24 Hrs.
2026/9	BAAD	NSG-6	BAD	24 Hrs.
2026/10	FARAH	NSG-6	FAR	24 Hrs.
2026/11	RUNKUTA	NSG-6	RNKA	24 Hrs.
2026/12	ACHHNERA	NSG-5	AH	00:00-12:00 Hrs. ☐ 12:00-24:00 Hrs. ☐
2026/13	KOSI KALAN	NSG-4	KSV	00:00-12:00 Hrs. ☐ 12:00-24:00 Hrs. ☐
2026/14	RAJA KI MANDI	NSG-4	RKM	Platform No.-01 side 00:00-12:00 Hrs. ☐ 12:00-24:00 Hrs. ☐ Platform No.-02 side 00:00-12:00 Hrs. ☐ 12:00-24:00 Hrs. ☐
2026/15	IDGAH	NSG-4	IDH	Platform No.-04 side 00:00-12:00 Hrs. ☐ 12:00-24:00 Hrs. ☐
2026/16	DHOLPUR	NSG-4	DHO	12:00-24:00 Hrs. ☐

Note : A person can apply for one Shift/one Platform side/one station only:

Office address from where Application form may be obtained : Applicant can obtain Application forms along with terms & conditions from the office of DRM /N.C.R.-Agra on cash payment of Rs 1,000/-+180 (18% GST) = Rs 1,180/- to the Chief Booking Supervisor, Agra Cantt. in any working day from 31.08.2026 to date- 24.09.2026 up to 17:00 hrs. The Application form is not transferable and its cost is Non Refundable.

Duration of work : According to Railway Board's letter no. 2018/TG-120/P/STBA Dated-14.08.2024, engagement of station ticket booking agent at NSG-4 & NSG-6 category Railway stations for the period of 03 years and Railway Board's letter No. 2018/TG-1/20/P/STBA dated - 20.05.2026 engagement of station ticket booking agent (STBA) at NSG-4 category railway stations till 20.05.2027 or instruction received from Railway Board.

Last date & time of depositing of Application form : Duty filled Sealed Application Form should be dropped in Tender Box Date – 25.09.2026 till 11:00 hrs. and after that Tender Box will be sealed.

Date and Time of Opening of Application form/ Tender box : Application forms will be opened on 25.09.2026 at 11:30 hrs in the presence of Applicants. If the day of acceptance of Application form and the day of its opening is holiday the next working day will be the last day for submitting and opening of Application form.

Place of Submitting & Opening of Application form : Office of the Sr. Divisional Commercial Manager, DRM Office, Agra Cantt.

Website description and Notice Board where full details can be viewed : The Notification inviting Application, Application form, Terms and conditions are also available on the website of North Central Railway <https://ncr.indianrailways.gov.in/> as well as on Indian Government portal www.tenders.gov.in If the Notification documents are downloaded from the website, then, the applicant will have to attach the cost of Application form Rs 1,000/- +180 (18% GST) = Rs 1,180/- with Application form in the form of DD. (in original) issued by any Nationalized/Scheduled Bank in favour of Sr. Divisional Finance Manager N. C. Railway- Agra, otherwise the Application will be rejected. Application received after the date and time specified above will not be considered. Offer valid up to 90 days from the date of opening of application form.

‘Serious concern’: Rajasthan lawyers’ groups break silence on allegations against Acting CJ

Hamza Khan
Jaipur, August 27

“STRONGLY CONDEMNING any alleged misuse of position” and expressing “deep concern” at the recent allegations against the acting Chief Justice (CJ) of Rajasthan High Court Sanjeev Prakash Sharma, three lawyer associations in the state have demanded that the matter be addressed with “utmost seriousness”.

The Rajasthan High Court Bar Association, Jaipur; the Rajasthan High Court Lawyers’ Association, Jodhpur; and the Rajasthan High Court Advocates’ Association, Jodhpur, convened an emergency online meeting of their office bearers on Thursday, where they expressed “serious concern over the recent developments that have come to light through the media”.

Earlier this month, Justice Sandeep Mehta of the Supreme Court wrote three letters to Chief Justice of India (CJI) Surya Kant, seeking the transfer of the acting CJ of Rajasthan and the appointment of a new CJ there.

Justice Mehta accused Justice Sharma of “misuse of powers” and said he had received “several complaints” which “raise doubts” on the Acting CJ’s “integrity”.

“The Chief Justice of the Supreme Court has requested an institutional investigation. Since this matter is extremely serious and concerns the institutional dignity and independence of the judiciary, the legal community views this entire development with deep concern,” the associations said in a joint statement.

“We strongly and unequivocally condemn any alleged misuse of any position or office within the judiciary... any incident or conduct that calls into question the impartiality, dignity, or credibility of the judiciary must be addressed with the utmost seriousness,” they said.

Earlier, in December 2025 and in April, the Rajasthan High Court Advocates’ Association, Jodhpur, had written to the CJI seeking a permanent Chief Justice for the HC.

In December, it had said that the relationship between the Bench and the Bar was deteriorating and that, “the absence of a permanent Chief Justice often leads to an administrative vacuum or, as witnessed currently, an overreach of acting powers.”

In April, they had requested the CJI to shift the acting CJ out of Rajasthan “so that harmony can be maintained between the Bar and the Bench.”

Meanwhile, both Jodhpur-based lawyers’ associations have requested the acting CJ to ensure that the judges’ strength at the principal seat in the city be suitably increased.

In their letter to the acting CJ, they said that it has been the consistent tradition, practice and institutional history that the strength in Jodhpur “has ordinarily remained higher than that at the Jaipur Bench...”

They said that on several occasions, both associations have requested that the permanent sitting at Jodhpur be suitably increased, “keeping in view the enormous volume of litigation, mounting pendency and the continuing institutional responsibilities of the Principal Seat...”

Objecting to the nomination of two judges to Jaipur Bench despite their letters, they said, “It is, therefore, a matter of serious concern for the members of the Bar that, notwithstanding the repeated representations for strengthening the permanent sitting at Jodhpur, Hon’ble Mr. Justice Farzand Ali as well as Hon’ble Mr. Justice Arun Monga have recently been nominated to sit permanently at the Jaipur Bench until further orders.”

They said that such an arrangement “has caused considerable concern amongst the members of the Bar.

Death of rape victim in abortion bid: Kishtwar hospital worker among 3 held

Arun Sharma
Jammu, August 27

THREE MORE people, including an employee of the state-run district hospital in Kishtwar, have been arrested by Jammu & Kashmir Police in connection with the alleged sexual assault of a tribal teenager by a school headmaster last week, leading to her fatal pregnancy.

A sweeper at the hospital where the teenager was taken for an abortion and two relatives of the headmaster have been arrested, taking the total arrests to five.

Kishtwar SSP Naresh Singh said a Special Investigation Team is conducting a “thorough, scientific and time-bound investigation into all aspects of the case”. It comes days after the National Commission for Scheduled Tribes sent a notice to district authorities over the incident.

According to police, the teenager had allegedly been abused by the headmaster for several months, leading to her death on August 20 after a failed abortion attempt last

week. Her death led to protests across the district.

The case emerged after the girl complained of stomach pain and was allegedly taken to a local health centre, which confirmed her pregnancy. She was eventually taken to local medical facilities, where a fatal abortion bid allegedly weakened her. Labour was allegedly induced, leading to a stillbirth.

Police allege that the headmaster and his brother took her to the district hospital in Kishtwar and, with the help of the sweeper, got an ultrasound done and made her take abortion medication.

“The SIT is investigating all aspects of the case,” the officer said.

Although the girl died on August 20, no formal complaint was registered, with police eventually initiating proceedings. Police later registered a case under the Protection of Children from Sexual Offences Act and sections of criminal conspiracy, rape of a minor, and death caused by an act intended to cause miscarriage, among others.

The headmaster and his brother — both of whom are said to have accompanied the teenager for the failed abortion attempt — have been arrested. The education department has initiated an inquiry and suspended the headmaster.

The National Commission for Scheduled Tribes (NCST) issued notices to the J&K Chief Secretary, Director General of Police and Kishtwar SSP, asking them to submit a report within five days.

In its notice, the commission said police had failed to invoke the Scheduled Castes and Scheduled Tribes (Prevention of Atrocities) Act even though the teenager was a tribal. The commission has also asked authorities to verify the status of the girl and the headmaster, provide protection to the family, consider compensation for them and preserve evidence.

On Wednesday, SSP Singh said the Scheduled Castes and Scheduled Tribes (Prevention of Atrocities) Act has also been invoked in the case.



DIS/AGREE

THE BEST OF BOTH SIDES

A weekly column, which offers not this-versus-that, but the best of both sides, to inform the debate

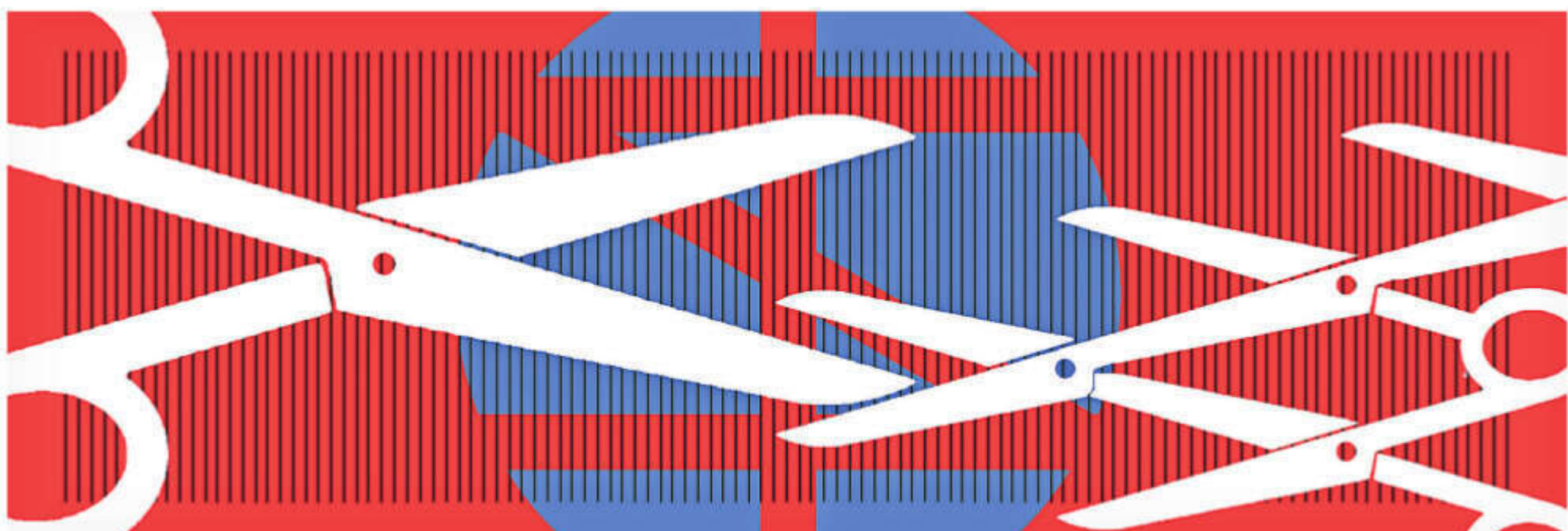


ILLUSTRATION: C R SASIKUMAR

Is Canadian PM Mark Carney’s middle power solidarity approach an apt counter to Trump’s playbook?

Carney’s defiance is well thought out



VIKAS SWARUP

THERE ARE moments in international diplomacy when the most audacious thing a country can say is “no”. Mark Carney has just provided one. The Canadian Prime Minister walked away from trade negotiations with the US after Washington put forward terms Ottawa deemed unacceptable, including demands that would have come at the cost of its sovereignty, key industries, French language and culture, and its freedom to negotiate with other countries. Carney’s formulation was blunt: The Americans “asked too much and offered too little”. He has also announced dollar-for-dollar retaliation against new US tariffs, making clear that Canada will not absorb American pressure without imposing costs of its own. He deserves applause.

Canada sends roughly three-quarters of its exports south, into an economy roughly 10 times its size, and a sustained trade confrontation could put up to 90,000 Canadian jobs at risk. But Carney’s gamble is not without its logic. It rests on three key calculations.

One, he has broad domestic backing, including from the Conservative opposition, amid public frustration with US President Donald Trump’s threats and repeated talk of making Canada the 51st state. Two, the new tariffs apply to only about 5 per cent of overall Canadian exports to the US, roughly \$20 billion. And three, the breakdown will also hurt the US.

Canada is the largest export market for 26 American states and among the top three trading partners for 45 of the 50. It supplies roughly 60 per cent of America’s crude-oil imports. Canadian electricity helps power grids in New England and the upper Midwest. Canadian potash is vital to American agriculture, while Canadian critical minerals feed strategically important American supply chains. A prolonged trade war, therefore, cuts both ways.

The timing is also hardly ideal for Washington. The stalemate with Iran has pushed US gasoline prices above \$4 a gallon, while the 30-year Treasury yield has climbed above 5.3 per cent, its highest level since 2007. Federal debt has crossed \$40 trillion, and Trump’s net approval rating has fallen to minus 26 per cent. Carney does not need to win a trade war outright. He only needs his retaliatory tariffs to land on the right swing states long enough to make the arith-

metic politically painful in Washington.

There is another reason his gamble deserves attention. Carney did not improvise his defiance. After his warning in Davos, that middle powers must stand up or risk ending up “on the menu”, he spent the better part of a year building trade ties with China, the Gulf, and Asia, India among them, so that a closed door in Washington did not mean a locked room globally. That is statecraft of the highest order. And this is why the Canadian episode matters far beyond Canada.

From Mexico City to Brussels to Tokyo, governments have spent the past year confronting an American president who increasingly treats a signed trade agreement not as a settlement, but as an opening bid that can be revisited whenever it suits him. Trump’s playbook has remained unchanged: Coerce partners with escalating tariff threats, demand unilateral concessions on domestic policy, and attempt to impose restrictions that erode national economic sovereignty. The conventional wisdom in many capitals has been to bend, compromise, and sign whatever deal avoids immediate retribution. Carney tore up that playbook. By walking away from unacceptable terms, Carney demonstrated a fundamental truth of international relations: It is always useful — and often necessary — to stand up to a bully. If Canada demonstrates that a middle power can withstand US pressure by exploiting its own strategic importance, diversifying its markets and making the costs of retaliation visible inside America, it changes the negotiating psychology for everyone else.

India should pay close attention. New Delhi is still waiting to conclude its own trade deal with the US, and India has powerful reasons to pursue one. Access to the US market matters enormously to Indian exporters, just as American capital and technology remain crucial for domestic growth. Ultimately, a stable trading relationship with Washington is firmly in India’s national interest. But the need for a deal must never mutate into a willingness to accept any deal.

India must know what it can negotiate and what it cannot. It must protect policy autonomy, avoid concessions that permanently damage vulnerable sectors and retain the freedom to pursue independent economic and strategic relationships. Above all, it must build alternatives. So that if its own moment to say “enough” arrives, it costs a great deal less to say it.

Trump’s calculus is that in a contest between unequal powers, the bigger bully always wins. Carney has just shown that, in geopolitics as in life, size isn’t everything.

The writer is a former high commissioner to Canada



T V PAUL

MARK CARNEY walking away from a lopsided trade deal with the US raises the question of whether Canada can withstand American economic and political pressure. More than 70 per cent of Canada’s trade is with the US, compared to about 15 per cent of US trade with Canada. A great power is asserting dominance over a neighbour that Donald Trump has repeatedly portrayed as a potential 51st state or, at minimum, a vassal with limited capacity to pursue independent policies.

Canada’s defiance will bring short- and potentially medium-term pain to its economy and standard of living. The \$27 billion in dollar-for-dollar tariffs announced by Ottawa could further anger Trump and prompt additional tariffs on Canada. If the US carries out its threatened 50 per cent tariffs on Canadian autos and steel from January 1, and Canada’s threatened retaliatory tariffs on oil and electricity exports take full effect, prices could rise significantly on both sides of the border. High unemployment could follow.

But countries do not always behave according to economic rationality when confronting a cantankerous neighbour. When the stronger side asserts too much power, it can generate nationalism in the weaker country, as is evident in Canada today. Carney cannot unilaterally accept a trade deal that could become a domestic quagmire for him and the Liberal Party. For provinces like Ontario, the auto-parts provisions are a major issue; for Quebec, restrictions affecting French-language marketing are a no-go zone. Separatist movements in Quebec and Alberta could also be emboldened if Ottawa were seen as submitting to American pressure, although Alberta could be particularly affected by any Canadian tariffs on the oil products it exports to the US. Washington appears to have underestimated Canada’s domestic dynamics and the implications for its federalism.

Carney’s calculation may be that, despite the power asymmetry, Canada holds several trump cards that can be used in the negotiations. Studies show that Canada performed well in previous North American Free Trade Agreement negotiations and in negotiating its successor, the Canada-United States-Mexico Agreement. Canada secured several provisions that are now being contested, although their long-

term benefits remain uncertain.

The larger issue is Canadian sovereignty and its determination not to be, as Carney himself has put it, a “subsidiary” of the US. The Trump administration’s neo-imperial policies do not distinguish reliably between allies and adversaries. Carney wants to diversify Canada’s trade relationships, including with China and India, and reduce its dependence on the US market. This strategy is integral to the vision he presented in Davos that middle powers such as Canada should remain independent actors. Protecting and strengthening Canadian manufacturing in collaboration with partners in Europe and Asia will be central to that strategy.

For the Trump administration, time may be short. Impending electoral cycles could constrain its policies. Carney may be calculating that a mercurial president could abandon an agreement at any time over another issue, perhaps even one driven by personal considerations, and that a possible Democratic victory in the November congressional elections could place greater restraints on Trump’s unilateralism. Moreover, more than half of all American states depend heavily on trade with Canada and could pressure Trump and his trade negotiators to make concessions and compromises.

If Canada succeeds in persuading the US to compromise, it could provide other countries with an example of how to deal with Washington. In the long run, external pressure could also help Canada build a more self-reliant economy capable of manufacturing a broader range of products, despite its relatively small population and economy.

A stronger Canada can say no to America’s tendency toward neo-imperialism and neo-mercantilism. Even during the Cold War, Canada resisted participating in some US military interventions and has now refused to join the ongoing Iran war. Canada also maintained diplomatic and economic relations with Cuba despite US efforts to isolate the communist regime. America under Trump is more strident, while Canada’s options are limited: Accept an unfavourable trade agreement or stand firm in pursuit of a better one.

Other middle powers and European partners are closely watching the emerging saga. They are unlikely to form a formal coalition of resistance with Canada, but they can cooperate with Ottawa in less conspicuous ways. Sometimes ruptures and crises are necessary, even among friends, to make clear what is at stake in unequal relationships. Canada may be doing the international order a favour by refusing to concede.

The writer is Distinguished James McGill Professor at McGill University, Canada

On workers’ rights, shrinking spaces and cruel state response



AJAY SINGH

FORTY THOUSAND to 50,000 casual workers die every year due to occupational hazards in India’s unorganised sector, according to numerous research studies. This is just the tip of the iceberg, as many perish without even a mention in official records.

India’s unorganised sector, which employs nearly 80 per cent of the workforce, bears the burden of this regular massacre. Human lives are counted as the collateral cost of development, ignored much like the demolition of anthills for construction projects.

Are we aware of the abject conditions in which workers on real-estate projects live? Are we not aware of stories of domestic helps being subjected to inhuman conditions and torture in housing societies that are among the most expensive in Delhi-NCR and other metros? We read these stories as remote observers, as if they are not connected to people like us. They are not our stories.

On April 13, when thousands of workers in Noida and Ghaziabad took to the streets to demand higher wages, the Noida police, caught off guard, all but invented a conspiracy theory about the agitation being sponsored by “Pakistan-based handlers” and radical leftists. In no time, the agitation was not only “otherised” but also criminalised to a large extent. About 200 people were arrested for inciting violence, including two — journalist Satyam Verma and DU student Akriti Chaudhary — under the draconian NSA, not for their acts but for their ideological leanings. While the Uttar Pradesh government announced higher wages, those who were arrested fought a grim battle in courts and continue to face the aftermath even after coming out of jail.

The episode was noticed by the wider public, possibly because it disrupted traffic for many hours, causing some to miss their appointments and flights. Otherwise, workers’ plight or agitations rarely make news.

The liberalisation of the Indian economy has progressed to the point where the trade union movement has become a relic of a distant past. The trade union movement produced great leaders such as George Fernandes, but that era is over. Since “working journalists” were classified as labour, there were union leaders in newsrooms and printing presses too. Sometime in the 1990s, news organisations began hiring people on a contract basis instead of on the payroll for the long term. That was part of a trend already under way in many sectors. Event-

Real Creator IAS Edition https://t.me/+2rVd_RGf9mljMzg1



ually, the biggest employer in the country, the governments at the Centre and in the states, also adopted it as a cost-saving exercise, precipitating the “casualisation” of labour.

As a result, workers and employees today have no means to demand better working conditions or fight against any injustice. This is also a time when the Left parties are losing their political strength and even relevance. In social-media parlance, “leftist” is used as a pejorative. Those protesting in Noida were, of course, “leftists” in the old as well as the new sense of the term.

In the whole Noida episode, the conspiracy of silence shocks me no end. In my formative years of journalism in Kanpur in 1985, I had seen a bond of unique camaraderie among leaders of trade unions, irrespective of their ideological pursuits. The CITU, AITUC, INTUC, BMS and others would join hands for the cause of labour. Workers in textile mills and in the defence sector justifiably earned their rights by dint of their consistent struggles against the management. The trade union movement consolidated workers’ unity and did not divide them on ideological grounds. The leaders of the BMS and the CITU would not work at cross-purposes despite their ideological differences. This was why Kanpur, despite being a predominantly

Brahmin constituency, was represented in the Lok Sabha by SM Banerjee, a veteran trade union leader, from 1957 to 1977.

What is particularly galling is the criminalisation of written material in the possession of an individual. How can a book on Marxism, or on Gaza or the Palestinian struggle, be categorised as a criminal offence? In India’s polity, the Marxist ideology is as much part of the

political mainstream as the Congress or the BJP. All political parties that swear loyalty to the Indian Constitution are allowed to grow and function in the country.

In the past, political parties and their leaders had shown sagacity and flexibility in accommodating ideological adversaries. This was evident when, in 1997, the BJP’s national executive passed a resolution mourning the assassination of AISA leader and former JNU Student Union president Chandrashekar by Mohammed Shahabuddin in Siwan. Chandrashekhkar belonged to an ideological stream aligned with the Naxal ideology.

Perhaps, in today’s context, the BJP’s national executive resolution of 1997 would itself be treated as seditious material by the Uttar Pradesh Police — worthy of slapping the NSA against someone if it was found in their possession.

Singh was press secretary to President Droupadi Murmu and former president Ram Nath Kovind and is the author of The Architect of the New BJP: How Narendra Modi Transformed the Party

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Nepal tragedy

MY HEART goes out to all the families who have lost their loved ones in the Nepal flash flood (‘Over 100 Indians among hundreds missing in Nepal flash flood fury’, *IE*, August 27). Evidently, nature’s fury once again has been laid bare. There are no prizes for guessing that heedless development and obliteration of the environment have made such natural disasters more frequent and fatal. The Nepal tragedy is a reminder to people, governments, and other stakeholders across the world to mend their ways and adopt an environment-centric approach to the future.

— *Aanya Singhal, Noida*

No longer silent

THE ARTICLE captures an important shift in Indian democracy: Young people are no longer content to be silent spectators (‘Young found their voice. Opposition needs to find its language’, *IE*, August 27). The recent CJP-led mobilisation is a reminder that when institutions fail to adequately hear the concerns of the younger generation, they can find new spaces — and new languages — to make themselves heard. For students, these concerns are deeply personal: Exam pressure, paper leaks, cancelled examinations, un-

employment, rising educational costs and the uncertainty of building a secure future. Their voice is not merely a political trend; it reflects a generation asking for fairness, dignity and opportunity. Young people do not need political parties merely to speak on their behalf; they need institutions that are willing to listen, include and trust them. The CJP experience also demonstrates how digital platforms can turn individual frustration into collective civic engagement.

— *Fathima Ferzin Dilna N, Kannur*

Mutual respect

MUMBAI’S STRENGTH has always rested on its cosmopolitan character (‘Language & religion dikats shrink Mumbai’, *IE*, August 27). Attempts to impose language or religious preferences on citizens can weaken this social fabric and discourage people from different backgrounds from living and working together. Political leaders should avoid turning cultural identity into a tool of exclusion. The civic administration must ensure that public services, employment and housing remain accessible without discrimination. Respect for Marathi and local traditions is natural, but it should coexist with equal citizenship and mutual respect.

— *A Myilsami, Coimbatore*



SHIVANI SIBAL

THERE IS nothing that says you are growing old more than a sentence that begins with “In my time...”, but here I am.

There was a time, I gather — perhaps from the experience of being on the receiving end of parenting rather than the service-provider end, which it very much feels like now — when expectations of the whole thing were simpler. One hoped to raise children who were decent, reasonably happy, able to cope with the real world, and not a menace to others, perhaps as a result of the first three goals.

Modern parenting is a much more elaborate operation. It is no longer enough to feed, house, love and generally guide children and hope for the best. We are curating them, making sure that every moment

Don’t herd children through narrow tunnels

they spend on mother earth is optimised. In modern all-rounder hell, our kids must eat right, do well at school, play an instrument (because music and maths or something), not look at screens (bad, the very worst), and soon. Even playing is not called playing anymore. It is free play, and it has a window in the schedule.

To parent today in a way that is even reasonably boast-worthy is to endlessly schedule, supervise, monitor, enrich and improve. Decisions that were previously ordinary now come with inbuilt moral undertones. A snack is not a casual item one might pick up when hungry. It carries the weight of health, discipline and future habits. School holidays spent resting are deemed “wasted”. We are trying to get our kids somewhere — wherever it is we imagine they are meant to reach — quicker and better than the others.

This fear is central to modern optimisation culture. *Log kya kahenge*. So-and-so’s

child is in the state swim team, or got a full scholarship to university. What is yours doing? It is striking how much of modern parenting is organised against FOMO. It is no longer enough to raise good children; we must all be raising exceptional ones. Children are like adults, in that they sometimes feel lazy and sometimes motivated, hesitate, surge ahead, have self-doubt, fail, try again, and sometimes give up. None of this is accounted for in the graph society currently lays out for them.

What makes this entire framework even less plausible is that no one can say with any certainty what sort of future it is we are preparing them for. What we can say for sure is that it is more uncertain than it has been in living memory because of the arrival of artificial intelligence. We are in the discovery-of-fire, invention-of-wheel territory of change here. Yet we continue to herd and nudge the young through narrow tunnels of achievement as we have known it so far, as if

we can confidently predict what forms of excellence will matter in the future and which will not. A great deal of what is currently measured as achievement — perfect recall, conventional academic superiority, several currently coveted professions — is beginning to look alarmingly perishable. All the things we are pushing our kids to excel at may well end up turning into dust.

One of the most important things we can prepare our children for is uncertainty, and that is truer today than ever. To tell them that everything they are doing today, because we tell them to, will reap rewards, when the world ahead may not require or value it at all, is doing them a disservice. We can hope, instead, that they are able to adapt to whatever is coming, because there is no real way to prepare them for a future we cannot yet envision. That uncertainty is the crux of the human condition. It always has been.

Sibal is the author of Equations

• NEPAL DISASTER

Echoes of past, warning for future

The devastating flash floods in Nepal are just the latest reminder of the vulnerability of the Himalayan region to similar natural disasters — from Kedarnath in 2013 to Dharali last year



AMITABH SINHA

THE DEVASTATING flooding in Nepal's Bhotekoshi-Trishuli river, which has already claimed more than 350 lives, is yet another reminder of the vulnerability of the Himalayan region to major disasters.

Though they were all triggered by a unique set of circumstances, the Nepal tragedy is not very different from similar disasters seen in India over the last 15 years — Kedarnath in 2013, Chamoli in 2021, Sikkim's South Lhonak lake in 2023, and Uttarakhand's Dharali last year.

Each of them involved a very large and sudden release of waters in the mountainous rivers, either due to a breach in a glacial lake, or because of a large block of glacial ice breaking off and falling into the river.

The breach in the lake or the breaking off of the ice-block can be spontaneous — under accumulated stress over time — or be caused by an extremely heavy rainfall, a landslide or an earthquake.

The end result, however, is the same — a series of cascading events in which a mass of water, stones and soil gushes downstream at great speeds, eroding river banks, uprooting trees, triggering landslides, and destroying buildings, roads and bridges. All the debris being collected by the river on the way further strengthens its force, and its potential to cause damage. The situation continues till the river arrives at a flatter landscape, offering the raging flow an opportunity to spread out and disperse.

What caused the Nepal event

Wednesday's event, which started in the northeastern district of Rasua in Nepal, is currently understood to have been triggered by a rock and ice avalanche, a result of a large block of glacier in the upper reaches of the Bhotekoshi river (the lower side is also called the Trishuli) falling off. What caused this break-off is not very clear as of now. There was no heavy rainfall incident recorded in the area, so that factor is largely ruled out.

The US Geological Survey had reported a 4.4 magnitude earthquake in the region on Wednesday, which was initially believed to be the trigger. On Thursday morning, however, it said the signal that was captured by its sensors was most probably a result of a landslide and not a seismic event.

"This event was initially reported as a magnitude 4.4 earthquake. Additional analysis of nearby seismic stations, long period seismic waves and satellite imagery led to the determination that the seismic event was instead a glacial collapse and debris flow, and that no earthquake had occurred," said the USGS update. That could mean that a large chunk of snow broke off from the glacier on its own, possibly under its own internal stress, and caused a landslide which triggered the chain of events.

But Syed Iqbal Hasnain, a veteran glaciologist and former vice-chancellor of University of Calicut, pointed out that ice-blocks were not visible in any of the videos of the disaster. "The ice that breaks off from a glacier is almost like a solid rock. It does not melt immediately. But no ice block is visible in the videos of the incident. It is possible therefore that the incident was caused not by ice blocks breaking off from a glacier, but from



THE TRAIL OF DESTRUCTION

THE DISASTER in Nepal was most likely triggered by a rock and ice avalanche, a result of a large block of glacier in the upper reaches of the Bhotekoshi river (the lower side is also called the Trishuli) falling off.

THE CAUSE of the break-off is unclear as of now. While an earthquake was speculated earlier, it has emerged that it was the break-off that caused the seismic event.

THE EFFECT, however, was devastating — from the Gyirong land border between China and Nepal to Nuwakot district and beyond.



Real Creator IAS Edition https://t.me/+2RvD_RGf9mljMzgl

Kathmandu-based The International Centre for Integrated Mountain Development (ICIMOD), a major research organisation working on the Himalayas. Chamoli was caused by an ice and rock avalanche, a result of a large ice-block of a glacier, estimated to be 27 million cubic metres in all, breaking away and falling downhill. Kedarnath, on the other hand, was a GLOF (Glacial Lake Outburst Flood) event, the result of a breach in a glacial lake.

The Kedarnath incident was much more devastating. The damage potential of an event like this depends on factors like geography, the incline of the river, vegetation, population and urbanisation. The amount of rock and ice that fell off in the Nepal incident is yet to be estimated, but the fact that its fall was captured as a fairly large seismic wave (USGS had revised its 4.4 measurement to 5.2) suggests the involvement of a very big chunk of mass. It is not surprising, therefore, that the impact of the Nepal event appears to be significantly bigger than the Chamoli incident, in which about 200 people were reported to have been killed, or gone missing.

The reason these events in the Himalayan region become so risky is that while they start off as individual events — extreme rainfall or landslide or lake overflow — they soon transform into a multi-hazard disaster, involving multiple landslides, flooding and building collapse episodes.

"The Himalayan region is very fragile. Such events lead to a chain reaction. A surging river with large rocks and ice blocks would erode the banks and slopes, and more soil, mud and rocks would become part of the raging river. It becomes a cascading disaster because the waters do not have any other way to spread out. That is why any such event in the Himalayan ecosystem becomes extremely dangerous," said Azam, currently in China attending a disaster risk reduction conference.

A study published in *Science* magazine last year about a 2023 event in Sikkim captured the cascading impact of such flash flood events in the mountains. This event had been triggered by the collapse of a large chunk of glacier into the South Lhonak lake, situated over 5,000 metres above sea level, in northern Sikkim. This led to a GLOF event that took the shape of flash floods. The study found that a landslide had re-

PHOTOS: AGENCIES; NOTE: MAP SHOWS APPROXIMATE LOCATIONS OF SITES SEEN IN PHOTOGRAPHS

• HIMALAYAN DISASTERS

KEDARNATH, 2013: In June, Uttarakhand received an unusually high amount of rainfall, leading to the melting of the Chorabari glacier and the Mandakini river overflowing. The floods affected large parts of Uttarakhand, Himachal Pradesh and Western Nepal, causing massive flash floods and landslides. Nearly 6,000 people were presumed dead.

CHAMOLI, 2021: A large glacier broke away and set off a flood, leading to surging waters in the Rishiganga river in Uttarakhand. Over 200 people were reported dead.

SIKKIM, 2023: A glacial lake (large bodies of water that sit in front of, on top of, or beneath a melting glacier) situated in northwest Sikkim at 5,000 metres burst due to incessant rains. It led to the release of water in downstream areas and the deaths of at least 55 people.

DHARALI, 2025: The terrain of the region in Uttarakhand (6,900 metres above mean sea level), combined with continuous rain for days, triggered mudslides, debris slides and flash floods. At least 69 people were reported dead.

sulted in the collapse of nearly 14.7 million cubic metres of rocks, soil and snow deposited around a glacier into the South Lhonak lake, which triggered a series of cascading events. The volume of the flowing sediment downstream had grown to about 270 million cubic metres.

"The collapse of approximately 14.7 million cubic metres of frozen lateral moraine into the South Lhonak Lake... on 3 October 2023 generated a 20-m-high displacement wave. The wave overtopped and breached the frontal frozen moraine, causing the sudden drainage of approximately 50 million cubic metres of water... The GLOF eroded approximately 270 million cubic metres of sediment and triggered 45 secondary landslides. Most of the erosion occurred within about 67.5 km of the lake," the study had found.

Vulnerable Himalayas

Azam said the entire Himalayan region was "out of balance entirely" because of population pressure and climate change.

"The whole ecosystem is vulnerable. Because of climate change and increasing instances of extreme weather events, newer areas are getting exposed. Earthquakes or heavy rainfall events are quite common, and any of them can trigger these kinds of disasters," he said.

The Himalayan region is also one of the most dangerous places for earthquakes, recording some of the biggest temblors in the past. Nepal itself was the victim of a 7.2 magnitude earthquake in 2015.

The only way to minimise the damage from such events is to install early warning systems, prepare evacuation plans, and strictly monitor and regulate construction and other activities in the ecologically fragile region so that further instability is avoided.

After the Sikkim disaster, the NDMA had initiated a National GLOF Risk Mitigation Programme (NGRMP) seeking to install early warning systems at glacial lakes at high risk of facing a breach. The Rs 150-crore programme is targeting connecting 195 glacial lakes in Sikkim, Uttarakhand, Arunachal Pradesh, Himachal Pradesh and the Union Territories of Jammu and Kashmir and Ladakh with early warning systems.

• DIPLOMACY

India-China boundary talks: Some progress, but a long road ahead



EXPERT EXPLAINS

SUJAN CHINO

DIRECTOR GENERAL, MANOHAR PARRIKAR INSTITUTE FOR DEFENCE STUDIES AND ANALYSES

THE EIGHT-POINT consensus reached at the 25th round of talks between Special Representatives (SRs) Ajit Doval and his Chinese counterpart Wang Yi in Beijing is a welcome step ahead of the expected visit of President Xi Jinping to India for the BRICS Summit.

Some of the outcomes concern the maintenance of peace and tranquillity in the border areas, and advancing negotiations on a framework for the settlement of the boundary question in accordance with previous agreements. There is a specific reference to advancing discussions through an Expert Group and Working Group respectively, to explore an "early harvest" of boundary delimitation in appropriate sectors, and effective border management.

Last year, there was agreement in principle on working towards setting up additional General-Level Mechanisms/Senior

Highest Military Commander (SHMC) meetings in the Eastern and Middle sectors akin to the existing mechanism in the Western sector at Chushul/Moldo.

This time, the two sides agreed to implement that understanding along with establishing two hotlines in the Eastern and Middle Sectors. Going forward, the implementation will have to be handled carefully.

The past as prologue

In 1992, the Joint Working Group (JWG) on the Boundary Question decided on confidence building measures (CBMs) such as border personnel meetings (BPMs), complementing forward movement on border trade.

A sub-group of the JWG was created following the border peace and tranquillity agreement (BPTA) of 1993 — the India-China Expert Group of Diplomatic and Military Officials (EG), a precursor to the Working Mechanism for Consultation and Coordination on India-China Border Affairs (WMCC), an institutional mechanism for border management set up in 2012.

After the success achieved in 1995 on disengagement at Sumdorong Chu (along the India-China Line of Actual Control in Arunachal Pradesh), Lipulekh (Middle Sector) and Dichu (Eastern Sector) were subsequently identified as additional military meeting points. The plan for BPMs at Lipulekh was abandoned due to lack of infra-



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structure and adverse weather conditions. A trial meeting at Dichu in the Kibithu sector in Arunachal Pradesh was finalised. Dichu is a sensitive area in Anjaw district, and the site of a famous battle in 1962 at Hill 100, in which the Kumaon Regiment did the Indian Army proud. The site chosen for the BPM on Madan Ridge proved contentious. No further meetings could take place.

It was not until 2014 that the proposal for additional points for BPMs was revived. Eventually, it was decided to have regular BPMs at Wacha/Kibithu in the same sector opposite Damai on the Chinese side, in addition to existing venues across Bum La in

Arunachal Pradesh and Nathu La in Sikkim. Together with BPMs across the Lungnak Lungpa stream at Daulat Beg Oldie (DBO) and Tianwendian (TWD) in the Chip Chap valley, and at the Chushul-Moldo meeting point in the Spanggur Gap, these have contributed to the two militaries maintaining direct contact.

Additional meetings would further the cause of peace. Existing hotlines at DBO and Chushul, some informal communication at Demchok in the Western Sector, and similar hotlines at Nathu La (Sikkim) and Bum La and Kibithu in the Eastern Sector have pro-

• The LAC's sectors

THE LINE OF ACTUAL CONTROL separates Indian-controlled territory from Chinese-controlled territory.

IT IS DIVIDED INTO into three sectors: the Eastern Sector (Arunachal Pradesh and Sikkim), Middle Sector (Uttarakhand and Himachal Pradesh) and Western Sector (Ladakh).

NSA Ajit Doval and Chinese Foreign Minister Wang Yi at the 25th Meeting of Special Representatives in Beijing on Tuesday. ANI

vided the two militaries with channels for direct contact. The two additional hotline channels agreed to for the Eastern and Middle sectors could strengthen this capacity and help defuse local tensions.

The road ahead

The SRs are working to realise the consensus reached between Prime Minister Narendra Modi and President Xi at Kazan in October 2024 and at Tianjin in August 2025 on improving ties.

Recent developments such as the resumption of the Kailash Mansarovar Yatra, direct flights, and border trade are mean-

ingful steps in the right direction.

However, the road ahead, especially on the task of "early and substantial harvest of boundary delimitation and border management" may be long and arduous, requiring patient negotiations. It would be premature to suggest that substantive boundary delimitation has already begun in earnest. After all, the Expert Group and Working Group under the WMCC are now explicitly tasked with finalising their respective Terms of Reference. That means the framework is being created and the process is being activated incrementally.

There is also the issue of making piecemeal progress as against a more holistic settlement of differences along the Line of Actual Control. Neither the Sikkim sub-sector nor the Middle Sector are free from the burden of differences. The negotiators must be empowered to engage in meaningful discussions. They must have sufficient experience in handling a matter that has proved vexatious for previous generations.

If taken in the right direction, the guidance provided by the political leadership can lead to lasting peace and offer a window for substantive cooperation between two large and populous neighbours in an era of global flux.

(The author was head of the Indian side in the Expert Group of Diplomatic and Military Officials negotiating with China between 1996 and 2000)

THE CEA RECENTLY CALLED FOR A LOWER ETHANOL-PETROL BLEND OPTION

‘No reversal to E10, choice for old vehicles being explored’

Sukalp Sharma
New Delhi, August 27

AMID THE public debate around E20 petrol — 80% petrol and 20% ethanol — being the only standard petrol variant in the country, the option of additionally offering petrol with 10% ethanol blending, or E10, is being explored specifically for older vehicles, Sanjay Khanna, chairman of the country’s second-largest fuel retailer Bharat Petroleum (BPCL), said Thursday in an interaction with reporters.

But no concrete decision has been taken yet as discussions have been taken yet as discussions supply chain and logistical challenges that selling two variants of base fuel are likely to pose.

Khanna also said that there is no proposal to fully replace the E20 blend with E10.

“One of the options being explored is can we have E10 fuel for the older vehicles, which is what is being pursued right now. What are the challenges related to the supply, can we handle another grade of MS (motor spirit, or petrol) simultaneously? Yes, those challenges are there and they are being debated, they are being worked out right now. That is the reason why we don’t have

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• THE E20 DEBATE

INDIA ACHIEVED 20% ethanol blending in petrol last year, five years ahead of the deadline

THERE HAS been opposition over the E20 fuel from various quarters, with claims ranging from notable reduction in mileage and engine component wear in older vehicles

ON ITS part, the government has been trying to allay fears, saying that the drop in mileage in older vehicles would be 3-5% at most,



and would be outweighed by E20’s benefits as it is a superior fuel

any ready answer. But definitely, it was one of the options that was being pursued. In what form it would come, to what extent it would come, the details are being worked out at this juncture at different levels,” Khanna said in response to a question from *The Indian Express*.

On August 19, *The Indian Express* had reported quoting sources that early exploratory discussions within the government and the industry were underway on whether E10 petrol can also be retailed for older vehicles alongside the E20 fuel.

Any decision on the matter

is likely to be taken at the government level, and will be binding on all fuel retailers.

India achieved 20% ethanol blending in petrol last year, five years ahead of the ordinal deadline. There has been opposition over the E20 fuel from various quarters, with claims ranging from notable reduction in mileage and engine component wear in older vehicles whose engines were not designed for higher ethanol blends.

On its part, the government has been attempting to allay fears, saying that the drop in mileage in older vehicles would

be 3-5% at most, and would be outweighed by E20’s benefits as it is a superior fuel.

It has also consistently rejected claims that E20 fuel could damage engine components. Questions have also been raised on why motorists aren’t being offered the choice of pure petrol, E10, and E20 fuels. According to sources in the know, the discussions — described as preliminary — are being held on various technical as well as non-technical aspects of the country’s complex fuel retail supply chain.

They said that the backlash from certain quarters against E20 and the lack of choice for consumers, specifically those with older vehicles — particularly two-wheelers — that were certified for E10 petrol, led to the initiation of these discussions.

In July, the government had said that offering multiple grades of base fuel across the country would create an “enormous logistical challenge”, apart from raising costs and reducing operational efficiencies in India’s complex fuel retail network. It also said that the current base fuel E20 is cleaner and superior than pure petrol and lower ethanol-petrol blends.

FULL REPORT ON www.indianexpress.com

FM: Closer India-Canada economic ties important amid global uncertainty

Press Trust of India
Washington, August 27

CLOSER ECONOMIC cooperation between India and Canada has assumed greater significance amid a rapidly changing global landscape marked by geopolitical uncertainty, Union Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman said, calling for stronger partnerships to build resilient, sustainable and inclusive economies.

“The world is going through a profound transformation. There’s just a lot of uncertainty everywhere. And the geopolitical and economic realities are constantly evolving,” Sitharaman said while addressing a joint briefing after the inaugural Economic and Financial Dialogue between India and Canada at Toronto.

Against this backdrop, she said closer economic cooperation between the two countries would be important to build resilient, sustainable and inclusive



Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman with François-Philippe Champagne, Minister of Finance & National Revenue of Canada, in Toronto. PHOTO CREDIT: MINISTRY OF FINANCE

Real Creator IAS Edition https://t.me/+2RvD_RGf9mljMzg1 dialogue between India and Canada reflects the shared ambition to move beyond traditional trade in goods and services and build a deeper economic partnership encompassing investment, finance, capital markets and regulatory cooperation.

Prime Minister Narendra

Modi and his Canadian counterpart have set an ambitious goal for strengthening bilateral ties, giving fresh momentum and strategic direction to the relationship, she said. The discussions with her counterpart François-Philippe Champagne covered three broad areas: macroeconomic developments and domestic policy priorities in both countries; practical avenues for financial-sector cooperation; and broader international and multilateral cooperation on issues of shared interest. Highlighting that India has demonstrated “remarkable macroeconomic resilience”, she said the complementarities between the two economies, along with considerable scope for expanding investment and economic cooperation.

On financial-sector cooperation, she said the two sides explored areas including cross-border payments, financial stability, fintech and capital markets.

S&P affirms ‘BBB’ rating on India; cites infra push, policy stability

Reuters
Bengaluru, August 27

GLOBAL RATINGS agency S&P on Thursday affirmed India’s sovereign ratings at “BBB/A-2” with a “stable” outlook, citing continued policy stability and high infrastructure investment that supports the country’s long-term growth prospects.

The affirmation comes despite risks from higher energy prices, which could strain India’s external balances and inflation outlook given its heavy reliance on imported crude oil. S&P estimates India’s real GDP growth to ease slightly to 6.6% this year, a pace it said remains strong compared with most emerging-market peers amid a broad global slowdown.

Gadkari: India’s EV market to hit Rs 20L cr by 2030

New Delhi: India’s electric vehicle (EV) market is expected to grow to Rs 20 lakh crore by 2030, with the potential to create five crore jobs, Union Minister Nitin Gadkari said on Wednesday.

Addressing a summit organised by the CII-ITC Centre of Excellence for Sustainable Development, Gadkari said that currently 57 lakh electric vehicles are registered in India, with 7% market penetration. “India’s electric vehicle (EV) market will be worth Rs 20 lakh crore by 2030. It will also create five crore jobs by 2030,” he said.

The road transport and highways minister highlighted that India’s two largest two-wheeler vehicle manufacturers, Bajaj Auto and Hero MotoCorp, export more than 50% of vehicles they produce. PTI

SIA to ‘carefully consider’ Air India’s cash infusion pleas

ENS Economic Bureau
New Delhi, August 27

THE BOARD of Singapore Airlines (SIA), which owns 25.1% stake in Air India, will carefully consider any request from the latter for additional capital infusion after considering the SIA group’s other capital requirements as well as Air India’s overall business strategy, the city state’s flag carrier said Thursday.

The comments come amid the loss-making Air India seeking capital infusion from its shareholders Tata Sons and SIA, which has also led to concerns being raised by a member of parliament (MP) in Singapore.

Air India, which is implementing an ambitious and cash-guzzling transformation programme, is also struggling due to external headwinds like the Pakistani airspace closure, West Asia conflict-related disruptions, and sky high fuel prices. The airline recently sought about \$1.5 billion from its shareholders, it is learnt.

“As a significant minority shareholder, Singapore Airlines works with Tata Sons to support Air India’s transformation programme. SIA’s Board will carefully consider any requests for additional capital from Air India, taking into consideration the Group’s other capital requirements and Air

India’s business strategy,” an SIA spokesperson said.

“The SIA Group’s capital allocation follows a disciplined evaluation process that considers its operating cash flow, investment requirements in new aircraft and products, as well as multi-hub investments such as Air India, to support sustainable long-term growth and returns,” he added. In a social media post on Wednesday, Kenneth Tiong, an opposition MP in Singapore’s parliament, raised concerns over Singapore Airlines investing further in Air India, and the consequent impact it could have on Temasek, the Singapore government-owned global investment company that in turn owns Singapore Airlines. “Singapore Airlines owns about a quarter of it (Air India), and Temasek owns most of Singapore Airlines, so this is not only a question for private shareholders. Whichever of the two writes the cheque, it will have a significant impact on Temasek... No one, least of all Singaporeans, owes Air India a living. I will not support, nor expect, any future use of Temasek’s funds to prop up Air India via Singapore Airlines. If Singapore Airlines wants to continue its bet on Air India, it should do so on its own two feet, and not on Temasek’s,” Tiong said.

FULL REPORT ON www.indianexpress.com

Subhash Chandra case: HDFC Bank eyes NCLAT over Rs 6.5 crore order

George Mathew
Mumbai, August 27

HDFC Bank is “exploring an appeal” against an National Company Law Tribunal (NCLT) order approving a repayment plan for Essel Group founder Subhash Chandra that entails a substantive haircut on creditors’ admitted claims.

The NCLT has approved Chandra’s proposal to pay Rs 6.25 crore against total guarantees signed for Rs 22,000 crore.

HDFC Bank said its admitted claim accounted for 3.2% of the total claims and that it was inherited from erstwhile HDFC Ltd prior to the merger of the two entities. The NCLT verdict saved the case from going into bankruptcy. The proceedings concern personal guarantees given by Chandra for borrowings of Essel Group-linked companies. When a promoter gives a personal guarantee for corporate loans, the lender can, subject to the applicable legal process, pursue the guarantor when the underlying borrower defaults. Chandra’s insolvency proceedings were initiated in 2024 following a petition by Indiabulls Housing Finance.

The case therefore goes beyond Zee Entertainment Enterprises. It concerns Chandra’s personal liability arising from guarantees linked to corporate debt. There is a separate corporate insolvency proceedings involving companies associated with the Essel Group, or with regulatory proceedings involving Zee Entertainment and its executives. “Total claim against Subhash Chandra as a personal guarantor, in the personal insolvency proceedings is only Rs 3,992 crore by the objectors of the plan and not Rs 22,000 crore,” Subhash Chandra’s office said in a press statement issued on Thursday. “Out of which, also a claim of Rs 620 crore settled and further Rs 1,063 crore offered to be paid by the borrower entities. The borrowing entities for whom Chandra has provided personal guarantees have till date repaid Rs 43,000 crore. The borrowing entities have assured to settle any other amount which might have left,” it said.

“He (Subhash Chandra) declared his total assets stood at Rs

39,08 crore which he declared in the Parliament of India in 2016, which is a public record. How could a bank take/accept his net worth of Rs 45,888 crore in 2017?” the statement said.

“His personal net worth came down to Rs 31.79 crore in 2024 from Rs 39.08 crore in 2016,” it said. The August 25 order was not the result of a straightforward unanimous decision. A two-member NCLT bench had earlier delivered a split verdict on the repayment plan. With the members divided, Nilesh Sharma, judicial member of the NCLT, acted as the third member to resolve the disagreement.

The third member ultimately sided with approval of the repayment plan. Creditors had mounted strong objections, particularly over the extraordinarily low amount they were being offered. But the tribunal concluded that the objections did not provide sufficient legal grounds to reject the plan. The tribunal reviewed the available financial information and concluded that the approved repayment plan could yield a better outcome than forcing the matter into

bankruptcy. Put simply, the reasoning was pragmatic: recovering Rs 6.5 crore could be preferable to the potentially lower returns from liquidation or bankruptcy.

The creditors’ objection centred on the extraordinarily low recovery. Creditors also questioned whether the debtor’s assets and financial affairs had been examined deeply enough, including whether a forensic investigation should have been conducted. The tribunal, however, did not accept the argument that a forensic investigation was an essential precondition for approving the repayment plan.

The NCLT also emphasised the importance of the commercial decision of creditors. Where creditors have voted on a plan in accordance with the IBC, the tribunal does not ordinarily substitute its own commercial assessment for that decision.

The repayment plan had secured the requisite support from creditors, reportedly receiving approximately 80.81% of the voting share. FULL REPORT ON www.indianexpress.com

BEFORE THE NATIONAL COMPANY LAW TRIBUNAL
AHMEDABAD BENCH, AHMEDABAD
C.A. (CAA)/ 33 (AHM) 2026
In the matter of Sections 230 to 232 read with other applicable provisions of the Companies Act, 2013 and
In the matter of Scheme of Amalgamation of
ACC Limited ("Amalgamating Company") with
Ambuja Cements Limited ("Amalgamated Company")

ACC LIMITED,
a company incorporated under the provisions of the Indian Companies Act, 1913, and having its registered office at Adani Corporate House, Shantigram, Near Vaishno Devi Circle, S. G. Highway, Khodiyar, Ahmedabad, Gujarat – 382 421, India.
CIN: L26940GJ1936PLC149771

... APPLICANT NO. 1 /
AMALGAMATING COMPANY

NOTICE AND ADVERTISEMENT OF NOTICE OF THE MEETING OF THE EQUITY SHAREHOLDERS
(WHICH CONSIST OF PUBLIC SHAREHOLDERS)

Notice is hereby given that by an order dated July 29, 2026 ("Order"), the Hon'ble National Company Law Tribunal, Ahmedabad Bench ("Hon'ble Tribunal") has directed convening of the meeting of the equity shareholders of ACC Limited (hereinafter referred to as the "Amalgamating Company"), for the purpose of considering, and if thought fit, approving the arrangement embodied in the Scheme of Amalgamation of the Amalgamating Company with Ambuja Cements Limited (hereinafter referred to as the "Scheme") pursuant to the provisions of Sections 230-232 of the Companies Act, 2013 ("Act") and other applicable provisions thereof and applicable rules thereunder.
In pursuance of the Order passed by the Hon'ble Tribunal and as directed therein, further Notice is hereby given that a meeting of the equity shareholders of the Amalgamating Company will be held on, Tuesday, September 29, 2026 at 10:30 a.m. (1030 hours) IST through Video Conferencing ("VC")/Other Audio Visual Means ("OAVM") (hereinafter referred to as the "Meeting") in compliance with the applicable laws including circulars issued by the Ministry of Corporate Affairs ("MCA Circulars") from time to time and the Circular No. SEBI/HO/CFD/CFD-PoD-2/P/CIR/2024/133 dated October 3, 2024, issued by the Securities and Exchange Board of India ("Circular issued by SEBI") and the said equity shareholders are requested to attend the Meeting.
The Amalgamating Company has completed the electronic dispatch of the Notice of the Meeting dated August 20, 2026; the explanatory statement as required under Sections 230(3), 232 (1) and (2) and 102 of the Act read with Rule 6 of Companies (Compromises, Arrangements and Amalgamations) Rules, 2016; and the annexures to the explanatory statement which includes the Scheme (collectively referred to as "Particulars") on August 27, 2026, through e-mail. The Particulars were sent through electronic mode to those equity shareholders whose e-mail addresses are registered with Kfin Technologies Limited, the Amalgamating Company's Registrar and Transfer Agent (hereinafter referred to as "Kfin")/depositories/Amalgamating Company and whose names appear in the register of members/list of beneficial owners as on Friday, August 14, 2026. The Particulars are placed on the website of the Amalgamating Company and can be accessed at www.acclimited.com and are also available on the websites of National Stock Exchange of India Limited at www.nseindia.com; Bombay Stock Exchange Limited at www.bseindia.com; Central Depository Services (India) Limited ("CDSL") at www.evotingindia.com; and Kfin at https://crim.fintech.com/bmails/files/24982_ACC_Merger_R1.pdf.
If so desired, copy of the particulars can be obtained free of charge, between 10:30 a.m. to 12:30 p.m. on all working days up to one day prior to the date of the Meeting at the registered office of the Amalgamating Company, or from the office of its advocates, M/s. Singhi & Co., Singhi House, 1, Magnet Corporate Park, Off Sola Bridge, S. G. Highway, Ahmedabad – 380 059, Gujarat, India or by sending a request along with the details of shareholding to the Amalgamating Company by email at acc-investorsupport@adani.com.
Since, the Meeting is being held pursuant to the Order passed by the Hon'ble Tribunal and in compliance of MCA Circulars and Circular issued by SEBI through VC/OAVM, physical attendance of the equity shareholders has been dispensed with. Accordingly, the facility for appointment of proxy by the equity shareholders of the Amalgamating Company is not available at this Meeting.
The Hon'ble Tribunal has appointed Justice Mr. Virendra Singh Gyan Singh Bisht, former member of the National Company Law Tribunal, to be the Chairman of the Meeting.
Mr. Anil S Kadril, Advocate, or in his absence, CS Raimeen Maradiya, Partner, Chirag Shah and Associates, Practicing Company Secretary (Membership No. 11283 & C.P. No. 17554), has been appointed as the scrutintizer to scrutinize the e-voting during the Meeting and the remote e-voting process.
The Scheme, if approved by the equity shareholders will be subject to subsequent approval of the Hon'ble Tribunal and such other regulatory approvals as may be necessary.
NOTICE is further given that:
1. The Amalgamating Company has provided remote e-voting facility to its equity shareholders to enable them to cast their votes electronically and has availed the services of CDSL for providing VC/OAVM facility, remote e-voting and e-voting during the Meeting. Some of the important details regarding remote e-voting are provided below:

EVSN	260824011
Commencement of remote e-voting period	Thursday, September 24, 2026 at 9:00 a.m. IST (0900 hours)
End of remote e-voting period	Monday, September 28, 2026 at 5:00 p.m. IST (1700 hours) The remote e-voting module will be disabled by CDSL thereafter.

2. The e-voting facility will also be made available during the Meeting to enable the equity shareholders who have not cast their vote through remote e-voting, to exercise their voting rights. Equity shareholders who have cast their vote through remote e-voting prior to the Meeting may attend the Meeting but shall not be entitled to cast their vote again.

3. An equity shareholder, whose name is recorded in the register of members or in the list of beneficial owners maintained by Kfin/depositories/Amalgamating Company as on the cut-off date, i.e. Tuesday, September 22, 2026, only shall be entitled to exercise his/her/its voting rights on the resolution proposed in the Notice and attend the Meeting of the equity shareholders. The voting rights of the equity shareholders of the Amalgamating Company shall be in proportion to their share in the paid-up equity share capital of the Amalgamating Company as on cut-off date i.e. Tuesday, September 22, 2026.

4. The Scheme shall be acted upon if a majority of persons representing three-fourth in value of the equity shareholders of the Amalgamating Company voting through remote e-voting and e-voting during the Meeting approve the Scheme, in terms of the provisions of Sections 230-232 of the Act.

5. Further, in accordance with Master Circular No. SEBI/HO/CFD/POD-2/P/CIR/2023/93 dated June 20, 2023 issued by Securities and Exchange Board of India, the Scheme shall be acted upon only if the number of votes cast by the public shareholders (through remote e-voting and e-voting during the Meeting) in favour of the Scheme is more than the number of votes cast by the public shareholders against it.

6. The results, together with the scrutintizer's report, will be displayed at the registered office and on the website of the Amalgamating Company and on the website of CDSL at www.evotingindia.com and shall be communicated to National Stock Exchange of India Limited and to BSE Limited on or before Thursday, October 1, 2026.

7. Information and instructions for attending the Meeting including manner of voting (both remote e-voting and e-voting at the Meeting) by the equity shareholders holding shares in dematerialised mode, physical mode and for equity shareholders who have not registered their e-mail address has been provided in the Notice of the Meeting. The manner in which (a) person who becomes an equity shareholder of the Amalgamating Company after dispatch of the Notice and holding equity shares as on cut-off date (mentioned herein above); (b) equity shareholders who have forgotten the User ID and Password, can obtain/generate the User ID and password, has also been provided in the Notice of the Meeting.

8. Equity shareholders holding equity shares in physical mode, who have not registered/updated their e-mail address with the Amalgamating Company, are requested to register/update their e-mail address by submitting Form ISR-1 (available on the website of the Amalgamating Company at <https://www.acclimited.com/investors/shareholders-information> duly filled and signed along with requisite supporting documents to Kfin at enward_ris@kfintech.com.

9. Equity shareholders holding equity shares in dematerialised mode, who have not registered/updated their e-mail address with their depository participant(s), are requested to register/update their e-mail address with the depository participant(s) where they maintain their demat accounts.

10. Equity shareholders seeking any information with regard to the Scheme or the matter proposed to be considered at the aforesaid Meeting, are requested to write to the Amalgamating Company atleast 3 (three) days before the date of the Meeting through e-mail on acc-investorsupport@adani.com.

11. In case of any difficulty or queries in connection with attending the Meeting through VC/OAVM or casting vote through remote e-voting facility, equity shareholders may contact:

For	Name & Designation	E-mail	Address	Contact No.
E-voting	Mr. Rakesh Dalvi, Sr. Manager (CDSL)	helpdesk.evoting@cdslindia.com	Central Depository Services (India) Limited, A Wing, 25th Floor, Marathon Futurex, Mafatal Mill Compounds, N.M. Joshi Marg, Lower Parel (East), Mumbai – 400 013	1800 21 09911
VC/OAVM				

Sd/-
Justice Mr. Virendra Singh Gyan Singh Bisht,
former member of the National Company Law Tribunal,
Chairman appointed for the Meeting

Dated: August 27, 2026

Sensex	NIFTY	Gold ▼	US Dollar ▲
76,933.59	24,090.85	₹1,58,386	₹95.54
-539.35	-116.90	Silver ▼	Oil ▼
-0.70%	-0.48%	₹2,39,500	\$88.17
NOTE: GOLD, SILVER RATES AS PER INDIA BULLION AND JEWELLERS ASSOCIATION GOLD PER 10G, SILVER PER 1KG; CRUDE OIL (INDIAN BASKET) AS OF AUGUST 26, 2026			

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DAY AFTER ‘HIMALAYAN TSUNAMI’ IN NEPAL: HELICOPTERS DROP AID & SEARCH FOR THOSE ALIVE, FAMILIES PICK UP THE PIECES

‘Can’t explain how big waves were’

For survivors, in just a minute their world turned upside down

Binod Ghimire

Kathmandu, August 27

THE NUMBERS alone reflect the scale of the destruction: Hundreds of people are reported dead so far, with over a thousand others missing, and entire towns have been wiped out after floods swept the Himalayan region on the border between Nepal and Tibet on Wednesday.

But for the survivors, it is the force of the deluge that haunts them. One minute, their lives were routine. The next, the world turned upside down.

Rajan Khatri, 41, a police officer posted at Syabrubesi, one of the riverside villages worst affected by the floods, said he had received a call around 9:10 am local time from a friend warning him that a massive flash flood was heading downstream.

He and his colleagues had no time to react. As soon as he hung up, high waves swept through the police station.

The water flung him out of the building, and he lost consciousness. “One of my senior officers and I were together when the wave struck. I was thrown out, but he was unlucky and was buried or swept away,” he said from a hospital bed in Kathmandu.

“I cannot explain how big the waves were. They engulfed several-meters-high buildings in a fraction of seconds,” he said. “It wasn’t just water. It was a combination of boulders, sand and thick sludge.”

Of the seven people who had been working at his police station, Khatri is one of three to have been found alive. He said he was worried about whether the other four had survived.

After regaining consciousness, he looked around and saw nothing but debris. He said at least 100 houses had been swept away, along with the office of a hydropower project, schools and other government facilities.

• Foreign Nationals Missing in Nepal

As many as 540 foreigners from 31 countries are among the 667 tourists missing in Nepal after the devastation

COUNTRY	MISSING
CHINA	100 +
US	65+
MALAYSIA	55+
UKRAINE	53
BRITAIN	33
AUSTRALIA	25
CANADA	25
SINGAPORE	9
RUSSIA	8
GERMANY	8
NEW ZEALAND	5
SOUTH KOREA	19

REUTERS

Khatri waited amid the debris until his rescue on Thursday morning. He had sustained chest injuries from the force of the floodwaters.

Smriti Ojha, 17, was getting ready for school in Trishuli, in Nepal’s Nuwakot district, when she felt a tremor.

Initially, she thought it was an earthquake, not unlike the one in 2015 that destroyed her family’s home. She rushed out of the house where she lives with her friends. Just as she came out, she saw enormous waves.

“Everyone in the house got out before it was too late, but we couldn’t save anything,” she said from her hospital bed, where she was receiving treatment for a cut on her right foot. Her immediate family, which lives more than five miles from the destruction, is safe, but four of her relatives are missing.

“It was terror,” she said. “I cannot believe everything was swept away before my eyes.”



Real Creator IAS Edition <https://whatsapp.com/channel/0029Van2VRb6RGJOKH6oBd0F>

UK offers funds, responders; King Charles ‘heartbroken’

London: The UK on Thursday offered Nepal 5 million pounds and emergency responders. British PM Andy Burnham described scenes emerging as “devastating” and urged British nationals caught in crisis to follow guidance from local officials.

“It’s a devastating picture that is emerging from Nepal... An offer has been made of emergency responders to head to region... there are a number of British nationals who currently are thought to be missing and we’ll be providing all the support we can to their families,” he said.

King Charles III and Queen Camilla said they were “heartbroken” to hear of the devastating flooding and expressed their “profound sympathy”. “Many in the UK have strong, deep and personal ties to this part of the world,” the royals said. PTI



A drone view shows mud covering buildings following the devastating floods at Trishuli in Nuwakot district, Nepal on Thursday; (Left) A girl cries as she awaits news of relatives missing in Bidur district. PTI/AP



“I am saddened by severe flooding in Nepal & China, which claimed many lives, left people missing, and caused destruction. I extend my condolences to the families of the victims, and wish a swift recovery to those injured. My solidarity is with all affected. The UN is supporting Government-led response. UN teams... are mobilising aid & personnel.”

ANTÓNIO GUTERRES,
SECRETARY-GENERAL OF THE UNITED NATIONS

A drone view shows mud covering buildings following the devastating floods at Trishuli in Nuwakot district, Nepal on Thursday; (Left) A girl cries as she awaits news of relatives missing in Bidur district. PTI/AP

China’s information control could hamper flood rescue efforts in Tibet

Lily Kuo

August 27

AS JOURNALISTS in Nepal gather eyewitness accounts and up-to-date information about the deadly flood that swept entire villages away Wednesday, the scene across border in China could not be more different.

By Thursday, videos taken and posted online by locals, including a widely circulated clip of a mudslide engulfing a border crossing in Gyirong County, in China’s Tibet, were censored on Chinese social media platforms.

More than 500 people were missing in Gyirong, with three confirmed deaths in the county of about 2,000 people. The authorities have provided no details about which villages and settlements in the mostly rural area

have been affected.

Instead, the only information has come from China’s government-controlled state media outlets, where coverage has focused mostly on the rescue efforts. The government has sent members of Chinese military and other emergency workers into the area, the outlets report, along with drones and helicopters.

The *People’s Daily*, the official newspaper of the Chinese Communist Party, led on Thursday with a story about China’s leader, Xi Jinping, ordering that all-out efforts be made to help the victims in Gyirong.

Censorship and tight control of information is common throughout China, but nowhere is that more apparent than in Tibet, which has been under

Chinese control since 1950s and where calls for greater autonomy have erupted into protests.

No foreign journalists are allowed in except on heavily orchestrated government tours. Officials in Tibet have tightened restrictions on Tibetan monks and nuns and expanded policing to prevent any renewed protests.

Tibetans in the region can be detained or arrested for speaking to journalists or posting anything online that is seen as counter to the government narrative, according to rights activists.

“If people are afraid to share that information, or if their posts are removed,” he said, “potentially useful information may not reach families, relief workers or the wider public.” NYT

Qatar PM pursues mediation in Iran as US ramps up ‘economic war’

Reuters

Cairo, Dubai, August 27

THE PRIME minister of US ally Qatar visited Tehran on Thursday in a bid to revive diplomacy as the US and Iran traded re-primations over Washington’s latest sanctions drive, described by one Iranian official as “all-out economic war”.

The visit comes as the war nears its sixth month with fighting largely paused but no diplomatic breakthrough in sight. Both sides are at odds over control of the Strait.

The White House said there were currently no negotiations happening between the United States and Iran as Tehran had not yet “come to the table in a meaningful way”. Iran has repeatedly said it has never left the negotiating table.

Qatar’s Prime Minister

Sheikh Mohammed bin Abdulrahman Al Thani, who is also his country’s foreign minister, held talks in Tehran with Iranian Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi, according to Iran’s foreign ministry channel on Telegram.

The two discussed a proposed phased framework that includes establishing a temporary joint Iranian-Omani shipping corridor through strait and carrying out a joint project to clear mines from the waterway, Qatar’s foreign ministry said.

A memorandum of understanding reached between the US and Iran in June to end the conflict broke down in part because of differences over the Strait between Iran and Oman.

Tehran has said the Strait will remain shut unless the US meets Iranian conditions agreed under the June interim ceasefire. Those conditions in-

clude an end to the US blockade on Iranian ports, compensation and removal of sanctions.

The two officials also reviewed the latest developments in the region and efforts to de-escalate tensions and create conditions for dialogue, the Qatari ministry said.

White House press secretary Karoline Leavitt said on Thursday that President Donald Trump “continues to retain all options on the table” with regard to Iran. “We’ve had Operation Epic Fury to destroy their military. Now we have Operation Economic Outcast to destroy their economy,” Leavitt said in an interview with *Fox News*.

“No negotiations are happening right now, and this will continue until the president feels that maybe they come to the table in a meaningful way,” Leavitt said.

Trial for accused mastermind of 9/11 attacks set for June 2028

Washington: A US Air Force judge on Wednesday ordered Khalid Sheikh Mohammed, the accused mastermind of the September 11, 2001, attacks on the United States, and three co-defendants to go on trial before a military tribunal in June 2028.

The trial-scheduling order entered by Air Force Lieutenant Colonel Michael Schrama marked the latest milestone in a military prosecution beset by two decades of legal deadlock surrounding the four detainees held in Guantanamo Bay, Cuba.

Last month, a US appeals court had refused to allow Mohammed and two of his co-defendants to plead guilty under agreements that would have spared them the death penalty. REUTERS

Russia bombards nine Ukraine cities in massive overnight drone strikes

Associated Press

Kyiv, August 27

RUSSIA BOMBARDED cities across Ukraine with missiles and drones in an overnight onslaught that ran into the daylight hours Thursday, when explosions echoed around Kyiv through the morning.

The Russian Defence Ministry said its forces carried out a “massive” strike on targets in nine Ukrainian cities that began after nightfall on Wednesday. It described the targets as military-related, including industrial facilities, oil refineries, logistics hubs and port infrastructure.

Civilian areas, including apartment buildings, suffered damage. The barrage killed a 78-year-old woman in the southern Zaporizhzhia region and

another person in the northern Kharkiv region, with at least 14 people reported wounded elsewhere, Ukrainian officials said.

“Russia continues to invest in missiles and in expanding its war, which means more countermeasures are needed,” Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy said, noting promises earlier this week by European countries to provide more air defence assistance. “It is important that these (measures) are also supplemented by additional ballistic missile defence packages” through European purchases of weapons from US, he said.

Zelenskyy was due to visit neighbouring Moldova on Thursday to mark its national day commemorating its 1991 declaration of independence from the Soviet Union.

• BRIEFLY

SERBIA

‘Butcher of Bosnia’ Ratko Mladic, convicted of genocide, dies at 83



Ratko Mladic was captured in 2011 and put on trial for genocide

RATKO MLADIC, the former Bosnian Serb general whose actions during the Balkan wars of the 1990s led to him being called the “Butcher of Bosnia” and who was held responsible for Europe’s deadliest massacre since World War II, the killing of some 8,000 Muslim men and boys at Srebrenica in 1995, has died. He was 83. His death was announced on Thursday by Serbian state media. Mladic was captured on May 26, 2011, in a farming village north of Belgrade, Serbia’s capital, after almost 16 years as a fugitive, ending one of the longest manhunts in modern history. His 2017 conviction by an international tribunal on charges of genocide, crimes against humanity and war crimes marked the end of a dark and bloody chapter. NYT

FRANCE

2 killed after car rams into crowd, suspect arrested

A DRIVER deliberately rammed their car into a group of people in northern France, killing two people and injuring nine others, authorities said. The incident Wednesday night in Caen isn’t being treated by officials as a terrorist attack. Caen Mayor Aristide Olivier told said it seemed to be the result of “a fight that turned bad.” The top regional official, Calvados Prefect David Claviere, initially said that one person was killed. His office on Thursday revised the death toll to two. The suspected driver has been arrested, according to Claviere, who said the man was born in Russia. AP

UNITED STATES

Lake Ontario is Lake America: Trump signs it

US PRESIDENT Donald Trump signed an executive order on Thursday to rename Lake Ontario as Lake America, a change he said would take effect immediately. A White House aide said the order directs the Department of the Interior and Secretary Doug Burgum to make the change. One of the five Great Lakes of North America, Lake Ontario borders both the Canadian province of Ontario and the US state of New York. Canadian Prime Minister Mark Carney’s office did not immediately respond to a request for comment on the proposed name change. REUTERS

• META TO TIGHTEN AGE CHECKS, CAP UNDER-18 USE AT TWO HOURS DAILY, BLOCK ACCESS FROM MIDNIGHT TO 6AM AND HIDE ‘LIKE’ COUNTS ON POSTS

Time limits and a midnight cutoff: Meta’s new rules for kids

Barbara Ortutay & Wyatt Grantham-Philips

Oakland, August 27

KIDS UNDER 18 will soon see changes to their Instagram and Facebook experiences under an \$18 billion settlement Meta Platforms reached with 48 US states.

Besides the money, Meta has agreed to strengthen age estimates to keep children under 13 off its platforms, place teens in age-appropriate accounts, impose a two-hour daily limit for users under 18, block access from midnight to 6 am and hide “like” counts.

The safeguards apply only

in the United States, with most remaining for 10 years.

Critics acknowledged the measures go further than Meta has previously gone on child safety, but cautioned they will not solve its problems overnight.

Arturo Béjar, a former Meta engineering director and the first witness in the federal trial, called the settlement a “significant milestone” but said parents should not consider Instagram entirely safe for children.

He criticised the agreement for allowing Meta to define harm and urged Meta to address addictive content recommendations. Teens may stop



Real Creator IAS Edition https://t.me/+2RvD_RGf9mljMzg1 using the platform after two hours but remain distressed because its design can leave them craving more.

Meta said users over 18 can adopt some controls individ-

law. Béjar testified that Meta had taken a “don’t ask, don’t tell” approach toward children under 13, despite having systems to detect fake accounts. He said there were “no goals, no metrics” for checking suspected underage users.

Many safeguards will be enabled by default, including the two-hour limit, which requires parental permission to disable, and the midnight-to-6 a.m. restriction. But features such as turning off video autoplay or displaying posts chronologically will remain opt-in.

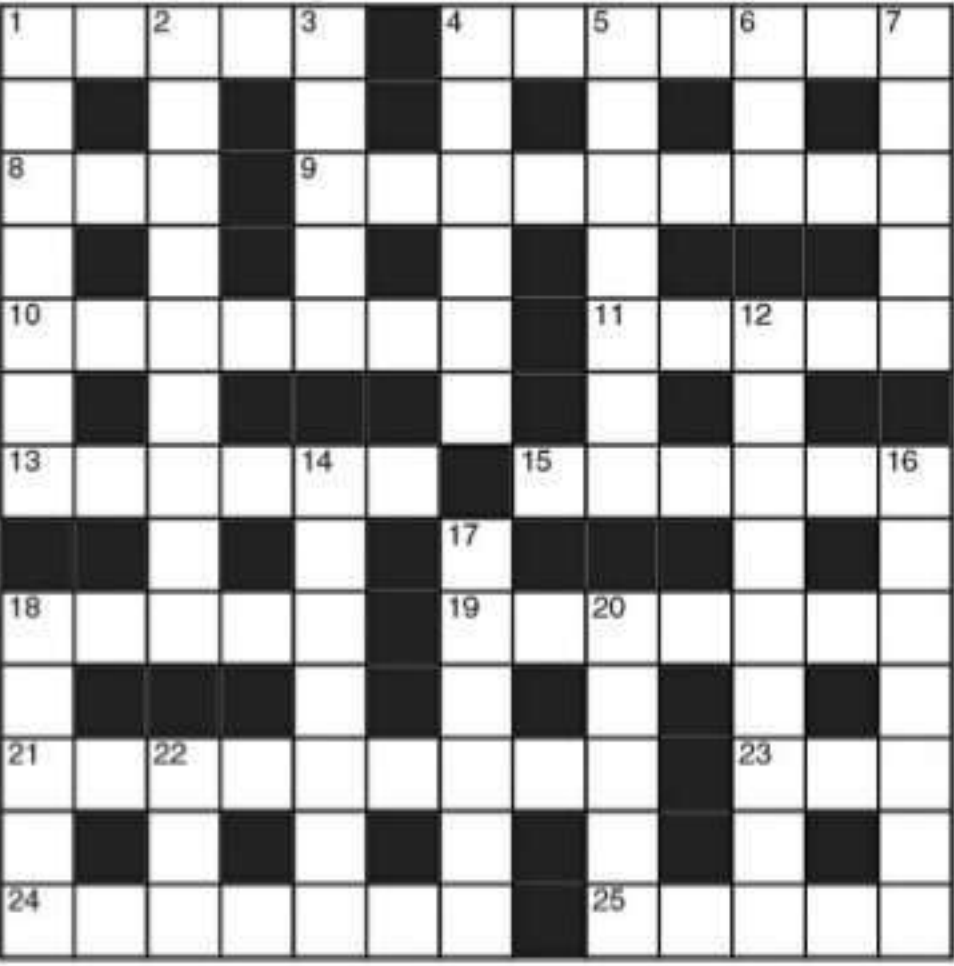
Josh Golin, executive director of online safety nonprofit

Fairplay, said the deal focused too much on giving parents tools rather than restricting harmful features. He criticised the lack of default limits on recommendation algorithms that can connect children to predators or lead down “dangerous rabbit holes.”

Yaël Eisenstat, of the Cybersafety Research Center, said it was too early to know whether all desired changes would happen, noting that many past safety tools had proved ineffective. Still, she called the settlement monumental because it shows feasible options exist. AP

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CROSSWORD



ACROSS
1 Type of Italian capitalist? (5)
4 Return ticket to the Australian bush? (7)
8 It is thought wise to be seen at night (3)
9 Youngster put to bed and left alone (9)
10 Motion for bail due to be heard (7)
11 One studies images (5)
13 One's characteristics begin holding one back (6)
15 Much time and trouble is taken in its drafting (6)
18 Pass out with many a twitch (5)
19 Large vessel used as a pressure cooker (7)
21 Yet it's wrong to imitate anything like this (9)
23 Pile of carpets (3)
24 Individuals appearing in court (7)
25 Like to declare in test (5)

DOWN
1 Draconian law give Brazilian city discretion (4,3)
2 Mother takes in the older variety of play (9)
3 Article sent up by Robert — a rich man (5)
4 It plays a vital part in a tent (6)
5 Impressive work by the bookmaker (7)
6 Wild cat exploit (3)
7 Rising United Kingdom party's prestige (5)
12 They add grace to manners perhaps (9)
14 Many carried away by it lost their heads (7)
16 A prize for waste (7)
17 States times for customs (6)
18 Groups of files for example dropping in (5)
20 A minor player makes more (5)
22 Shut up and write (3)

SOLUTIONS CROSSWORD 6078 ACROSS: 1 Grandstand, 8 Clout, 9 Ammeter, 10 Nebular, 11 Arrow, 12 Insist, 14 Adders, 17 Elsie, 19 Escapee, 21 Emerged, 22 Verne, 23 Put on an act **DOWN:** 2 Rhombus, 3 Natal, 4 Starry, 5 Amband, 6 Deter, 7 Crowd scene, 8 Considered, 13 Sleight, 15 Empiric, 16 Redden, 18 Steep, 20 Coven

JUMBLLED WORDS

Given below are four jumbled words. Solve the jumbles to make proper words and move them to the respective circles below. Select the letters in the shaded circles and jumble them to get the answer for the given quip.

Happiness isn't something you experience; it's something you — Oscar Levant (8)

ALVEE

ELYER

EEGRMR

EFLUBM

remember - Oscar Levant

ANSWER: Happiness isn't something you experience, it's something you

OVER THE HEDGE



CALVIN & HOBBS



MARVIN



DIFFICULTY LEVEL 3s INSTRUCTIONS

To solve a Sudoku puzzle, every digit from 1 to 9 must appear in each of the nine vertical columns, in each of the nine horizontal rows and in each of the nine boxes.

DIFFICULTY LEVEL

1s = Very easy; 2s = Easy; 3s = Medium; 4s = Hard; 5s = Very Hard; 6s = Genius

SUDOKU 6424

5	2	3				6	1	
		4				2	7	9
				8	9		3	
3				4				2
	9		2	7				
8		7	1				2	
	6	5				4	7	1

SOLUTION SUDOKU 6423

8	4	5	7	6	1	9	3	2
9	3	2	4	5	8	1	6	7
7	1	6	2	3	9	4	5	8
4	7	9	5	1	3	2	8	6
3	6	8	9	7	2	5	1	4
2	5	1	8	4	6	7	9	3
6	9	7	1	8	4	3	2	5
5	2	3	6	9	7	8	4	1
1	8	4	3	2	5	6	7	9

ROYAL STARS

ARIES (MAR 21 - APR 20): This is a challenging day at work. Unexpected problems, including staff shortages, might occur. People are also touchy. Be mindful of everything you say and do. Tonight: Privacy.

TAURUS (APR 21 - MAY 21): Today you need to keep track of your money because something unexpected could impact your wealth through damage, loss or theft. This is an accident-prone day for your kids. Social plans will change. Tonight: Friendships.

GEMINI (MAY 22 - JUNE 21): This is a challenging day! It's the classic day for rebellion against authority. Your home routine might change. Equipment might break. Tread carefully. Tonight: Be modest.

CANCER (JUNE 22 - JULY 23): Pay attention to everything you say and do today because this is an accident-prone day. Think before you speak, because you might feel controlled by your impulses. Be aware of everything you do. Keep things simple. Tonight: Check your finances.

LEO (JULY 24 - AUG 23): This is a challenging day in terms of dealing with your money as well as friends and groups. Fortunately, you will be diplomatic and skillful when speaking with others. By nature, you are quick to see the big picture, and this will help. Tonight: Cooperate.

VIRGO (AUG 24 - SEP 23): Today the Sun is in your sign at odds with Uranus and the Moon. This is not easy. You might suddenly have an argument. Sudden upsets are classic. Equipment or cars might have sudden breakdowns. Keep your eyes open to avoid accidents. Tonight: Work.

LIBRA (SEP 24 - OCT 23): This is a tough day, but there are some blessings. For the most part, your work routine might be interrupted. Travel plans might suddenly change. It's the kind of day where you take two steps forward and one step back. Tonight: Get better organised.

SCORPIO (OCT 24 - NOV 23): Unexpected upsets with friends, groups and financial institutions might take place today. People might quarrel about assets or money. This is an accident-prone day for your kids. Tonight: Socialise.

SAGITTARIUS (NOV 24 - DEC 22): This is the classic day for a public argument or a rebellion. Fortunately, the position of the Sun makes you look good. You could end up with egg on your face. Don't throw your weight around. Be patient and tolerant with others. Tonight: Relax at home.

CAPRICORN (DEC 23 - JAN 20): Tread carefully, because this is an accident-prone day. Whatever happens will be swift and come right out of the blue. Pay attention to everything you say and do, especially related to your work. Travel will be interrupted. Tonight: Intense conversations.

AQUARIUS (JAN 21 - FEB 19): Today is full of all kinds of unexpected events and little rebellions; this wild energy will likely impact your possessions and money. Social plans will suddenly change. Parents must be extra vigilant about their kids. Tonight: Check your belongings.

PISCES (FEB 20 - MAR 20): Today the Moon is in your sign at odds with the Sun, Mercury and Uranus. Today is the classic day for little rebellions and accidents. Equipment and cars might break down. Family arguments might take place. Tonight: You're in charge.

CORPORATE BRIEFS

EDUCATION



AMITY UNIVERSITY - LEADERSHIP FORUM
Amity International Business School, Amity University Noida, organized the CEO & CHRO Leadership Forum and Awards 2026 to strengthen academia-industry engagement on leadership, innovation, AI, talent, and employability. Dr. Gurinder Singh, Group Vice Chancellor, highlighted Amity's integration of technology, case-based learning, NEP 2020, and industry exposure. The CEO Forum featured leaders from Tata Consumer Products, Mahindra Finance, Volvo Cars India, Deloitte, and HDFC Bank, who discussed "The New Leadership Equation: Driving Growth through People, Purpose & AI," emphasizing the importance of human values, trust, wisdom, and responsible AI. The CHRO Forum explored "People, Purpose & Possibilities: Reimagining Human Capital in the Age of AI," with senior HR leaders sharing insights. Distinguished leaders were also felicitated for excellence in strategic leadership, human capital, consumer business, and industry contribution.



SARLA CHOPRA DAV PUBLIC SCHOOL - EVENT
Sarla Chopra DAV Public School, Noida hosted the 18th edition of 'VIBGYOR - A Colourful Fiesta', a vibrant inter-school extravaganza. The fiesta witnessed enthusiastic participation from nearly 300 students from around 20 schools across Delhi-NCR and Noida. The event featured competitions in sports, sustainable fashion, music, dance, fitness, art, poetry, literature and technology. It concluded with a prize distribution ceremony celebrating talent, creativity and stellar performances. Principal Mrs. Upasana Sharma motivated the students and expressed gratitude to the distinguished judges. Her talents. She also expressed heartfelt gratitude to the distinguished judges.



NIET - EVENT
Noida Institute of Engineering and Technology, Greater Noida, participated in the QS I-GAUGE National Summit on AI in Indian Education, held on recently at The Leela, Gandhinagar, Gujarat, with support from MeitY, Government of India. Dr. Neema Agarwal, Additional Managing Director, NIET, joined the Presidential Roundtable on "Crafting the Next-Generation Graduate: University Leadership for an AI-Driven Future." The summit brought together academic leaders and experts to discuss responsible AI adoption in higher education, focusing on access, equity, excellence and ethics. Dr. Agarwal's participation reflected NIET's commitment to future-ready education, responsible innovation, employability, and human-centric learning in an AI-driven landscape.



JIIT NOIDA - INTERNATIONAL SYMPOSIUM
The 30th International Symposium on VLSI Design and Test (VDATE 2026) was inaugurated at Jaypee Institute of Information Technology (JIIT), Noida, from 20-22 August 2026, themed "Advancing Intelligent, Secure and Quantum-Ready Semiconductor Systems." Hosted by JIIT with leading Delhi-NCR institutions and supported by VLSI Society of India and IEEE Uttar Pradesh Section, the symposium brings together academia, industry and researchers. Chief Guest Ms. Sunita Verma, MeitY, and Guest of Honour Dr. Kamaljeet Singh, SCL Mohali, highlighted India's semiconductor ambitions. Discussions focused on AI, chiplets, hardware security, advanced packaging, silicon photonics and quantum technologies.



K.R. MANGALAM UNIVERSITY - ORIENTATION
The University organised 'Aarambh 2026' Orientation Day to welcome new students. Chancellor Padma Shri Prof. Dinesh Singh highlighted the impact of Artificial Intelligence and urged students to contribute to Viksit Bharat @2047 through innovation. Chief Guest Mr. Ankur Warikoo encouraged creative thinking, adaptability and entrepreneurship. Vice-Chancellor Prof. (Dr.) Anil Kumar Saini emphasised values, responsibility and NEP 2020's vision of future-ready education. Startups from the University's Business Incubator received Letters of Intent, while the Student Council and clubs were recognised. Singer Akasa Singh's performance added vibrancy to celebrations.



HRIT UNIVERSITY - ORIENTATION
The University organised an Orientation Program for the Faculty of Pharmacy and Pharmaceutical Sciences. The event began with lamp lighting and Saraswati Vandana, followed by introductions to the University. Senior officials guided students on academics, attendance, skill development, placements, scholarships, examinations and discipline. Senior students shared experiences and entertained the gathering with musical performances. The highlight was the Pharmacist's Oath, administered to students, marking the beginning of their professional journey. The programme concluded with a vote of thanks by Shikha Parmar, reinforcing the University's commitment to holistic learning.



GALGOTIAS UNIVERSITY - EVENT
The University hosted a 200-member delegation from Yamanashi Prefecture, Japan, led by Governor Kotaro Nagasaki, marking a significant step towards strengthening India-Japan academic, research and workforce collaboration. Dr. Dhruv Galgotia, CEO, Galgotias University, welcomed the delegation and highlighted opportunities for global careers and joint research in clean energy. The visit witnessed the signing of an MoU with the Yamanashi Prefectural Government and a Letter of Intent with the University of Yamanashi, focusing on talent mobility and clean-energy research. Delegates engaged in discussions on green hydrogen, healthcare education, student exchanges and skilling, and toured advanced facilities in AI, drones and semiconductors. Both sides reaffirmed their commitment to student and faculty exchanges, collaborative research, innovation and clean-energy initiatives.



KIET UNIVERSITY - INTERNATIONAL CONFERENCE
Hosted its 10th International Conference - ICRIPI'2K26 on "Redefining Innovative Practices in the Age of AI" recently. Organized with international partners including Southwestern Oklahoma State University, INTI International University & Colleges, and The George Washington University, the conference brought together academicians, researchers, and industry experts. Vinita Singh Sahay, Director, IIM Bodh Gaya, graced the event as Chief Guest. Discussions explored AI's impact on business, education, healthcare, sustainability, and society. With 12 technical tracks and over 100 research papers, the conference promoted knowledge exchange, global collaboration, and responsible AI innovation.



IMS DIA - ORIENTATION
IMS Design & Innovation Academy (IMS DIA), Noida, welcomed Batch of 2026 with Parambh, its orientation held August 18, 2026. Dr. Nair and Dr. Nimisha welcomed attendees; Nehal and Apoorva presented on DIA, followed by a lamp-lighting ceremony with Ritu and Mr. Nair. VP Chirag Gupta spoke on nurturing creativity through observation and experimentation. Students joined Sasi Menon's workshop, "Exploring Perception: The Magic of Imagination," while parents attended Yash's "DIA - Calendar of Opportunities." Performances by DIA's Dance, Music and Fashion Clubs, plus a closing DJ session, welcomed the new cohort into DIA's creative community.

SRI LANKA VS INDIA, SECOND TEST

Four wickets from a series sweep, India run into immovable obstacle Dinusha

Twin centuries and a stubborn lower order turned a probable 2-0 result into a hard-earned 1-0 series win

Shankar Narayan
Mumbai, August 27

IN THE middle of the 104th over, Keshara Nuwantha needed medical attention from the physio. India had, by then, bowled 31 overs on the fifth morning in Colombo, and still couldn't prise apart the stubborn pairing of Sonal Dinusha and Nuwantha. The clock ticked, but the wickets refused to come.

It had reached the point where Rishabh Pant tried swapping the bails, before Dhruv Jurel went a step further and swapped the stumps, perhaps hoping a small alteration might somehow change India's fortunes. It was a small act, but a telling one. India had become that desperate.

Nuwantha eventually fell soon after lunch, briefly offering India the opening they'd been waiting for.

The pitch remained stubbornly unresponsive, and Sri Lanka's lower order refused to give in. Shubman Gill's decision to enforce the follow-on had looked logical after India reduced Sri Lanka to 229 for 6. Four wickets on the final morning appeared well within reach. The bowlers kept Sri Lanka under pressure, but couldn't finish the innings before the hosts had done enough to survive. India had hoped Sri Lanka might dangle a carrot and set a stiff target. It never came.

Those four wickets looked simple enough on paper, but proved incredibly hard to find in practice. The pitch offered only occasional help, Sri Lanka's lower order refused to budge, and Dinusha seemed determined to keep India waiting. The spinners toiled almost relentlessly. The most experienced of the trio, Ravindra Jadeja, bowled 38.3 overs and finished with 3 for 94. He found enough drift and occasional turn to remain a threat, but never the sustained assistance that would have made the pressure tell.

His dismissal of Lahiru Kumara was one of India's few late rewards. A ball spun sharply in, struck Kumara on the pad and lobbed up, and Yashasvi Jaiswal reacted quickly to hold a one-handed catch at short leg. Kumara had faced 90 balls for his 12, soaking up valuable time for Sri Lanka.

Manav Suthar, who bowled the most overs in the second innings, 41, was similarly industrious, varying his pace and flight and repeatedly asking questions. India could have been more attacking at times, though, particularly against the tail: fuller lengths, tighter fields, more pressure around the bat.

One missed opportunity summed it up. Kumara slog-swept Suthar towards Jurel at

● **Scorecard**

SRI LANKA vs INDIA

COLOMBO

TOSS: India won, chose to bat

INDIA (503/9 DECLARED)

SRI LANKA 290 & (FOLLOWING ON) 0/N-229/6

Sonal Dinusha not out

133 (264b, 8x4, 2x6)

Keshara Nuwantha c Jurel b Suthar

46 (150b, 4x4)

Prabath Jayasuriya c Jurel b Jadeja

2 (28b)

Lahiru Kumara c Jaiswal b Jadeja

12 (90b, 1x4)

Asitha Fernando not out

0 (24b)

● EXTRAS (b 7, lb 8, nb 7, w 3)

25

● TOTAL (154 Overs)

429/9d

● FoW: 7-330 (Keshara Nuwantha, 104.4 ov), 8-355 (Prabath Jayasuriya, 116.3 ov), 9-402 (Lahiru Kumara, 144.4 ov)

● BOWLING: Prasidh Krishna 18.3-3-57-1; Mohammed Siraj 15-7-26-1; Manav Suthar 41-7-121-3; Saransh Jain 37-4-98-1; Ravindra Jadeja 38.3-4-94-3; Shubman Gill 2-0-8-0; Yashasvi Jaiswal 1-0-9-0; Dhruv Jurel 1-0-1-0

deep mid-wicket, who ran in and dived, but the ball landed just short.

There was an element of unfamiliarity too. Neither Suthar nor debutant Saransh Jain had previously faced the challenge of bowling a top side out in the third innings of a Test.

It was a very different examination from bowling in the first innings. The pitch was more tired, the batsmen knew their only task was survival, and every over carried greater significance. For Suthar and Jain, this was an experience being learnt in real time.

India's frustration was that Sri Lanka's resistance wasn't merely about blocking. Dinusha made them pay whenever they strayed

Jain bowled 37 overs and finished with 1 for 98. He was economical enough at times, and got the odd ball to turn, but Dinusha nullified his threat comfortably.

The seamers faced a different challenge. Mohammed Siraj, disciplined throughout, finished with 1 for 26 from 15 overs. He probed the channel, made Dinusha play, and kept things tight, but the surface offered little consistent movement. Once the Sri Lankan batsmen settled, spin became India's principal weapon in trying to force a result.

India's frustration was that Sri Lanka's resistance wasn't merely about blocking. Dinusha made them pay whenever they strayed. Heswep, reverse-swept and attacked when the opportunity presented itself, while knowing



Sonal Dinusha scored 133 runs from 264 balls, getting a century in both innings and earning a hard-fought draw for Sri Lanka. PTI

when to shut the door and simply defend.

By the time he reached his hundred, Dinusha had faced 196 balls. It was his second century of the match, centuries in both innings, placing him in rare company. More importantly, it changed the complexion of the game. India knew the chance of a 2-0 win was diminishing with every passing over.

That was the cruellest part. Nuwantha's dismissal had briefly raised the possibility of a collapse, but Kumara and Dinusha made sure it didn't happen.

Every time India looked close to opening the door, another Sri Lankan batsman found a way to keep it shut.

By the final hour, the desperation had drained from India's body language. There was little chirping, little urgency, just bowlers going through the motions and batsmen eating into the overs before the game could be called off. Sri Lanka declared at 429 for 9, Dinusha unbeaten on 133. The draw had been secured.

For India, it was a missed opportunity of considerable magnitude. They had begun the final day knowing that bowling Sri Lanka out quickly and chasing the target down would have completed a 2-0 series sweep, and boosted their WTC final qualification chances.

Instead, they left Colombo having won the series 1-0, their bowlers having put in the effort without finding the breakthroughs they needed on Day 5. Sri Lanka had dangled no carrot, offered no chase, and survived when India had hoped they would fall.

Why a draw in Colombo could end up costing India a World Test C'ship final spot

Shankar Narayan
Mumbai, August 27

INDIA'S WORLD Test Championship (WTC) final qualification chances took a small hit after the second Test against Sri Lanka in Colombo ended in a draw on Thursday. The result left the Shubman Gill-led side in fifth place in the 2025-27 WTC standings.

The draw left India with a points percentage (PCT) of 51.52, with Australia, South Africa, New Zealand and Bangladesh occupying the four spots above them in the table. A win in Colombo would have taken their PCT to 63.33 and moved them up to fourth.

India now have seven Tests left in this WTC cycle. They will play two Tests in New Zealand in November, before returning home for a five-Test series against Australia in January.

Winning six of those seven would give India 140 points and a PCT of 64.81; winning all seven would give them 152 points and a PCT of 70.37.

Even seven wins, though, wouldn't guarantee India a place in the final, since their position will also depend on how the teams above them perform. Despite the draw in Colombo, Gill remained optimistic about India's WTC final qualification. "We are going to

● World Test Championship standings

TEAM	M	W	L	D	PTS	%
Australia	10	8	2	0	96	80.00
South Africa	4	3	1	0	36	75.00
New Zealand	6	4	1	1	52	72.22
Bangladesh	6	3	2	1	40	55.56
India	11	5	4	2	68	51.52

New Zealand in November, so that's a good series for us, and then we've got a good home series coming, against Australia. So hopefully if we have a good New Zealand series, as long as we have a chance, we always keep believing, and hopefully we'll make it to the finals," he said at the post-match presentation.

India haven't won a Test in New Zealand on their last two tours, in 2014 and 2020. Their last Test win there came in 2009, when they beat New Zealand in Hamilton and went on to win the series 1-0. They have lost their last two home series too, against South Africa and New Zealand, by 2-0 and 3-0.

Australia continue to lead the WTC table with a PCT of 80.00, after beating Bangladesh in the second Test at Mackay. Defending champions South Africa are second with 75.00, while New Zealand are third with 72.22.

'I won't say it backfired': Gill on follow-on that didn't pay dividends

Express News Service
Mumbai, August 27

INDIA CAPTAIN Shubman Gill defended his decision to enforce the follow-on against Sri Lanka despite the second Test ending in a draw, insisting it was the right call given the weather situation and the match scenario.

After taking a 213-run first-innings lead, India asked Sri Lanka to bat again but were unable to claim the 10 wickets as the hosts batted almost two days in their second innings to save the game. Gill said the decision was made with rain in mind and rejected suggestions that it had backfired.

"I won't say that the follow-on backfired. We fielded for about 250 overs. They bowled around 130 overs. Around 70 overs were lost because of rain," Gill told reporters after Day 5 on Thursday.

"We were also anticipating whether Days 4 and 5 would be possible or not. We wanted to take that chance. Either we bat one or one-and-a-half sessions on Day 4, make 200 runs, give them a target of around 400, or give them the follow-on and then score another 100 runs or whatever."

The team didn't want to take any chances with the weather, given that every match is crucial in the context of the World Test Championship (WTC) final race.

"If we hadn't enforced the follow-on and it had rained, you would have asked why we didn't give the follow-on because everyone knew it was going to rain. You can always think about this decision in hindsight, but you have to make the best decision possible in the situation you are in. They (Sri Lanka) played really well. Some things didn't go our way," the skipper said.

Gill, however, praised his players for maintaining their intensity throughout their marathon stint in the field.

"It gets very frustrating. You start questioning yourself - was the follow-on the best decision or not? But then you have to go back to that moment and ask yourself: Did I take the best decision at that moment? After that, you can't do anything about it. You just have to keep trying your best. I think we did that. We tried all that we could."

"From the players, you can

The team didn't want to take any chances with the weather, given that every match is crucial in the context of the WTC final race

expect only one thing — giving 100 percent. I don't think there was any lack of intensity or effort. The spinners bowled 50-60 overs on the trot. Fielding for three days in these conditions, in this heat, is not easy. So in terms of effort, I would say 10 on 10 for the effort and the intent," he said.

Regaining rhythm

The captain dismissed concerns over Mohammed Siraj's fitness after the fast bowler sent down only 26 overs across the match, explaining that he was gaining rhythm after a lengthy break.

"Siraj wasn't injured. He was playing after almost a couple of months. When someone comes back after one-and-a-half or two months, it takes time to get back into rhythm. Even in the first Test, we felt the pace was slow. But sometimes, once you play, you come back into rhythm," he said.

Gill reserved special praise for left-arm spinner Manav Suthar, who finished as the leading wicket-taker in the series with 16 scalps.

"He's been the pick of our bowlers. Even when things are not happening, he's been our go-to bowler. Especially this series, he's made things happen for us. He's created chances, which is what I want as a captain. Wickets are never guaranteed, but you expect your bowlers to create chances."

"It should always feel like a wicket can come. I think he did that brilliantly," he opined.

A 2-0 series triumph would have boosted India's prospects of qualifying for the WTC final but Gill felt his team remained in contention despite staying in fifth spot in the table.

"I still think we've got a pretty good chance to qualify for the WTC. If we play the New Zealand series well, hopefully by the time the Australia series comes, if we're in a situation where we just have to win that series, we'll be in a good position," he felt.



Shubman Gill said the follow-on call was made with rain in mind. PTI

● NEXT GENERATION

Sehwag, Dravid to play for India U-19: 'Backfoot punch, cut just like Viru's'

Shuvaditya Bose
New Delhi, August 27

SEHWAG AND Dravid will be batting together for India. Again.

Fans could be forgiven a jolt of déjà vu three weeks from now, when two iconic surnames return to the blue jersey. India U-19's squad for next month's series against their Australian counterparts was announced on Thursday, featuring Aaryavir Sehwag and Anvay Dravid — sons of Virender Sehwag and Rahul Dravid, respectively.

While Anvay has represented India at this level before, it will be the debut series in blue for Aaryavir. The teenager has been a consistent presence for Delhi U-19, most memorably scoring 297 against Meghalaya in the 2024 Cooch Behar Trophy. Had he scored 23 more, he would have surpassed his father's highest

Test score of 319 — and, per a pact with his father, earned himself a Ferrari before he became eligible to drive one.

Yogesh Nagar, Delhi U-19 coach, could sense the disappointment. Not at missing a Ferrari, but a triple hundred.

"Aaryavir was not satisfied after scoring 297. Anyone else would have been, but he has a hunger for runs that is rarely quenched. He lamented missing a triple century and we had to console him by saying it didn't matter. But moments like those tell you who is going to make it big and who is not," Nagar recalls in a conversation with *The Indian Express*.

For Nagar, Aaryavir's India U-19 selection completes a peculiar circle of life.

"I have had the unique opportunity of playing under Viru bhai's captaincy in the IPL, and am now coaching his son for Delhi U-19. I try to teach my boys what Viru bhai taught

me during our Delhi Dare-devils days. I have passed on his father's teachings to Aaryavir."

Having seen the two generations of Sehwags from close quarters, Nagar feels there are unmistakable similarities.

"Aaryavir's backfoot game is just like his father's. You could figure out that this is Virender Sehwag's son just by his batting technique."

Jaswant Rai, Nagar's predecessor with Delhi U-19, had only a handful of training sessions with Aaryavir. Yet, they were enough to stir memories of an old friend.

"Viru and I played a lot of matches together. When I first saw Aaryavir, my immediate reaction was: like father, like son. The same backfoot punch, the same cut shot," Rai, who is also Arshdeep Singh's childhood coach, tells this newspaper.

Aaryavir carries the sur-



Aaryavir Sehwag scored 297 for Delhi Under-19 in a Cooch Behar Trophy match against Meghalaya Under-19. WEST DELHI LIONS

name but not the ego that could easily have accompanied it.

"The most important thing is that he does not have the attitude of a star kid. There is no ego whatsoever. He knows that only runs will take him to the big stage," Nagar says.

Rai echoes: "He has always

had immense potential, but potential alone cannot take you to the top. It's very common for a kid who has come from a position of privilege to lack the determination needed to shine. But that has never been a problem with Aaryavir."

His temperament has been tested outside age-group

The most important thing is that he does not have the attitude of a star kid. There is no ego whatsoever"

YOGESH NAGAR,
DELHI UNDER-19 COACH

cricket too. Aaryavir was part of West Delhi Lions' Delhi Premier League campaign this year, but did not always make the XI.

Ready to step up

Despite having to wait for almost the entire season to get a chance, Aaryavir would never lack enthusiasm, observed the team's mentor Uday Gupte.

"Ideally, Aaryavir should have got more chances, but we had experienced openers, so

opportunities were limited. That, though, didn't deter him from giving his best day in and day out in training," Gupte tells *The Indian Express*.

Gupte, a veteran of Delhi cricket who watched Virender Sehwag as a teenager, sees echoes beyond technique.

"I had seen Viru when he was 17, and now I have seen Aaryavir at 17. The mentality is similar. Like his father, Aaryavir likes to take down the bowler from the first ball. In only his first game this season, he hit two fours in his first five balls."

Aaryavir scored 22 off 14 in that DPL fixture. Gupte remembers his shots, but more than that, he remembers the conversation in the build-up to the game. "It was a must-win game for us. We lost three on the bounce. I told him before the game that he would be getting his chance. 'Are you ready?' I asked. He is just a kid.

But he replied: 'Sir, bas ek baar chance deke dekho ki main kya karta hu (just give me one chance and see what I do).'"

Sources have informed *The Indian Express* that the aggressive brand of batting is among the reasons why Aaryavir has been selected in the India U-19 team. With neither Vaibhav Sooryavanshi or Ayush Mhatre set to feature at the 2028 ICC U-19 World Cup, the selectors are looking at openers who can score quickly.

Not all facets, however, have been explored. "Not many know this, but he is a handy leg-spinner too. He has got a great googly. I have told him that if he hones his bowling skills, in addition to the technically astute batter that he is, he will go to the very top," says Gupte. The Indian cricket fans would hope for the same.

(With inputs from Venkata Krishna B)

After Brazil clash, India to face Uruguay on October 6

Express News Service
New Delhi, August 27

WITH MATCHES against Brazil and Panama confirmed, India will face another Latin American giant in 2-time FIFA World Cup winners Uruguay in Kolkata. The match which will be held in the Salt Lake Stadium on October 6, will take place just 3 days after India's historic fixture vs Brazil in the same venue on October 3.

"The Indian men's national team will welcome another heavyweight of world football to Kolkata, with two-time FIFA World Cup champions Uruguay set to face India in an international friendly match at the Vivekananda Yuba Bharati Kirangan on October 6, 2026," the All India Football Federation said on Thursday.

Uruguay, who are currently ranked 20th in the world, had a disappointing World Cup this year, failing to cross the group stages. They are currently coached by the legendary Diego Forlán who played for Mumbai City FC in 2016. He replaced Marcelo Bielsa who left the team after Uruguay's disappointing World Cup campaign.

This match was the latest fixture to be added to AIFF's calendar after India withdrew from the inaugural FIFA ASEAN Cup in order to prioritise their high-profile friendly against Brazil, thus avoiding a scheduling clash that had made their participation in both competitions untenable.

Meanwhile, Sree Kankeerava Stadium in Bengaluru has been chosen as the venue for the Indian senior men's team's international friendly against Panama on September 26, the AIFF said.

The fixture will mark the Blue Tigers' first appearance in Bengaluru since their SAFF Championship 2023 campaign, when India lifted the title on home soil after defeating Kuwait in the final at the same venue.

HOCKEY WORLD CUP

India show signs of life under Marijne with fifth-place finish

Beat Germany 3-1 to record best-ever finish at World Cup since 1974; dogged fights against top teams point to bright future for the women's team

Prithish Raj
New Delhi, August 27

NAVNEET KAUR dodged past two German defenders, wrong footed goalkeeper Finja Starck, and dinked the ball over towards the goal to score the third and decisive goal in the fifth-sixth classification match of the women's World Cup in Amstelveen on Thursday.

India defeated Germany 3-1 to finish fifth and register the best-ever finish after the inaugural 1974 World Cup where the team had finished fourth.

"We would have liked to play the semi-final but it is what it is. This fifth place finish gives us more confidence going into the Asian Games," player of the match Neha said after the game.

She is right about playing the semi-final. Ranked ninth in the world, the Indian women's team pushed above their weight holding Olympic silver medallist China, England, and Australia to draws and losing 0-2 to Netherlands creating a realistic chance to have a shot at the podium.

However, the otherwise flawless finishing in the second half against Germany, was missing against the likes of the Netherlands, Australia, and England.

"I know things could have been different. Today, we were attacking but not getting anything in the first half. Then, we started going more aggressive in the second half and it resulted in goals," Neha added.

The match had a storyline of its own as Sjoerd Marijne's team took on the team coached by India's former coach and Marijne's assistant during Tokyo Olympics, Janneke Schopmann.

While Germany had more shots and circle entries to show for, the Indian midfield controlled possession better which allowed the transition from defence to offence on multiple occasions.

The Indian team was playing on counter from the first game when Baljeet Kaur and Sakshi Rana combined on the right flank in the fifth minute. However, the German defence denied Indian skipper Salima Tete any chance to reach the ball.

Lalremisiami created a great chance in the 13th minute when she found Navneet in the German circle but put too much weight on the pass as Navneet failed to reach it. In the 15th minute, India lost the video review trying to overturn a penalty corner decision in favour of the Germans which was thwarted away by Bichu Devi.

In the second quarter, the Indian team tested Starck multiple times with the German goalkeeper making three consecutive saves to keep it 0-0 at the half-time. While India attacked more and registered four shots, it was not shown on the scoreboard.

Navneet shines

After the half-time, the Indian team not only amped up their attacks but also transitioned smoothly from defence



Navneet Kaur scored a brace while Ishika added a third in India's 3-1 win. **H1**

• Number Plate

52

India's fifth-place finish at the World Cup is the best performance in 52 years. At the 1974 edition, the team finished fourth, which remains their best-ever show at the mega event.

to attack. The first goal came in the 43rd minute when a calculated pass from Neha cut through the German defence and found Ishika whose determined run ended in 1-0 as she kept her composure to finish past Starck.

India doubled the advantage one minute later as ever-brilliant Navneet scored a thundering hit from penalty corner variation to make it 2-0.

Later, Navneet turned a poacher in the 47th minute after Salima found her on the baseline and the experienced Indian forward produced one

of the most beautiful goals of the current World Cup.

One would think that had this finishing came against Australia or England, India could have been in position of podium. But as they say, hindsight in sport is nothing but wishful thinking.

After India took 3-0 lead, the German team attacked more aggressively and desperately in order to salvage something from the match. However, as good the Indian attack was, the defence also gave a testament to the skillset. India's defence handled ten circle entries of the German team and let inside just one goal in the 59th minute with Lynn Krings getting the consolation goal.

Positive show overall

Finishing just one place outside of World's top four is not something Indian fans had thought about the women's team. It was expected from the men's team but they faltered big time in both stages with a chance to finish seventh tomorrow

against 2018 World Champions Belgium.

Coach Marijne, who seems to have become the lucky charm for the women's team, will have many positives to look forward to as the Asian Games close on. A gold medal at the Asian Games will give India direct Olympic qualification which the team missed in the 2024 edition. "Yes, the Asian Games is important for us and we will carry the confidence from this tournament," said Neha. India finished the tournament with two wins, three draws, and one defeat with the defeat coming against defending champions and host Netherlands.

If anything, the World Cup finish points at the potential of the Indian women's team where they can challenge reigning Asian Games champion China for a spot at the Olympics in Aichi Nagoya. **PLAYING TONIGHT: India vs Belgium (M), 9.45pm, Live on Star Sports Network & JioHotstar**

UEFA prepares criminal complaint against FIFA

Associated Press
Monaco, August 27

UEFA IS preparing a criminal complaint against FIFA President Gianni Infantino in Swiss courts for possible financial mismanagement over his failed plan to sell future World Cup profits to private investors.

UEFA said Thursday it filed documents in a Manhattan court requesting discovery of potential evidence from the New York investment fund, Thrive Capital Management, founded by Joshua Kushner.

UEFA also filed a request in a southern Florida district for authorization of discovery "in a foreign proceeding" against FIFA itself, which has offices in the Miami suburb of Coral Gables. Thrive and Kushner were to be the anchor investors intending to pay FIFA \$4.2 billion for a 20% stake in a subsidiary that would run the soccer body's commercial events, including the World Cup.

"UEFA and its counsel are contemplating a Swiss criminal proceeding against Infantino and possibly other FIFA officials for criminal mismanagement under Article 158 of the Swiss Criminal Code," UEFA's lawyers state in a 56-page document. The document suggests the \$4.2 billion figure could be a "fraudulently off-market price promoted by Infantino for his own benefit."

UEFA first threatened to take legal action on Aug. 3 when it warned FIFA against destroying or hiding any "relevant materials". "Infantino claimed that the plan would unleash the commercial potential and opportunity that FIFA has," UEFA lawyers told the courts. "In truth, it was a vehicle for Infantino and that small circle to acquire a permanent stake in and otherwise profit from FIFA's most valuable assets to the detriment of FIFA, its members, and other parties within the football family."

Praggnanandhaa fights for 95 moves but Caruana holds firm in GCT final marathon

Mayank Chaudhary
New Delhi, August 27

FOR FIVE and a half hours and 95 gruelling moves, R Praggnanandhaa threw everything he had at Fabiano Caruana. There were moments when the Indian seemed poised to strike back, when the game tilted in his favour. But in the end, the American held firm, forcing Praggnanandhaa to walk away with only a draw, a result that leaves him with a six-point deficit heading into the final day of the Grand Chess Tour Finals.

With two Rapid and four Blitz games remaining on the final day, Caruana now leads the match 9-3.

After conceding a 6-0 lead in the first Classical game, Praggnanandhaa needed to respond. It wasn't quite a must-win situation, but heading into the shorter time controls with a six-point gap is far from ideal.

Determined to fight back,

Praggnanandhaa, playing White, came prepared with a sharp line in the Italian Game, hoping to land a counterpunch. Caruana responded with the Polerio Variation, offering a pawn sacrifice to gain a lead in development and open lines for his pieces.

After following the standard line, Caruana deviated with a second pawn sacrifice, a move that was neither necessary nor objectively good.

The engines slowly shifted in Praggnanandhaa's favour by the 14th move. By then, both players were out of their opening preparation. Caruana spent nearly an hour on just six moves in this phase, though Praggnanandhaa held no significant clock advantage either.

Praggnanandhaa's response after gaining a two-pawn edge wasn't his best. He avoided trading his light-squared bishop, letting Caruana manoeuvre his own



Pragg trails Caruana 9-3, with 2 Rapid and 4 Blitz games left. **FILE**

bishop and win back a pawn, almost neutralising the position. The Indian chose to preserve his bishop pair at the cost of his second pawn.

He then went for a queen exchange, giving up his remaining pawn advantage. The game drifted into an endgame where White had a rook and bishop pair against Black's rook, bishop and knight. Caruana forced a trade of his knight for Praggnanandhaa's dark-squared bishop, entering

an opposite-coloured bishop endgame, but at the cost of a third pawn. Praggnanandhaa now had something worth fighting for, with an extra pawn.

The slow grind suddenly turned sharp as both players raced to reach time control. Praggnanandhaa traded off one pair of rooks and kept the position tense. Soon, there was more than just hope for the Indian, as Caruana began to lose his grip.

Praggnanandhaa deflected Black's rook while his a-pawn started running down the flank. Then the American won the pawn back, a costly mistake that left Praggnanandhaa with an objectively winning position. But converting a winning position in a complex endgame is often the hardest thing in chess. Praggnanandhaa's hopes faded quickly when he let Caruana's king come to the defence, as the American gave up two more pawns to shut the game down.

Leaping over PCOD challenges, Ancy becomes India's best

Nihal Koshie
New Delhi, August 27

PLAIN RICE was replaced by vegetables and meat, while biryani and maida-based Malabar parotta were junked by Ancy Sojan, the long jumper who broke Anju Bobby George's 22-year-old national record in June.

Before jumping 6.88 metres at the Inter-State Championships to better Anju's 6.83m, Ancy needed to manage weight gain caused by Polycystic Ovarian Disease (PCOD), diagnosed only last year.

Last week, after winning gold at the World Athletics Continental Tour Silver in Bhubaneswar, with a best jump of 6.71 metres, Ancy spoke about her struggle with PCOD.

"Now, I am 55 kilograms, but at the start of last year I was 63kg. My body fat percentage was 26 last year. I checked my fat percentage before coming to Bhubaneswar, it is just 13 now," Ancy told *The Indian Express*.

Irregular periods led to weight gain and an uncontrollable craving for food, said the 25-year-old, who is bound for the Asian Games. Ancy got her first period in her late teens. "Initially, if I didn't get my period for one month, I will get it in the next month. At that time, I was very lean. But in 2025, it started to get worse. I started eating a larger quantity of food. Last year, I trained for three months, and all I lost was just a percent of fat. My coach said, 'earlier, two weeks of training were enough for you to get lean.' I had to do something."

She suspected these were symptoms of PCOD but never got herself tested, until things got out of control last year and she had to address it.

"I started missing my period for a second month too. I was gaining too much weight. I started getting joint pain and mood swings, and I had low energy. I couldn't get a good output in training last year. I knew this was a symptom of PCOD. My nutritionist told me to consult a doctor," Ancy said.

The doctor's diagnosis was PCOD-related hormone imbalance. Ancy manages a tricky balance even today. A side effect of the medicine she takes when she misses her period is weight gain. "If I start the medicine, that also results in weight gain. But once I get my period, the weight goes down. Before the Asian Games, I need to have the medication and get my period, so I can lose weight," Ancy said.

Giving up comfort food is a challenge for Ancy, but she's willing to make the sacrifice.

"I am eating salads, meat, fish, and one roti. The doctor told me, you are not a long-distance runner, so you don't need too many carbs. If you want to have rice, eat only brown rice. Even if I order food, I stick to a Subway sandwich," said Ancy, who hails from Nattika in Thrissur, Kerala.

The change in diet, the medication, and learning to live with PCOD helped Ancy improve.

At the Continental Tour Silver in Bhubaneswar, five of Ancy's legal jumps were over 6.50 metres. When she broke



Ancy Sojan jumped 6.88m at Inter-State Championships. **AFI**

Initially, if I didn't get my period for one month, I will get it in the next month. At that time, I was very lean. But in 2025, it started to get worse. I started eating a larger quantity of food. Last year, I trained for 3 months, and all I lost was just a percent of fat."

ANCY SOJAN,
ON HER STRUGGLE WITH PCOD

Anju's national record at the Inter-State Championships in June, her series of jumps read: 6.73m, foul, 6.67m, 6.72m, 6.88m and 6.69m. "Before, in India, 6.71 metres (Silver Tour) was a huge jump. Now it is average for me. 6.88 metres was a statement. From 2022 onwards, I started thinking of a 7-metre jump," Ancy said.

Focus on speed

Ancy's coach at the Jio Institute in Navi Mumbai, Anoop Joseph, said they began training for the 2026 season in September. "This year, the focus was on speed on the runway. Her strength has improved. Her clean lift is now 82kg plus. Previously, it was 75kg. She has a good technique, so that helps," Joseph said.

Speed comes naturally to her: 11.82 seconds, her best time in the 100 metres, from 2021, when she was an active sprinter.

The challenge for Ancy is to hold her peak form until the Asian Games. She broke the national record in June; the Games begin September 19. "She has to hold her peak. 6.88 metres is close to her maximum peak this season. So, we have not changed a single exercise. We don't want to add any new exercises. I know it is very boring for an athlete, but she understands. She has the potential to jump seven metres," Joseph said.

When she isn't chasing the seven-metre goal, Ancy relaxes by sketching. She started with Avengers characters printed on bags from the delivery app Blinkit, and has since graduated to a full sketchbook. "I have a second Instagram page, mis.picasso, where I post randomly. I have completed four sketchbooks. When my boyfriend saw I was busy colouring, he called me 'hey Miss Picasso.' So I went with that name for Instagram."

PREMIER LEAGUE

At 41m pounds, Brentford's Sangare becomes the bargain buy of transfer season

Sandip G
New Delhi, August 27

BEFORE MAMADOU Sangare had to convince the world of his talents, he had to conquer the streets. Growing up in the Malian town of Bamako, the teenager had to beat men twice his age to get noticed in the streets. "It was not 11 vs 11. There were times there were more than eleven players in a side, in grounds half the size of a normal football ground," the breakout star of Gameweek One in English Premier League told FC Lens website last year.

He shocked some of the elderly players with his courage and resistance. One of them handed him a pamphlet of Yeelen Olympique, one of the most prestigious academies in the nation, conducting a selection trials. He barely wasted time to impress the selectors.

He arrived in the stadium with a pair of battered boots. He left with a new pair of boots and a twinkle in the eye of the coaches.

His first step to a long journey that involved transits in Salzburg, Liefering, Graz, Warendorf, Hartberg, Vienna and Paris, to the West London suburb of Brentford thus began. The first impressions with the Bees, in a 3-0 evisceration of Tottenham Hotspur, with the 185 million pounds, midfield heart of Sandro Tonali and Matheus Fernandes, was so striking that Brentford looks like another stopover in his vault to grander stages of Europe.

It took him just six minutes to show that at 41 million pounds, he could be the bargain of the season where both Chelsea and Manchester City broke British transfer records to

purchase midfield reinforcements. He strung a supreme line-splitting pass for Keane Lewis-Potter to slap a lethal cross into the box. Six minutes later, he and Dango Outtara tangoed in a thrilling one-two that produced the opening goal. The sequence summed up his virtues.

He gathered the ball in the inside right channel near the half-line, strolled upfield, passed to Outtara with outside of his left foot, cut infield, burst past a pair of inattentive Spurs defenders and sewed a precise cutback to Lewis Potter. The confidence and energy grew. At the stroke of half-time, he produced a gorgeous back-heel after a swift pirouette to set-up Outtara, who was not quite in his wavelength. He apologised and later paid compliments to the new midfield bulwark. "He is tal-



Mamadou Sangare joined Brentford from French club Lens. **AP**

ented, confident and intelligent," he said. Lewis-Potter chimed in: "He is such a humble guy, hard-working, but he is absolutely unbelievable and a joy to play with every single day and all credit to him. He's someone who I can link with as well and try to build a relationship with him."

The blend of qualities is rare — rather a sui generis. His pri-

mary profile is to win the ball, which he performs with his strapping physicality and astute positioning. Midway through the first half, he redirected a Spurs counterattack by merely craning his left leg and intercepting the ball. He bullies his midfield counterparts with his raw strength and puts them under enormous pressure to concede the ball.

He is a trickster when he wants to, sometimes feinting and dribbling, wriggling himself out of tight spaces

A marauding war machine, he has considerable elasticity too. He is a trickster when he wants to, sometimes feinting and dribbling, wriggling himself out of tight spaces with cunning. He has the qualities of a classic box-to-box midfielder with a vast repertoire of passes and vision, as well as a modern No.6 with speed and strength. "I was trained as an attacking midfielder, but I feel really comfortable in the double pivot too," he told FC Lens website.

"I'm a versatile player. I've had technical ability since I was

very young. I was lacking in physicality when I first arrived in Austria, so I worked a lot on that aspect during my various loan spells. My style is really based on playing forward. It comes naturally to me. Finishing is something I'm really working on," he added. He filed a thunderous half-volley that the Spurs' goalkeeper Antonin Kinsky repelled only upto Michael Kayode to put Brentford 3-0 up. Goals would fly off his boots soon, too. His coach for the national team Tom Saintfiet attests: "His multifunctional qualities are his strengths."

How he slipped through the radar of bigger clubs with a wider network of scouts is still a mystery, especially at a time when elite midfielders are the most prized asset in Europe, especially when he was pivotal to FC Lens finishing as runners-up last season. Perhaps, the

scouts overanalysed the nomadic nature of his club careers. He spent his Salzburg stint with loan spells at four different clubs. He impressed everywhere, but nowhere did he find a permanent home. Or perhaps the disciplinary record was a blot.

With Rapid Vienna, who he guided to Europa Conference League triumph in 2024, he picked up 16 yellow cards and two reds in 44 appearances across all competitions. "Sometimes I lose possession and lack concentration; those are things I need to work on," he gave a brutal self-assessment.

One show might not make a summer. But the virtues shine in Sangare to become the next prized midfielder in the league. The boy who conquered the streets of men is ready to rule the most competitive league in the world.